

Free Digital Edition

SWEATER

Literary Fiction

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CHAPTER 1

March

Mongolian Soy Sauce

Tuesday, 1st March (Independence Movement Day)

The alarm went off. I sprang out of bed. I yanked the curtains open and looked outside. The sky was packed with fat black clouds but thank God it wasn't raining. The forecast had promised a proper downpour from dawn. My stomach was in knots. Today is the day our family leaves the Bamseom flat and moves into a detached house in Gugil-dong. We'd been waiting so long we'd practically lost our voices.

Our cramped ancient Bamseom block is older than my dad. I've lived there thirteen years and eleven months. Mum and Dad have lived there a year longer than me. But I was also in Mum's belly. So if we're being fair we should add another nine months.

The building is long and wide rather than tall. And the ground floor is just one long row of shops. In summer if you opened the balcony sliding doors cooking smells would drift up in ribbons and sometimes you'd hear drunk people swearing. Because it's a corridor-style block the lift was always rammed. The hallway was miserable to get through because of bicycles, pushchairs, flowerpots and also bin bags that had been put out to throw away later. Dad used to grumble that he couldn't understand why people who'd lived long enough to learn a thing or two still chose to live like that.

Inside the lift there were notices stuck everywhere. One said not to flick cigarette butts in the corridor because they could burn someone walking past or leave marks on cars.

Another said if you grind up food waste and pour it down the sink or flush it the pipes clog so you have to use special bags. Another warned people about dogs barking. Warnings. Practically every day. But that was nothing.

What pushed our family out of the place I was born in was the upstairs noise that started last summer. Every night without exception. Thud. Thud. Thud. And worse than the noise were the vibrations. More unbearable. Sometimes the living-room window shook because of it. Brrr. Thud. Thud. Thud. Dad said someone was walking by stamping their heels. That was what made the thudding and the shaking.

A week after it began the grandad from the flat below rang our bell. He thought we were the culprits. He only left after he'd heard it too. Right there in our living room. Thud. Thud. Thud. That night he rang more than ten doors trying to find the source and failed. The neighbours started suspecting each other. Even when we passed in the lift or corridor we stopped saying hello. As sleepless nights piled up Mum and Dad had to decide. We decided to move.

At first we weren't planning to move into a detached house. There isn't a single one in Bamseom. And if we left Bamseom for a house I'd probably have to change schools. I didn't want to. Not even a tiny bit. So we looked for a top-floor flat instead. People said top floors were too hot in summer and too cold in winter. That didn't appeal either but we had no better plan. Except after months of waiting we couldn't find a top-floor place the right size for the three of us. Dad rang every estate agent in Bamseom every weekend. The answer was always the same. 'Wait.'

Then one day the grandad downstairs moved out and a young couple moved in. They didn't have a child but they did have a dog the size of a calf. And once that dog started barking it didn't stop. When the couple left for work in the morning it barked all day as if it had a thorn lodged in its paw. Complaints exploded. The building management got involved.

The young couple didn't shift an inch. Residents started shouting at each other. The police came more than once. Still nothing changed.

Dad pleaded with Mum. 'Anywhere just let's move now.' He didn't care about the top floor anymore. He wanted to leave even tomorrow. He looked genuinely desperate. Mum calmed him down gently, saying they had to think rationally. 'If we give up on the top floor and move and the flat above has King Kong we're finished,' Mum said. Even if we avoided King Kong by luck there was no guarantee there wouldn't be another calf-sized dog downstairs next door or in the building opposite or behind. Dad looked crushed and said nothing. When Mum concluded it had become a world where you couldn't avoid either upstairs noise or barking, Dad's eyes almost filled up. And then Mum said to me. 'Byeok what if we move into a detached house?'

Dad shot to his feet and said we should go view houses right away. Before I could even answer.

We thought living in a house would solve everything. But after visiting houses every weekend we gradually realised reality was different.

- Pros of a detached house -

1. Free from upstairs noise. Neighbours can still make noise but at least you don't get the thud-thud-thud vibrations.
2. There's a yard.
3. There are trees in the flowerbed.
4. You get your own roof terrace.

- Cons of a detached house -

1. No security guard like in a block of flats. The place is less secure.

2. Even in a house it's hard to escape dogs barking.
3. Bad insulation. Hotter in summer and colder in winter than a flat.
4. Nobody to take deliveries.

We decided to buy a detached house. But so I wouldn't have to change schools we searched in Gugil-dong. In the same school catchment as Bamseom. After two months we finally found a two-storey house built of blue bricks that we liked. In a flowerbed the size of a clump of dung there was a persimmon tree and two junipers. In one corner of the yard about the size of a palm there was a little tap installed. And strangely that was what Mum liked most. That tiny water point. The house had been renovated two years earlier so it was bright and clean. Ground floor. Living room and kitchen. Upstairs. My parents' bedroom and mine. There was a bathroom downstairs and another upstairs. Compared to our old cramped and absurdly expensive Bamseom flat it was practically paradise. The only regret was that during the renovation they'd 'forgotten' the basement. One day if we cleaned it properly it could become a cosy little den.

On the way back after signing, Dad said we were now 'paying rent to the bank'. I asked whether that made us house-poor. Mum burst out laughing. No, not to that extent. So don't worry. And she pulled me into a hug. Dad ruffled my hair.

Outside it looked like rain could start any second. I prayed it wouldn't rain at least until the move was finished. The movers arrived twenty minutes early. After one quick look round the flat one of them let out a long sigh. 'First time I've seen this much stuff in an eighteen-pyeong place.' That was because we hadn't moved once in fifteen years but mostly because Dad owned over a thousand books. Dad handed a white envelope to the bearded man who looked like the boss. 'For lunch at least.' The boss muttered 'Oh you shouldn't have...' And then shouted 'Right. Let's start packing!'

The moment they began, we had to get out of our tiny flat. Dad told one of the movers not to throw out the white bin bag in the small room. It wasn't rubbish. It was a globe that had already been wrapped and they needed to take it. Mum said it was dangerous. It could be lost. It would be better to put it into another bag or a box. But Dad insisted 'Bin bags are strong. They're perfect.' When Dad doesn't listen to Mum something bad always happens. I was already afraid of what would happen this time.

While Mum and Dad went to sort things out at the estate agent's I stayed downstairs and watched the loading. Boxes kept coming down the furniture lift without stopping. It was incredible. How could so much come out of such a small flat? When they came back, packing was nearly done. We took one last look around the empty flat. Only then did it properly hit me. We were leaving the place we'd lived for fifteen years. In the pile of rubbish stacked in the kitchen Mum found Dad's white bin bag. Without a word she handed him the white bag with the globe inside. Dad started to say, 'But... I told them not to throw it away I said—' And his sentence died. Mum didn't lecture him about why he'd put a globe in a bin bag. Oddly, she's scarier when she says nothing.

The bearded boss left first, saying they'd get to the Gugil-dong house before two after lunch. While we ate at a restaurant on the ground floor of our building a huge downpour came down. But thankfully the moment we finished eating and stepped outside the rain stopped dead. As if it had never existed.

All afternoon, the movers put things away without resting. They were so strong and so fast that in a few hours everything was done. Mum said whatever we didn't need immediately could stay in boxes and go straight to the basement. Dad agreed. We'd take our time and unpack bit by bit.

We ate dinner at home. Dad suggested going out because he worried Mum might be tired. But Mum said going out was even more tiring and made something simple. I was too

exhausted to want to go anywhere. Mum and Dad have to work tomorrow. I suppose there isn't a rule that gives you a day off just because you moved house on a public holiday. The only comforting thing is that tomorrow isn't Monday but Wednesday. In three days it'll already be the weekend and Mum and Dad can rest.

Tomorrow I'm starting Year 9. What sort of adventure is waiting for me this year? I lay down and closed my eyes. And outside I could hear a dog barking. Woof. Woof. Woof.

Wednesday, 2nd March

First day back. I'm Year 9, Class 3, Number 17 at Bamseom Secondary School. Ppagasari has become the form tutor for Class 4. Apparently the teacher who was supposed to take Class 4 suddenly asked for leave. The Class 4 kids all look like condemned men. One of them even says he's going to beg his mum to let him change schools. Ppagasari, who teaches social studies, is as skinny as dried pollock. And to this day nobody in our school has ever seen him smile.

Our form tutor is Mr Kim Yun-sik, the Korean teacher. I'm sitting next to a new kid. Go Dong-wan. He used to live in Yongsan and moved to Bamseom not long ago. Dong-wan is taller than me by a full handspan. His skin is slightly darker so he gives off a sort of foreign vibe.

The best news of the day. Kim Hee-jeong is in our class. Hee-jeong is the prettiest girl in school. No. The prettiest in Bamseom. Maybe even the prettiest in the whole country. Who knows.

I'm reading *The Moon and Sixpence* by Somerset Maugham, borrowed from Dad's shelf.

Thursday, 3rd March

An incredible revelation! My desk mate Dong-wan's mother is Mongolian. His dad met her when he was working in Mongolia and they fell in love. Dong-wan was born in Mongolia and lived there until he was three. Every summer holiday he spends about two weeks there with his mum.

I asked him how to say 'hello' in Mongolian. He taught me. 'Sain baina uu.' Sleeping one night in a huge Mongolian tent. What would that feel like?

At cram school the teacher screamed because my maths homework was a disaster. He said if I ever handed in something that sloppy again he'd ring my mother. I want to live in a world without maths.

The Moon and Sixpence is the story of an irresponsible man. I don't understand why Dad has that kind of book on his shelf.

Friday, 4th March

The rumour is out. Dong-wan's mum is Mongolian. The first to pounce is Jong-gu the annoying delinquent. He provoked Dong-wan. 'Oi! Go Dong-wan—heard you're multicultural, yeah? Where are you from? Southeast Asia?'

Before Dong-wan could answer Cheol-jin said 'No apparently he's from Mongolia.' And Jong-gu said 'Mongolia? Right then from today you're Mongolian soy sauce.'

Jong-gu's clique started calling him Mongolian soy sauce. And other kids began whispering too. 'He's multicultural.' But Yeong-sik in our class has a Japanese mum and nobody makes fun of him. If Dong-wan's mum had been Japanese... would it have changed anything?

Saturday, 5th March

I'm annoyed at Dad because of the telly. I was watching Animal Kingdom and Dad changed the channel saying he had to watch Flash Girl. A man Dad's age enjoying watching idols dance and sing. I can't understand it. I want a television of my own. I'd buy a lottery ticket but I'm too young. When exactly do you become an adult?

To escape Flash Girl noise I went to my room and read a Chekhov short story. It was called 'Fear'. A bloke cheats with his friend's wife. There was a character named 'the Forty Martyrs'. I don't know why anyone would be called that. Russian novels are icy. Probably because it's cold there. I should try a different Russian author.

Dad was smoking in the yard and Mum told him off again. She said to get the 'good health' discount on our insurance he had to quit. And asked how long he planned to keep smoking. She said if he stopped now it would save several million won in premiums. Dad laughed 'Alright alright.' And the second Mum went inside he smoked another one. Dad is a snake. A proper one. Then he said to me, 'Son, never learn to smoke. It's really hard to quit.' And he inhaled like his life depended on it.

He says he started in the army with an '88' cigarette issued as a ration. Before that he didn't smoke. He promised that if I came first in the class he'd quit. So I told him actually it was better if he didn't. First? Not tenth. First. Impossible.

Today I learnt there are things you shouldn't even say as a joke.

Sunday, 6th March

I went to Grandad's early. He's a man who believes it's a hundred times better to do what you like than to get good grades. With him I feel calm. We watched a western on TV. The Brave.

It's about a girl who hunts down the bandits who killed her father to take revenge. A freckled girl with two long braids on either side. She looks like a fierce version of *Anne of Green Gables*.

Grandad told me the original title was *True Grit*. And in an older film John Wayne played the sheriff. I asked what 'true grit' meant. He said 'real courage.' Then he added 'Brave is courage and grit is courage too but not the same. Grit is the stubborn kind. The kind that doesn't give up. Simple 'bravery' is brave.' In the film that freckled Anne-with-a-revolver really showed that 'true grit'. If I were her could I go after my father's killer? I hope it never happens.

After lunch Grandma asked 'Byeok what do you want to be later?' I said 'I don't know yet.' Grandad said it was good even if not right away to find something I wanted to do. To have a goal. And not neglect school too much either.

At night in bed I tried thinking about what I want to do, but nothing came. When I closed my eyes I could still see that red-haired Anne with the gun.

Monday, 7th March

At lunch the delinquent Jong-gu mocked Dong-wan again calling him Mongolian soy sauce. He spotted dumplings on the side and said 'Oi give me some Mongolian soy sauce to dip my dumplings.' Jong-gu's clique doubled over laughing. And even other kids laughed with them. I couldn't stand it. I shouted for them to stop. Jong-gu lunged at me. 'Oi—you donkey-head mind your own business!' Without Dong-wan separating us it would've turned into a fight. Thanks to Jong-gu's clique from today my nickname is 'donkey-head'.

After school Dong-wan and I were walking home and Jong-gu's clique followed us to the gate chanting Mongolian soy sauce and 'donkey-head'. Because Dong-wan—big and solid—stays indifferent it feels like they bully him even more.

Last night I dreamed I was galloping through the West on a huge horse. Hee-jeong was riding out to avenge her father and I became a just sheriff chasing bandits. While chasing them I got lost somewhere in Texas and woke up.

Today I skipped maths cram school. I don't want to go.

Tuesday, 8th March

Today again I didn't go to maths tutoring. The teacher finally rang Mum and everything was discovered. Mum called Aunt Jeong-su who lives in Bamseom. Aunt Jeong-su is the most famous private maths tutor in the neighbourhood. She said forcing a child with no interest in studying into an academy was a waste of money. And it would be better to stop sending me. When Mum asked how I was supposed to get into university if I wasn't good at maths Aunt Jeong-su said you could just not aim for a 'good' university. Mum was even more offended and hung up.

I'm reading Tolstoy's *What Men Live By*.

Wednesday, 9th March

Hee-jeong has become vice class rep. I have no role. Not exactly a shock.

In PE we played football. Because I didn't fancy running I put myself in goal. Kicking a ball around in every direction doesn't interest me at all. Standing there like a sack of grain I let in two stupid goals and got subbed off. Even two goals down our team won thanks to Dong-wan. He runs fast and shoots well. They went off to celebrate with tteokbokki but Dong-wan and I didn't go.

Mum told me I didn't have to go to maths tutoring anymore. But instead an 'exceptional measure' would be taken soon. An exceptional measure? I might have been better off just going properly.

At night when I lie down I think about Hee-jeong. The way she ran—quick and light—during PE keeps replaying. I can't sleep.

Thursday, 10th March

What Men Live By is a profound book. I was really moved by “The Two Old Men”. Helping people who suffer is noble. Spending all your pilgrimage money helping others. Tolstoy gives me something close to a religious revelation.

This week I haven't seen Dad even once. He comes home late every day. I've decided that when I grow up I won't be a programmer like him.

After school I went to Aunt Jeong-su's. Mum's 'exceptional measure' was this. Private maths tutoring at Aunt Jeong-su's every Saturday for one hour twenty. I'm dead. Aunt Jeong-su is even scarier than Ppagasari. Everyone knows her husband as a henpecked husband. At this level he's basically a national representative.

Friday, 11th March

I told Dad that Jong-gu's clique was picking on Dong-wan for no reason. Calling him Mongolian soy sauce. And because I was close to him they were calling me 'donkey-head' too. Dad burst out laughing. 'What a lovely nickname! Donkey-head. Suits you perfectly—you're stubborn!'

When I yelled 'Dad!' he added still smiling. 'Alright sorry. Son if someone hates you for no reason give them a good reason to hate you. One is enough.'

Mum who'd heard said dryly. 'What a wonderful education...'

Dad put on a serious face and said you had to get along with your friends.

Today I discovered something Dad Uncle and my form tutor have in common. All three are short on male hormones.

Saturday, 12th March

I was supposed to arrive at Aunt Jeong-su's at 8:55. I arrived at 9:00 exactly. Five minutes late ten minutes of scolding. Aunt Jeong-su always schedules appointments in five-minute blocks. She thinks it creates pressure and makes people respect the time. I sent Uncle two distress signals but he just shrugged and vanished into the bedroom.

Aunt Jeong-su gave me an hour of maths problems then went out to the living room. I sweated alone in the study. There were two salt-water problems. If I could just dip a finger and taste it I could solve the concentration. Just looking at them gives me chills. Thankfully no speed-and-distance problem this time.

An hour later the tiger-aunt came back. Out of twenty questions I solved five. And out of those five I copied two wrong. So really I got three. As I hung my head crushed she explained how to do maths properly.

1. Read the question to the end precisely.
2. Write your reasoning neatly.
3. Don't give up before the end.

She said maths isn't solved with your head but with your backside. Then she gave me a mountain of homework. Goodbye lost weekend.

At home Mum and Dad were arguing about splitting the housework. They bickered like children. Mum rang Aunt Jeong-su to complain. Uncle does every task Aunt Jeong-su orders perfectly. Mum should learn her method.

Sunday, 13th March

In the afternoon Grandad rang. We all had dinner at his place. On the news there was a report about the former 'comfort women'. Grandad told the story of my great-grandfather forcibly conscripted for labor by Japan. The ship he was on was sunk by an American bombing in the middle of the Pacific. He survived by a hair but was held prisoner for a while. He returned to Korea after liberation but he was so weakened he died soon after. Grandad cleared his throat and went to the toilet. His eyes were red.

Monday, 14th March

At the end of classes our form tutor asked the kids from multicultural families to stay behind. Dong-wan stood up sharply and said 'Sir I'm not a multicultural family kid. I'm just Dong-wan. Dong-wan. Please don't call me that.'

The teacher was speechless startled. Then he apologised to Dong-wan and Yeong-sik. 'Yes. Sorry. That was my mistake. I won't call you that again.'

After that the students stopped calling Dong-wan Mongolian soy sauce. Well. Except Jong-gu's lot.

Tuesday, 15th March

After school I went to Dong-wan's to play. His flat is the biggest and most luxurious in Bamseom. His living room is bigger than our entire house. His mother is unbelievably beautiful.

We ate the snack she'd prepared then played a role-playing game. I'd barely ever played and couldn't win. Because I got bored quickly Dong-wan showed me his miniature car collection. Ferrari Lamborghini Porsche. He explained each model. It didn't interest me. It was boring.

Then he showed me his dad's study. And that was paradise. Thousands of DVDs and CDs covered an entire wall up to the ceiling. A huge TV. Speakers almost as big as me. Dong-wan said I should come back when his dad was home to watch a film there. So today I just left.

Dong-wan's dad is a huge fan of a girl group called True Colors.

Wednesday, 16th March

These days I orbit Hee-jeong like a shy UFO alien hovering near humans. But she doesn't seem to notice anything. In her eyes I don't exist. I want to get closer but I have absolutely no idea how. I need real courage.

On Dad's shelf I found an old book titled *The Age of Gwancheol-dong*. I should look up where Gwancheol-dong is.

Thursday, 17th March

Jong-gu's clique mocked Dong-wan again calling him Mongolian soy sauce. I kicked my chair and shouted for them to stop and Jong-gu flinched. Without the bell we might've come to blows. Dong-wan is tall and brave and yet he takes it all without a word. Because of Jong-gu I think I've developed an anger-management disorder.

Teachers think Jong-gu is a model student because he's rich and good at school. But to me he's a bad kid. Recently he forced Cheol-uk to go eat fried chicken with them and then made him pay. Cheol-uk didn't tell his family because he was scared. Maybe justice exists only in films. Jong-gu's father is a police chief. If I ever meet him I'd like to tell him to start by installing justice at home.

Seeing Dad on weekdays has become as rare as a star in the sky. Mum comes home late too because of her job at the travel agency. Tonight we had dinner at Grandad's. I did the washing-up. Grandma said 'Our Byeok has grown up.' I want to become an adult quickly.

On the way home I bought a bag of bungeo-ppang. It hasn't even been an hour since dinner but I'm already hungry. Maybe it means I'm growing. The bungeo-ppang Hyung said it was a freebie and slipped in two extra. I think I'm going to become a regular.

Friday, 18th March

Doing the maths homework Aunt Jeong-su gives me has flattened my backside. I don't understand why we have to learn maths. Knowing how to count money should be enough.

Aunt Jeong-su rang and told me not to be late tomorrow under any circumstances. I promised I absolutely wouldn't be.

Saturday, 19th March

Ah. I want to disappear into a mouse hole. I arrived ten minutes late at Aunt Jeong-su's again. She said nothing and made me stand in the corner of the living room with my arms raised. And then. Hee-jeong walked in. Kim Hee-jeong the most beautiful girl at Bamseom Secondary School. She took maths tutoring there too. She saw me being punished pulled a tiny smile and went into the study. I wanted to crawl into an ant hole. My face burned as if it might catch fire if someone held a candle near it.

A little later Aunt Jeong-su told me to lower my arms and gave me twenty questions. This time I solved seven. And none were wrong because of bad copying. Hee-jeong only missed one out of twenty.

Aunt Jeong-su made noodles for snack. Hee-jeong ate with me. She's been taking lessons there for over a year. Uncle told me while I was eating. 'Do you know what an

honour it is to study with your aunt? Your mum begged her to accept weekend lessons. So don't ever be late again.' I answered 'Yes' while nearly choking. They say you shouldn't even bother a dog while it's eating. Hee-jeong smiled slightly tight around the edges.

Aunt Jeong-su concluded 'Go home now. Don't hang about anywhere. And you Byeok. One more late arrival and it's over. Anyone who can't respect the time doesn't need to study maths.' I ran out as if escaping. In the lift Hee-jeong said 'Your aunt's a real tigress.' 'Yes. Her childhood nickname was Tarzan.' I said 'Tarzan?' she repeated laughing.

I spent the entire afternoon on maths homework. My hair must have turned white in one go. Who dared to say life is beautiful?

Sunday, 20th March

All morning Dad has been helping Mum with housework. Mum is training him using Aunt Jeong-su's advice.

- How to manage your husband (according to Aunt Jeong-su) -

1. Don't ask vaguely. Give precise instructions. (For example. Shake the bedroom duvet twice front and back. Vacuum right under the sofa. Put the recyclables from the storage room outside.)
2. Drop without hesitation anything the husband absolutely refuses to do. (For example. Taking out food waste.)
3. Once the job is done praise him. (For example. Dolphin, puppy.)

In the evening Uncle insisted we go to a PC café. He looks like a mountain bandit but his hobbies are at primary-school level. After losing two matches in a row I had no energy

left. On the way home I asked whether he wasn't scared to live with Aunt Jeong-su. He said 'No. I run the house. Why?'

They say you can know ten fathoms under water but not one fathom inside a man's heart.

Monday, 21st March

In ethics class we debated whether nuclear energy was essential. The class rep Yeong-su said without nuclear power there'd be an electricity shortage so we just needed to manage it well. Hee-jeong argued it was better to reduce consumption and do without nuclear.

Then Jong-gu spoke up and said without nuclear plants you can't make nuclear weapons and our country should have them as soon as possible. Dong-wan replied you absolutely must not make weapons that dangerous. After that even the sleepy kids woke up to join in. The class split into pro-nuclear and anti-nuclear groups. They talked about nuclear weapons like they were toys.

I watched as a spectator arms folded leaning back in my chair. Mr Na Hee-cheol told me off and said to sit properly. My face went red as if I'd been hit by a nuclear bomb.

The teacher said nuclear power was a 'hot potato' and gave us homework. Write an opinion for or against due the following week.

I rang Grandad and asked what 'hot potato' meant. He said it was something that burns your palate if you put it in your mouth but if you don't eat it you stay hungry. It's a bit like. 'Would you rather solve a salt-water problem or a speed-and-distance problem?'

Tuesday, 22nd March

Dad couldn't make it into work. His neck and shoulders hurt so much he can't even turn his head. Mum told him to go to hospital but Dad said one day of rest would be enough. He should've listened to Mum but he dug in and didn't go.

I finished *The Age of Gwancheol-dong*. It's a book full of anecdotes about many poets and novelists. But because it's old there were lots of writers I didn't know. Shin Gyeong-rim, Cheon Sang-byeong, Kim Seong-dong, Kim Gwan-sik, Gu Ja-un. I especially liked the story where the poet Cheon Sang-byeong hides the novelist Oh Yeong-su's Pelikan fountain pen. These days it would end up in court but back then there was romance in it.

I asked Dad what he'd think if I became a writer later. He said do what I wanted but writers are poor and struggle to feed a family. I said I'd stay single even as an adult. Dad laughed and said that was an excellent choice. When Mum shot him a look he quickly added 'I'm joking.'

These days Dad looks more and more like Uncle.

Wednesday, 23rd March

Dad still couldn't go to work. He finally went to hospital early this morning and was diagnosed with a cervical disc herniation. Because he also has severe pain in his shoulder and back he has to rest completely for a while. Dad handed in a medical note and leave request at work. He's taken a month of sick leave. And yet he's as happy as a kid on summer holiday. Yes. Dad needed rest too.

Mum announced that from today we were immediately entering austerity mode. As if we hadn't already. She said my birthday present would be simple. The smartphone I'd been hoping for evaporated.

I must be the only kid in class without a smartphone. You can forget your textbooks but never your smartphone.

Thursday, 24th March

Walking along the Han River with Dong-wan we talked about our future dreams. It was mild and pleasant to walk. Dong-wan said his dream was to become the most just judge in the world. His dream is a bit long. A judge fine but 'the most just in the world'?

When Dong-wan said he wanted to be a judge his father advised him to set a more specific goal. He explained there are good judges, bad judges and corrupt judges and without a clear goal you could end up becoming one of the bad ones. That's why Dong-wan decided he would be the most just judge in the world.

That evening over dinner at Grandad's with Dad we talked again about Dong-wan's dream. Grandad said Dong-wan's father sounded like a truly admirable person. Next to him Dad joked 'Then Byeok when you grow up be the most just writer in the world.'

Grandad immediately told him off. 'Grow up. How can someone who studied philosophy be so immature...'

Friday, 25th March

Dad sat on the living-room sofa all day watching television. After his morning physiotherapy he doesn't leave the sofa. But the moment Mum's return time approaches he washes his hair brushes his teeth and even does the washing-up late like he's had a productive day.

Mum who suspects nothing worries only about his neck and shoulders. To me Dad doesn't look like he's in that much pain. In front of Mum he's a brat.

Saturday, 26th March

Thankfully I arrived ten minutes early at Aunt Jeong-su's. Because I'd also finished all the maths homework I was praised. When I asked if Hee-jeong wasn't coming today Aunt Jeong-

su said she had something on and had taken the Saturday morning lesson the week before.

‘Why? Are you interested in Hee-jeong?’ Aunt Jeong-su asked. My face went red like a tomato.

Even though it was Saturday Mum went to work. She says the travel agency is very busy at the moment. As if there have ever been quiet periods. Dad and I ate ramyeon for lunch. Now that we’re not even a double-income household anymore eating ramyeon is a bit grim. Pizza at least!

Sunday, 27th March

I told Mum and Dad I wanted a smartphone for my birthday but they acted like they hadn’t heard.

Dad lazed around on the sofa all morning then got told off by Mum again. From today all housework is Dad’s responsibility. Since Mum earns the household money Dad doesn’t really have a choice.

That evening watching a singing competition programme Dad suddenly declared that the philosophical basis of the show was ‘Darwinism’. According to him it wasn’t a system that selected the singer with the highest score. It was one that eliminated the singer with the lowest score. Exactly like Darwin’s theory of evolution. Dad summarised Darwinism in one sentence. Nature doesn’t choose. It eliminates. Sometimes Dad really does seem like he studied philosophy at university.

Monday, 28th March

After doing the dinner washing-up I asked Dad who was smoking in the yard why he’d given up philosophy to become a programmer. Without hesitation he said ‘You think people work because they like it? People work to live.’ Sometimes Dad looks sad to me.

Tuesday, 29th March

I took Charles Darwin's *The Voyage of the Beagle* from Dad's bookshelf, but Mum said it wasn't a book for me and told me to put it back. Dad defended me. 'It's fine. When I was in Year 9, I watched *The Godfather* at the cinema and understood life. There aren't children's books and adults' books. Let him read.' So Mum said 'In that case read it to the end. Don't abandon it halfway.'

I regretted it before I'd even finished the first page. I should've listened to Mum...

Wednesday, 30th March

Jong-gu's clique got severely told off by Ppagasari. At lunchtime they mocked the workers repairing the school sports ground and caused a huge commotion. From the second floor they kept throwing water down while provoking them. When the workers shouted for them to stop it calmed a bit. But then Jong-gu stuck his head out of the window and said 'If you live like that it's because you were bad at school isn't it?' One of the workers suddenly slammed his can on the ground and ran up to our classroom shouting. 'Oi you little brat—come here!' The Class 4 form tutor Ppagasari came running. Our own form tutor was in the toilet at the time. The other workers came up too. The atmosphere was terrifying.

Ppagasari apologised to the workers. Jong-gu's clique apologised reluctantly. They were all taken to the counselling room. They deserved a serious dressing-down.

Thursday, 31st March

Jong-gu's mother came to the school made a scene and left. In the staff room she screamed demanding who they thought they were to humiliate her child. Shouting at the form tutor and Ppagasari. The headteacher and deputy had to intervene to calm her down.

Jong-gu is bragging everywhere that he's going to hide Ppagasari's social studies textbook. That book is a national treasure. It's covered in notes, diagrams and red underlining everywhere. Bloated like it's been soaking in water that book is the true source of Ppagasari's income.

Jong-gu is really an idiot. If he wanted to hide it he should do it quietly. Talking about it like that means everyone will know he did it.

CHAPTER 2

April

True Grit

Friday, 1st April

Today is the most important day of the year. It's the first of April. Which means it's my birthday. I am now officially fourteen. I wish I could take two years at a time every year so I could become an adult faster.

As expected I didn't get a smartphone. Mum bought me trainers. Since the ones I wear are worn out anyway she says it's killing two birds with one stone. Dad gave me Hergé's *The Adventures of Tintin*. *The Secret of the Unicorn*, *Red Rackham's Treasure*, *Tintin in Tibet* and *Tintin in the Congo*. Dad has the nerve to call comics he bought for himself a 'present' for me. Does he think I don't notice? But since he also lives off the pocket money Mum gives him I've decided to be understanding.

Grandad and Grandma gave me the complete Sherlock Holmes. Aunt Jeong-su and Uncle. Radio silence. We'll see tomorrow.

Tonight on the radio I heard an incredible piece of music. 'April' by Deep Purple. It felt as if electricity was running through my whole body.

Saturday, 2nd April

I got a smartphone from Aunt Jeong-su and Uncle for my birthday. Unfortunately it isn't new. Uncle changed his phone and gave me his old one. He reset and cleaned it perfectly, put it back in the original box, and even wrapped it in luxury paper. Honestly when I saw the box with a ribbon I thought it was the latest model. My heart almost stopped. Luckily Aunt Jeong-su quickly told me it was second-hand. Hearing that my heart started beating normally again.

After maths at Aunt Jeong-su's I went to Dong-wan's. His dad was polishing shoes on the balcony. He had nine pairs. My dad has two and the heels are already chewed up. Dong-wan's dad said a man should polish his own shoes. Looking closely, he was just brushing off the dust and putting on some strange, clear cream. Maybe that's why they didn't look shiny at all to me. My dad's shoes are so polished you can almost see your face in them.

Dong-wan's dad put on *The Terminator*. An insane film. With the huge screen and pounding sound it felt like being at the cinema. The idea that a machine smarter and stronger than humans could rule the future didn't seem absurd at all. We already live in a time when AI beats humans at chess. And even at Go, right?

Even if one day they invent a time machine like in the film I will never use it. Because if travelling means you have to go completely naked. Past or future I'm not interested. Even if someone said 'You can take it and visit paradise' if I have to undress I will politely refuse.

When I got home Dad had Flash Girl on and had fallen asleep on the sofa. They say if AI keeps advancing even computer programs won't be written by humans anymore. AI will write them itself. If that happens just how happy would Dad be?

So as not to wake him I went upstairs quietly and read Sherlock Holmes. It's gripping. I wondered whether I'd become a detective or a writer one day.

Sunday, 3rd April

Dad and I unpacked the boxes piled up in the basement. Just opening a few boxes of books swallowed the whole morning. The old books smelled a bit musty but I don't dislike that smell.

After lunch Dad wanted to keep unpacking but Mum stopped him saying he shouldn't overdo it. So Dad said he'd just move the vinyl records to the upstairs storage room. The basement is damp and apparently vinyl gets mouldy. Mum said it'd be better to sell or throw away records we don't listen to anymore. Dad said 'Alright alright' but carried up the six boxes like sacred relics and settled them upstairs. I don't understand what's so precious about those records.

I fell asleep reading Sherlock Holmes. In the end being a detective seems more fun than being a writer.

Monday, 4th April

Dong-wan and I leafed through a science magazine in the library. The number of animals slaughtered every year for food is insane. 1.7 million camels, 24 million buffalo, 300 million cows, 400 million goats, 500 million sheep, 600 million turkeys, 1.1 billion rabbits, 1.3 billion pigs, 2.6 billion ducks and 52 billion chickens! Suddenly meat scared me.

Dong-wan and I were snickering saying people even eat camels when Hee-jeong arrived with her best friend Hye-seon and asked us to keep it down. We went quiet as if we'd swallowed honey. And blushed.

Tuesday, 5th April (Tree-Planting Day)

Dong-wan says if AI keeps advancing not only programmers but lots of jobs will disappear. In factories there'll be only robots. Nothing left for humans. So in Europe they're thinking

about taxing robots. I don't get it. What money does a robot have to pay tax with? Shouldn't you tax the owner instead?

In history class we learnt something similar. In the past slaves were made to work by taking away their freedom and in return they weren't taxed. Robots are like slaves aren't they? Why should they work 24/7 and then pay tax as well? What is it? The crime of being born a robot?

Wednesday, 6th April

I asked Grandad about the 'robot tax'. He said it isn't the robot that pays but the owner. Like ship tax. It's not the ship, it's the shipowner. Phew. What a relief. I worried for nothing.

Grandad says one day even in trials humans might not be needed. An AI judge without emotions could give the most impartial verdict. Maybe Dong-wan should rethink his dream of becoming a judge. But how could I say that? He'd be so disappointed.

I went home and reread Sherlock Holmes. To solve a case the most important thing is always securing evidence. Problem. Around me there isn't a single 'incident' worthy of being called a case.

And Dr Watson. I'm still not sure what exactly he's for.

Thursday, 7th April

From the 21st to the 23rd we're going on a school trip to Sokcho. Two nights and three days. Our form tutor says we have to prepare a 'performance' for the show. Disaster. I've inherited not a single talent from my parents. In my opinion one of humanity's worst inventions is forcing everyone to go 'from number one to last' so people can show off. Why not just let those who want to show off?

Friday, 8th April

The money units in Sherlock Holmes are too complicated. Pound crown penny shilling guinea. I understand nothing. I wish I knew what a pound was really worth a hundred years ago.

Saturday, 9th April

After finishing maths at Aunt Jeong-su's I went to Dong-wan's. His dad wasn't home so we couldn't watch a film. So after asking his mum Dong-wan came over to my place.

Seeing the books in our living room Dong-wan looked genuinely shocked. Dad buys books without even reading them. He says he already read them at university. Is that true? I don't understand why you'd buy books you've already read. At our place we even have three copies of *The Catcher in the Rye*.

I asked Dong-wan why he stayed calm even when Jong-gu mocked him. Dong-wan said that deep down Jong-gu was rather pitiful. He showed me his fist clenched as tight as he could. Huge like an adult's. He said he'd promised his mum never to hit anyone. He added that he could easily beat Jong-gu by force but simply didn't see the need.

On the way to Grandad's with Dong-wan we stopped by the stall run by the bungeoppang Hyung. He was playing lively music at his stand. When I asked what it was he said it was 'Take Five' by Dave Brubeck.

Grandad saw Dong-wan patted his head and told him to become the most just judge in the world. I told him the English money units were far too complicated. So Grandad fetched an encyclopaedia and explained it kindly.

One pound is four crowns. Four crowns are twenty shillings. And twenty shillings are two hundred and forty pence. In other words, a pound is either twenty shillings or two hundred and forty pence. A crown is five shillings, florin is two. A shilling is twelve pence

and twenty-one shillings make a guinea. And today a pound is about a hundred thousand won. So since a pound is four crowns, a crown is twenty-five thousand won. And since a crown is five shillings, a shilling is five thousand won. A florin worth two shillings is ten thousand won. Since a shilling is twelve pence, a penny is about four hundred and sixteen won. Finally since a guinea is twenty-one shillings, it's about a hundred and five thousand won today.

Today I understood why maths exists.

Sunday, 10th April

I'm anxious about this stupid performance for the school trip. Mum sings badly Dad sings badly and of course I do too. Mum dances badly Dad dances badly and so do I. No instruments. Nothing. Zero talent to show off.

I keep reading Sherlock Holmes. It's a thousand times more interesting than *The Voyage of the Beagle*. To become a detective you have to observe well. So today I trained my powers of observation all around the house. I even took photos with my smartphone 'for evidence'.

- Observation List -

1. Dad didn't wash his hair. He just got it wet quickly and lied to Mum. Mum noticed nothing.

2. The stairs from the living room (1st floor) to my room (2nd floor) have exactly seventeen steps.

3. The towels dumped in my parents' room have been lying there for three days already.

4. Behind the TV I found Dad's lost business card holder.

5. Under the kitchen mat I found Mum's lost handkerchief.

6. I saw Dad secretly hide emergency cash. He stashes it in *The Analects of Confucius*.
He gave me 10,000 won and told me to keep quiet.

In the end, it's better to be a detective who makes money than a writer who stays poor.

Monday, 11th April

Ppagasari's social studies textbook has disappeared!

Since morning Ppagasari has been running around looking for it. Too many suspects to list. He's shouted at too many people. He orders everyone around with a single finger.

'Hey you, come here.'

'Hey you, pick up the rubbish.'

'Hey you, don't run.'

'Hey you, change your shoes.'

'Hey you, bring your parents.'

And with that same finger he also picks his nose.

With Sherlock Holmes's sharp eye I searched for the book. No luck. Staring too hard made my eyes go bloodshot.

Tuesday, 12th April

Still no sign of the textbook. Ppagasari wants to search all the students' personal lockers making a huge fuss. But the headteacher is against it so for now he can't.

Wednesday, 13th April

In PE my stomach hurt. On the way to the nurse's office I passed our classroom to grab my jacket and smartphone. And then Jong-gu came in. He didn't see me. He looked around and

rummaged through Dong-wan's bag. My heart was pounding but I stayed calm. I filmed it with my smartphone. He found Dong-wan's locker key. Then from his own locker he pulled out Ppagasari's thick textbook and slipped it into Dong-wan's locker. It was so big and obvious I recognised it at once. My heart nearly burst.

After filming I sneaked up to the nurse's office. And behind me I heard. 'Byeok what are you doing here?' It was our form tutor. I thought my heart would drop onto the floor. I said it was PE and I was going to the nurse because my stomach hurt then slipped away.

Lying in the nurse's office I thought about how to punish Jong-gu. But I couldn't think for long. The medicine the nurse gave me knocked me out.

When she woke me school was already over. Since I wasn't in class at the end our form tutor came all the way to the nurse's office. The nurse said she'd 'forgotten' me because I was sleeping so deeply. As I sat up I heard the teachers talking.

'But why would Dong-wan hide Mr Kim Su-yeong's textbook?' the nurse asked.

'I don't know. Mr Kim wants to punish him. He's furious. Even if I apologise he won't listen.'

Hearing that I couldn't hold back.

'No! The one who hid Mr Kim's book. It wasn't Dong-wan. It was Jong-gu!' I shouted. My heart was racing and my hands were shaking.

'How do you know?' our form tutor asked.

'Do you have proof?' the nurse's eyes went wide.

I took a breath and explained calmly step by step. The two teachers watched the video on my phone then let out a huge sigh.

Dong-wan who had cried so much his eyes were swollen like chestnuts was cleared. I walked him home.

What a day.

Thursday, 14th April

This morning the rumour of the video swept through the school like a storm. Thanks to my courageous act Dong-wan was completely cleared. Without the video he could never have shaken off the accusation.

While the teachers were discussing Jong-gu's punishment his father arrived. His father is a police chief. Apparently he slapped Jong-gu several times the moment he saw him. Jong-gu apologised to Ppagasari and to Dong-wan. Of course under his father's eye. Jong-gu didn't return to class. He left with him. His cheeks were swollen as he crossed the corridor.

At the end of the day our form tutor said that since Jong-gu had been a 'model student' he'd be forgiven this time. If Jong-gu's father sold bungeo-ppang there'd have been no forgiveness.

On the way home I complained to Dong-wan. The punishment was too light. Dong-wan walked in silence then after a long while said 'The day I moved from Yongsan to Bamseom I saw a boy my age in a supermarket being beaten by his father. I turned away so I wouldn't see but our eyes met. On the first day of term I realised that boy was Jong-gu. He recognised me too. He bullied me because he was ashamed I'd seen him being beaten. But it's not really his fault. It's his father's.'

We walked for a long time without speaking.

Friday, 15th April

Jong-gu's clique no longer hangs around with him. Seeing him alone at break and lunchtime, it pinched my heart. Looking at him today he was small not really strong. Before I thought he was much bigger and much more powerful than me. In fact no. Without his gang Jong-gu was small and scrawny.

I spent almost the whole evening on Aunt Jeong-su's maths homework. From next week there's the 'maths gifted' class. In our class Hee-jeong Dong-wan and Jong-gu were chosen.

Saturday, 16th April

I practised the song I'm supposed to sing for the trip show. Dad mocked me. 'Sounds like someone slaughtering a pig.' When I didn't back down and sang another song Mum told me to stop. I'm neither gifted at maths nor talented in music. So what am I exactly?

Sunday, 17th April

Mum took me to the department store to buy clothes for the school trip. She shot past the famous brands without even looking then picked jeans and a T-shirt from a corner 'sale' rack at the end. I didn't really have a choice. I wish I'd never learnt the word 'coordination'.

If I want to be a writer I'll have to get used to poverty. In the end maybe detective is better. After all I've already solved a case!

Monday, 18th April

I think our form tutor is developing early dementia. He said only volunteers will perform in the trip show. Last time everyone didn't mean everyone had to go on stage but everyone had to attend the show. The students booed 'Eeeeh!' But whether it's dementia or mad cow disease I'm one hundred per cent in favour.

Since the textbook incident I feel like I have more friends around me. Today Hee-jeong asked me. 'So what are you doing for the show?' 'Er...' In my mouth saliva turned into glue. The bell saved me.

The sky is high and blue. The world is beautiful. Today max 18°C in Seoul. Isn't that the perfect temperature for love?

Tuesday, 19th April

On the bus home I saw Dong-wan and Jong-gu together. I tried to pull out my smartphone to film but the bus moved and I caught nothing. I hope nothing happens...

Wednesday, 20th April

I packed my bag for the school trip. Too much stuff. It wouldn't fit. I halved it. Still too heavy to carry. Dad saw it and said 'Halve it again.'

- Travel list (cut to half of a half) -

1. Two pairs of jeans (one worn, one in the bag)
2. One hoodie and one shirt (hoodie worn, shirt in bag)
3. One jacket
4. Three pairs of pants
5. Three vests
6. Three pairs of socks
7. One PE kit
8. One towel
9. Wallet (a little souvenir money)
10. Small torch
11. Travel toilet paper
12. Wash bag (toothbrush, toothpaste, soap, Nivea lotion)
13. Wet wipes

14. Smartphone charger

15. Earphones

* What finally didn't fit: spare jeans, spare shirt, spare underwear, spare socks, wool socks for sleeping, spare towel, spare handkerchief, pyjamas, spare jacket, hiking shoes, slippers, spare earphones and a sleeping bag.

After thinking I'm not taking my diary. It's the twenty-first century. So for two days I'll write on my smartphone.

Seeing my huge bag Dad nicknamed me 'the clean freak'. Mum laughed till she nearly ran out of breath and said we should go to court to change my name. I felt a bit left out.

Thursday, 21st April

I want to go home!

I thought we'd ride calmly on the bus admire the scenery climb Seoraksan to forge our spirits and breathe the sea breeze. Not at all. It's chaos. The driver asked for silence several times but the students' chatter turned the bus into a marketplace. My ears are still ringing.

And yet in the service-area toilets I heard the driver of Class 4 say. 'My God! I've never seen students so quiet and well-behaved.' Ppagasari's class really is different. Our form tutor is snoring away...

Because of the rain the campfire is postponed till tomorrow. In a tiny room the boys are playing truth game. Yuck.

After the game Jong-gu was called outside by his former mates. Min-jun from Class 1 and Ju-won from Class 4 were with them. They'd clearly planned to 'let off steam' on Jong-gu during this trip. Jong-gu followed them without a word. Dong-wan looked at me. A look

that said ‘Come on let’s stand with him.’ I hesitated. I didn’t want to get into a fight and honestly whether Jong-gu got shouted at or not wasn’t my business. Dong-wan read my face looked away and went after them alone. I looked around. Nobody else was going to side with Jong-gu and Dong-wan. In my head I swore ‘Damn it’ and ran outside.

Behind the lodge things heated up. The guys told us to get lost said it was none of our business. They hurled insults impossible to write in a diary. Furious Dong-wan stepped towards them. They backed off surprised by his momentum. Dong-wan scanned around and spotted a big abandoned mortar. He went to it shouted and lifted it above his head with both hands. As he advanced they began to retreat one by one. Dong-wan yelled ‘Aaaah!’ and threw the mortar aside. Completely terrified they ran off screaming ‘Every man for himself!’ Dong-wan was panting then he smiled softly at Jong-gu and me. Jong-gu was so stunned he couldn’t even say thank you. He froze.

Tomorrow we climb Seoraksan... I was scared Dong-wan might push the rocking rock down the mountain. I didn’t sleep a wink. It might be better to suggest to our form tutor that we adjust the route.

Friday, 22nd April

Bringing only one towel was a monumental mistake. There are no towels here. Red alert for hygiene. And on top of that I forgot my charger. I’m using Dong-wan’s. And I don’t even know why I brought that torch.

The food here is catastrophic. Compared to this our school cafeteria looks like a hotel buffet. From now on I will never complain about school meals again.

They say last night during truth game Hee-jeong and Hye-seon had a fight. Truth makes people uncomfortable. I know that just by looking at my parents.

Today it wasn't raining so we climbed Seoraksan. The teachers chose the Biseondae route instead of the rocking rock because the path was slippery. I'd spent the night worrying Dong-wan would push it down. What a relief.

In the evening we had the campfire and the show. Classes 2, 5 and 6 all did exactly the same thing. Dance and sing to True Colors. It should go into the Guinness World Records. Hee-jeong and Hye-seon who were supposed to sing a duet for our class gave up because of that stupid truth game.

Dong-wan sticks to Jong-gu like a bodyguard.

Saturday, 23rd April

Home is paradise. I can't write anything here.

Sunday, 24th April

I went to Aunt Jeong-su's for maths. With exams coming up she kept me all morning. I gave her a dodgy ladle and spatula set bought on the trip. Of course made in China. She locked me in the study and checked every hour how many problems I'd solved. With her there's no mercy. I should've bought a made in Korea set.

Drowsy afternoon. Mum cuts Dad's hair washes his head blow-dries it. Dad looks like a tame cat. Then it's my turn. Snip snip hair falls. I feel better. Dad turns up the music in the living room.

We really did well to leave that cramped Bamseom flat for this house with a yard. A peaceful weekend. I feel happy. Until Aunt Jeong-su calls. 'Tomorrow morning 8:55. You come study!'

Monday, 25th April

No school today. A compensatory day after the trip. Instead I had to do a mountain of maths at Aunt Jeong-su's. Dad went back to work. Even a cow or pig being led to slaughter couldn't look sadder. Mum on the other hand isn't afraid to go to work. She only has three employees but she's the boss.

Just as I was about to leave Aunt Jeong-su's Hee-jeong came in. 'Byeok you work hard.' She said that instead of hello.

'Er...' I don't know why but in front of her my mouth just stops working. Hee-jeong smiled and went into the study.

After homework I read *The Secret of the Unicorn*, my birthday present. It's a gem. Tintin that boy reporter. I love him. In fact 'reporter' is detective plus writer mixed together.

But looking at Uncle. Reporter is mostly just employee. Maybe because he's a proofreader.

Tuesday, 26th April

Dong-wan says he's decided to be friends with Jong-gu. He told me we should be friends the three of us. I said I'd think about it. But I don't want to. We're not three friends. It's more like three guys in the same gang. Our ties are too tangled.

At lunch there were fried prawns. With Holmes's eye I concluded. Prawns are the cockroaches of the sea. Their bellies are a bit disgusting. But they taste good.

Hee-jeong has lost her best friend and hangs around alone these days. Does she even know I exist?

Wednesday, 27th April

Dong-wan suggested we study at his place after school. I went. His mum wasn't there only the helper. Dong-wan doesn't go to cram school either like me. Yet he's good. To me Dong-wan is smart. He remembers what he hears. I mostly remember useless things.

While we were studying Jong-gu arrived.

'Jong-gu! Come in!' Dong-wan said opening the door.

'You studying? Hey Heo Byeok. Where do you live?'

He spoke to me as if he felt nothing about me. As if it were natural.

'Byeok lives in Gugil-dong.' Dong-wan said.

'The third-years say there are always lots of salt-water problems and speed-and-distance problems in exams.' Jong-gu said pretending to hide his mouth with his finger.

'They say Hee-jeong's 'solo' you know?' Dong-wan asked Jong-gu.

'Yeah. The class rep yeong-su tried sticking to her and got slapped,' Jong-gu replied.

The two of them talked like ping-pong. It was strange and unfamiliar. A funny sense of exclusion rose in me.

At home I found a very thin comic on Dad's shelf. *Hey, Wait...* by Jason. So thin I'd never even noticed it before. But Dad snatched it away. 'That book is a no!' And locked it in a cupboard with a padlock. On the cover was a dog with its ears pricked. Why 'no'? An adult comic? I'm grown up now too. I know everything or almost...

Thursday, 28th April

Seeing Dong-wan at school I felt a strange distance. He suggested studying together again. I lied and said I had an appointment with Grandad.

Friday, 29th April

Again today Dong-wan suggested it. I lied. Appointment with Grandma.

Saturday, 30th April

I dreamed my nose grew long like a stick. In the dream Jong-gu grabbed it and snapped it. And Dong-wan instead of stopping him laughed and giggled. I woke up with a start. 8:30.

To avoid being late for Aunt Jeong-su's without even washing I took Dad's car and went. Thankfully I wasn't late. Dad didn't even look at Aunt Jeong-su and drove off at once. Dad's scared of her too.

Before class Aunt Jeong-su made me wash my face then gave me bread and milk. She said my attitude—wanting not to be late—was praiseworthy but I had to get up earlier. Today we mostly did salt-water problems and speed problems. Maybe because they were easy I got seven out of ten.

After maths I ate at Grandad's for the first time in ages. Grandma is in hospital with a cold. Lately I've been too indifferent to them. I did the lunch washing-up.

On the way home I stopped by the bungeo-ppang Hyung's stall. He plays jazz to attract customers but in my opinion he should change the music. Still I like jazz. I don't know any pieces or musicians yet. But it draws me.

I shared the orange juice Grandma had made with him. He told me he'd gone to university but quit his job at the end of last year. Office life was too suffocating and inhuman apparently. At night he sings in clubs but he isn't famous yet. Of course. If a celebrity sold bungeo-ppang, fish-shaped buns, that'd already count as 'making it' wouldn't it?

CHAPTER 3

May

Hey, Wait...

Sunday, 1st May (Labour Day)

Dad starts grumbling first thing because Labour Day falls on a Sunday. I told him that today isn't 'Workers' Day' but 'Labour Day'. Dad said 'Workers' Day' is the right term.

'Are 'worker' and 'employee' different?'

'Of course. 'Employee' is like saying 'a diligent worker'.'

'Being diligent is good isn't it?'

'Of course. But even a positive word becomes unfair if it's badly weighted. If instead of 'ladies and gentlemen' we said 'gentlemen and well-behaved ladies' what would you think?

'Well-behaved lady' is a nice phrase but does it belong there?'

'No. It feels unequal.'

'Exactly. 'Employers and employees' is the same. It's lopsided. If you wanted balance you'd have to say 'good bosses and conscientious workers'.'

'So that's why you call it Workers' Day not Employees' Day?'

'Yes. I prefer 'worker'. It sounds straighter. Prouder.'

All of a sudden Dad seemed absurdly cool. So I confessed something I'd been keeping to myself.

'I feel left out because Dong-wan is too close to Jong-gu.'

Dad stared at me and asked.

'Why? Are you jealous?'

'No.'

'Then what's the problem?'

'I don't like Dong-wan being friends with Jong-gu. Jong-gu is nasty. He bullies people.'

'But these days Jong-gu is the one being frozen out isn't he?'

'Yes.'

'Then thanks to Dong-wan he won't get worse.'

'Yes. That's true.'

'So what's the problem?'

'...'

Today I think Dad put a small spell on me.

Monday, 2nd May

- First day of exams -

- Korean. Reading a lot doesn't have much to do with your Korean grade.
- Social Studies. Being 'good with people' doesn't mean you'll score well in 'social'.

Tuesday, 3rd May

- Second day of exams -

- English. I don't know why I got such a good mark.

- Science. My dream isn't to be a scientist. So I've decided not to cling to my science grade.

Wednesday, 4th May

- Third day of exam -

- Maths. They call this a miracle. Out of twenty questions I only got three wrong.

After the paper I rang Aunt Jeong-su. She replied calmly that she already knew. She'd expected it. I think Aunt Jeong-su has bewitched me too.

Thursday, 5th May (Children's Day)

I went to the cinema with Dong-wan and Jong-gu. But the only films we could get into were rubbish cartoons. I wanted to go home but the two of them said we'd watch 'anything'. The theatre was packed with primary-school kids and their parents. I spent two surreal hours in an unreal place and by the end my brain felt completely drained.

After swallowing pizza and cola, Jong-gu left saying he had to be home by one. Dong-wan and I were alone together—properly alone—for the first time in ages. We walked to the bus stop. Dong-wan's bus came first. As he got on he thanked me. My chest felt. Cleared out. Fresh.

After seeing him off I went to Kyobo Book Centre by myself. It's where Dad sometimes buys CDs of Flash Girl. Dad never buys online. He says if you buy online there's no story left. I don't understand what 'story' you need in order to buy a CD.

In the music section I bought a Deep Purple CD with 'April' on it. The cover was truly monstrous. A frightening image of a rat eating a human. But I loved that horror. The shop assistant must have been impressed by my taste.

This is my first ever album for my collection. Later, when I see this CD again as an adult, I'll remember how I opened my heart again to Dong-wan, that mung-bean-pancake-looking Jong-gu, and Kyobo Book Centre.

The money for Parents' Day carnations is going to be tight.

Friday, 6th May

No school again today. It's the school's anniversary. Mum and Dad went to work so I had the house to myself. It's May but the sky is grey and heavy. In the living room I played Deep Purple loudly. Carried along by the music I shouted and flailed about. And then I saw sitting on the speaker the book Dad had forbidden. *Hey, Wait...* by Jason. At the sight of it I swallowed. The books Dad locks away are banned books I'm not allowed to read until Year 11.

I picked up *Hey, Wait...* and hesitated. The thick pencil cover showed only a cute dog with rabbit ears. On the back it said. Warning. This beautiful story could hurt your heart... I wanted to open it. But I put it back on the speaker. I didn't want to betray my promise to Dad.

At noon I went to Grandad's. Grandad and Grandma were looking at photos on a smartphone. Photos of my Samchon who works in Beijing. He's Dad's younger brother. Until last year he came to Seoul often but he must be very busy now. After the washing-up I massaged Grandma's shoulders and knees. When they had their nap I slipped quietly out of Grandad's flat. At the entrance, as always, the bungeo-ppang Hyung was selling.

'Hyung do you know a song called 'April'? Deep Purple.'

'It's on the radio every 1 April. Why?'

'Hyung, how do you know that?'

'Kid, on 1 April it's 'April' and on 31 October it's Lee Yong's 'The Forgotten Season' all day long. So why?'

‘The song is good and the cover is pretty. Don’t you think?’

‘Oh! You’ve got an eye. That’s a Bosch painting. Hieronymus Bosch. I first saw it in Year 10 and fell in love.’

‘Hyung, then do you know a cartoonist called Jason?’

‘No. What do you take me for a doctor? Why?’

‘No nothing. See you hyung.’

Back home *Hey, Wait...* was still on the speaker. The banned book was calling me. The rabbit-eared dog seemed to whisper. It’s fine. Open me. Listen to my story.

I opened the first page...

Saturday, 7th May

Aunt Jeong-su scolded me because I couldn’t concentrate. During the lesson she ordered me three times to go and wash my face. While washing I caught my reflection. My ears were long like a rabbit’s. I jolted.

I bought six carnations. For Mum, Dad, Grandad, Grandma, Aunt Jeong-su and Uncle. Flowers cost as much as gold.

I had no energy. I lay down all afternoon. I thought about life and death. Then I fell asleep. I dreamed of a bus. The miserable passengers all had empty eyes. I sat next to Jon and Bjorn from *Hey, Wait...* The bus drove through darkness.

When I woke up it was raining.

Sunday, 8th May (Parents’ Day)

When I woke up Mum and Dad were still asleep. So first I pinned carnations on Grandad and Grandma. Then I took the bus to Aunt Jeong-su’s. She hugged me very tightly. Uncle, embarrassed by the carnations, hesitated, then got told off by Aunt Jeong-su. Red as a tomato

he gave me pocket money. Since I hadn't eaten Aunt Jeong-su made breakfast. Bagels, milk, strawberries, bell peppers. She stared at me across the table.

'Why don't you have a child?'

'It's because of me.' Uncle said, smiling.

'But there's IVF isn't there?'

'Oh my God—this one.' Aunt Jeong-su looked horrified.

'I know everything. We learn it in science.'

'Byeok it's not that kind of problem. It's more complicated. When you're older I'll tell you.'

The adult world is too complicated. These days maths problems seem almost like the simplest things in existence.

When I got home Mum and Dad were having a late brunch. I sat on the sofa waiting for them to finish. The book *Hey, Wait...* which had been on the speaker was gone. After the meal they got changed. I pinned carnations on them. But strangely I couldn't look Dad in the eye.

I went up to my room and flipped through *Tintin in the Congo* but it felt bland. Uninteresting. At that moment Dad knocked and came in. 'Did you see it?' he asked, sitting on the bed.

'...'

I couldn't say anything. I started to cry.

'I'm sorry. I should've put it away better...'

He stroked my hair.

'Byeok from now on you should only look at beautiful things. Pretty things. Bright things. You'll understand when you're older but there's no rush. Forget Jon and Bjorn.'

'...'

My throat was knotted. But I felt relieved. I could finally look Dad in the eye. Jon and Bjorn seemed to fade inside me too, carried away by my tears.

‘*Tintin in the Congo*... it’s not great. When you’ve finished it tell me what you think.’

Then Dad left.

I’m curious. What did Dad think when he read *Hey, Wait...*? Does he think about life and death too? What was his dream? And today. What does he dream of?

Monday, 9th May

In maths the ‘dung-beetle’ teacher called my name and made me stand. ‘Byeok not bad. In Year 7 you said you were giving up on maths and now it looks like you’ve actually worked.’

‘Ah, yes...’ I stammered.

And from the back someone let out, in a small voice but loud enough for everyone to hear. ‘Didn’t he copy off Dong-wan?’

And then a miracle happened. Yes, a miracle!

‘Oi Shin Cheol-jin! Mind your own business. What do you think you know? Byeok studies maths like a maniac!’

It was Hee-jeong who had just shut up Cheol-jin, that little creep.

The class went ‘Woooah!’ Dong-wan smiled and thumped me hard on the back. Cheol-jin worked his mouth a bit then went quiet.

Fourteen years old. I’d never had a moment more ecstatic than that.

After class Dong-wan and Jong-gu suggested tteokbokki but I said I had an appointment. Dong-wan smiled and thumped my back again.

At the school gate under the fine spring rain I waited for Hee-jeong. The sound of raindrops on my umbrella was cheerful. I waited more than thirty minutes but she didn’t come. And yet I didn’t hate the waiting. On the contrary. I didn’t know waiting for someone

could feel so sweet. I don't understand why Aunt Jeong-su hates waiting for me during her lessons. It's thrilling. It's pleasant.

For a long time I practised what I would say.

'Thanks for today. Shall we get jajangmyeon?' No, too heavy.

'Thanks hey! Do you like tteokbokki?' No I don't want to smear chilli paste on her lips.

'Hee-jeong thank you. Shall we go out?' No, too fast.

And then suddenly. 'Hey, Heo Byeok! What are you doing there?'

I lifted my umbrella. Hee-jeong and Hye-seon were together under the same umbrella.

Tuesday, 10th May (Buddha's Birthday)

Mum left early for work again. With the May long weekend she hasn't had a second. At this rate we might actually become rich.

Dad is sprawled out like an octopus. These days whenever he opens his mouth it's to say he's tired. He can rest as much as he likes. One day of work and he looks emptied out. I feel sorry for Dad. He clearly doesn't have the build for being an employee.

After breakfast I was reading *Tintin in Tibet* when Dong-wan called and told me to come over. His dad saw me and called me 'little hero'. I replied 'I'm not little.' He laughed and apologised.

'Waaah!' Jong-gu shouted when he saw the home cinema.

'My dad just downloads stuff for free...' Jong-gu started talking about his father, then let the sentence die.

Dong-wan's dad put on *The Shawshank Redemption* and asked, 'It's rated 15. You're fifteen aren't you?'

‘Yeees.’ I answered proudly. In situations like this Dad taught me you don’t count ‘international age’. You cheat a little.

The film shook all of us. Jong-gu was buzzing. It had become his all-time number one.

‘Bloody hell that film is insane! The prison governor—what a bastard! But Andy—he’s unreal. Right?’

Words you could never say in our house came out of his mouth one by one. Then he blurted, ‘By the way, I reckon Hee-jeong really likes you, Byeok.’

‘...’

I stared at Dong-wan then Jong-gu like an idiot.

‘You didn’t know? The whole class knows,’ Jong-gu said.

Today I discovered Hee-jeong’s secret. For the first time in my life I prayed to God that it wasn’t a joke.

Wednesday, 11th May

I feel like every pop song in the world is about me.

Dad says he’s sick of this rain that’s been falling for days, but for me it’s absolutely beautiful.

I think I finally understand the line Dad hums whenever it rains. ‘Love is like the rain behind the window’.

Thursday, 12th May

In maths the dung-beetle teacher wrote a complicated equation on the board and asked who could solve it. Dong-wan, Jong-gu and Hee-jeong raised their hands. The teacher said ‘Not you three. Anyone else?’ From the back Cheol-jin said in that small but audible voice.

‘Byeok.’ The teacher looked at me. ‘Alright, Byeok. Have a go.’

I wrote it out and solved it. The teacher arms folded leaning by the window watched me closely. When I finished he said ‘The answer is correct. The reasoning is perfect. Anyone who doesn’t understand write it down.’ I felt embarrassed. I lifted my head slightly and glanced at Hee-jeong. A smile slid across her lips. My heart pumped 3.14 times faster.

Dong-wan says I should talk to her. But the courage wouldn’t come. I’m afraid I’ll live my whole life without a girlfriend. At the end of the day our form tutor handed out a notice. For Teachers’ Day gifts are forbidden. Don’t worry sir. My parents won’t be giving anything anyway.

Friday, 13th May

During breakfast I saw a small spider scuttle under the table. Without thinking, I crushed it with my foot. All day my heart felt heavy. I should’ve put it outside in the yard...

Saturday, 14th May

I went early to Aunt Jeong-su’s for maths. Hee-jeong was already there studying. Aunt Jeong-su gave me a stack of questions and told me to do them alone at the kitchen table. Since they were easy ones I finished quickly. I watched the study room where Hee-jeong was and kept thinking about her smile. Saliva pooled in my mouth and stuck in my throat. When I coughed Aunt Jeong-su told me to stop making noise and drink water.

When Hee-jeong’s lesson ended Aunt Jeong-su came out. Looking at my answers she seemed a little surprised.

‘Byeok you haven’t learnt three of these yet. How did you do them? Are you studying maths separately?’

‘No. Haven’t we already done that?’

Hee-jeong cut in. ‘Auntie Byeok got praised in maths. Twice.’

‘Really? Why didn’t you tell me?’

‘Ah yes...’

‘Doesn’t Byeok know how to say anything other than ‘ah’ and ‘yes’?’

‘Ah yes...’

I don’t know why my mouth won’t open.

‘Well then. Looks like you like Hee-jeong.’

Even Uncle reading the paper in the living room joined in.

My face burned like a candle.

The lift ride down to the ground floor felt longer than a million years. All I did was swallow.

‘Byeok what are you doing now?’

‘Er...’ And suddenly a sentence arrived. ‘Nothing.’

‘Then shall we cycle along the Han River?’

‘I don’t live in Bamseom anymore. So I don’t have a bike.’

‘Doesn’t matter. Come to mine.’

Hee-jeong tugged my rucksack strap.

Hee-jeong’s mum is the prettiest woman I’ve ever seen. Right after Hee-jeong. This is a scientifically proven fact. If the princess is beautiful the queen must be too.

When she saw me her mum said ‘Ah, is that you—Gae?’

I said ‘No I’m not a dog. I’m Byeok.’

Hee-jeong’s brother snickered. Hee-jeong shouted ‘Oppa!’

Then her dad came out of the bedroom saying ‘In our flat we’re not allowed to keep a dog.’

So her mum replied ‘No, not that. I meant Gyaе—him.’

And her dad said ‘Ah! So it’s you. Byeok!’

Korean pronunciation is genuinely difficult.

Hee-jeong and I cycled to Seonyudo and back. Without the yellow dust I'd have wanted to ride longer but the air was too filthy so we came back early. We ate burgers and drank cola while chatting but I don't remember a single word. I wonder if I'm going to end up with heart disease.

Sunday, 15th May (Teachers' Day)

Hee-jeong called early. She wanted to go to an amusement park. I stuffed all my emergency cash into my wallet. Dad drove us to her place. As I got out Dad took out his wallet handed me 30,000 won and gave me a thumbs-up. 'Go on. Do it properly.' It was childish but for 30,000 won I decided to keep quiet.

Einstein was right. Time is relative. I don't remember anything about the day but one thing is certain. My heart beat 3.14 times faster.

Monday, 16th May

Hee-jeong and I are officially going out. The whole class knows. Her parents know. My parents know. Grandad and Grandma know. Aunt Jeong-su and Uncle know. At this point you could say the entire world has been informed.

To give my diary a bit of 'literary dignity' I'll copy a poem by Jean Cocteau.

The Wood Pigeon - Jean Cocteau

Two wood pigeons
with tender hearts
fell in love.

The rest

I cannot say.

Tuesday, 17th May

Next week there's an illustrated poetry exhibition at school. I write the poem. Hee-jeong does the drawing. We can't be separated now. At the amusement park I literally risked my life to go on every ride she wanted. After the Gyro Drop I had to swallow two headache pills... She's afraid of nothing. I get travel sickness just going up to the second floor at home.

Wednesday, 18th May (18th May Commemoration Day)

I wrote the poem for the exhibition and showed it to Hee-jeong. She says it's too abstract too conceptual and she doesn't understand it.

The Herring's Dream - Heo Byeok

A blue fish hung on the wall

When all life falls deeply asleep

you whistle softly

The herring dreams of a blue ocean

But your blue back is only a product of evolution

nothing more.

It is May.

I know it.

The herring's blue dream.

I reread it again and again and even I don't know what it's about. I think this isn't it.
Like Hee-jeong says I should write something simpler.

Thursday, 19th May

May – Heo Byeok

The wind blows.

Between zelkova leaves the sky hides.

The rain falls.

In a silent room objects speak to me softly.

The wind blows again

and the wind covers the world.

What is this

this clear blue thing

that has settled

in the sky

in the street

and in my heart?

Hee-jeong says it's hard to choose between May and The Herring's Dream. She says May is 'a bit easier' so she drew for that one. Mum and Dad read both poems and said 'Becoming a writer is your choice but maybe try a genre other than poetry.'

Friday, 20th May

Hee-jeong brought an incredible drawing for my poem May. At the top green zelkova leaves dance in the wind. In the centre a wide schoolyard spreads out. At the bottom distant buildings are drawn like grains of millet. Looking at her drawing I felt something drain out of my chest. A cold sensation.

Our form tutor was speechless for a moment. The art teacher said her work was at the level of a Year 11 student and praised her a lot. Even Jong-gu said the drawing made a hollow ache in his chest. But no one. Not a single person. Said anything about my poem.

Saturday, 21st May

Hee-jeong moved her maths lesson to Saturdays at 10:25. At first Aunt Jeong-su refused but Hee-jeong's mum asked too so she adjusted. My lesson is at 8:55. Hee-jeong's is at 10:25. During her lesson I'll do my maths homework at the kitchen table. If she finishes at 11:45 we'll have the entire Saturday afternoon together.

From today Aunt Jeong-su gave me double the homework. She says the final covers a wider range than the midterm. Without doubling effort you can't get a good mark. I decided to believe her. Of course it's not to please Hee-jeong.

After maths I went to Hee-jeong's. Her mum made 'proper' spaghetti. My mum puts ketchup on pasta. Hee-jeong's mum used 'real' sauce.

Hee-jeong showed me her sketchbook. Her drawing for the exhibition wasn't a fluke. Everything was incredible. They didn't look like drawings by a girl my age. There was lots of emptiness lots of space. Hollow solitary drawings. What does she think about deep inside?

‘So?’

‘It's good. You're strong.’

‘My brother draws better.’

‘Your brother? But he's in secondary school isn't he?’

‘Yes. He's going to art school.’

She brought out her brother's sketchbook. His drawings were all dark almost frightening. Like the Bosch image I'd seen on the Deep Purple cover. But they were beautiful. It was the first time I'd seen a painter's work up close like that. Until now ‘seeing paintings’ meant looking at an art book on Dad's shelf or a calendar. Of course I'd seen works at the contemporary art museum in Gwacheon or at the National Museum. But holding a sketchbook in your hands and turning it page by page is different. It was a Year 13 boy's sketchbook, but I preferred those drawings.

‘It looks like Bosch...’

‘Huh? You know Bosch? Hieronymus Bosch?’ Hee-jeong looked shocked.

‘Yes. I saw it on a Deep Purple cover.’

‘You know Deep Purple?’

‘And you?’

‘Yes. My brother's a fan. Because of Deep Purple he even bought a Bosch album. He says when he goes to university he'll go to the Prado in Spain just to see those paintings.’

Hee-jeong brought the Bosch album from her brother's room. We turned the pages one by one. Full of fascinating images. Then we went back to the drawings in the sketchbook. They looked sharper. I felt as if I were opening my eyes to drawing. A strange sensation.

Hee-jeong's mum looked at us and said 'Why does Seok-hee only draw things that weird?'

Sunday, 22nd May

On my way home from Hee-jeong's after maths I saw what I shouldn't have seen. Jong-gu's father hitting Jong-gu hard on the head. I walked away quickly and left through the other side of the building. My heart is still pounding.

In the evening I had dinner with Mum and Dad at Grandad's. Grandad and Grandma leave tomorrow for Jeju. A trip for their 45th wedding anniversary. Just thinking about it is beautiful.

I spent the whole day with Hee-jeong and yet I miss her. Why?

Monday, 23rd May

This Friday at the sports festival Hee-jeong was chosen for the girls' 400m relay. Dong-wan and Jong-gu were selected to represent our class in basketball. I'm a 'starter' in tug-of-war. And tug-of-war is the whole class. No absences.

After school Hee-jeong went to practise the relay. I don't need to practise tug-of-war. I watched Hee-jeong run. She runs lightly—very well. I still can't believe I've become close to a girl that pretty. I don't even feel like I've done enough good deeds to deserve it.

Until her training finished I hung around the parallel bars. Until now I'd only used them to hang my bag but today I tried them. It wasn't that hard. I even did a few pull-ups. It wasn't exhausting—either I'm lighter or my arms are stronger.

After that we studied maths together at Hee-jeong's. Her textbook looks a million times harder than mine. The questions are so long that understanding the question is already difficult. I'm already worrying about finals. I mustn't drop in maths...

Grandad called from Jeju. Grandma had got out of the car and left her handbag inside with the hotel key in it. And Grandad had lost the car key. In the rain they'd opened the umbrella and were lost. They explained to the hotel staff who helped them. The car key was stuck in the car door lock. And the handbag? Not in the car. In Grandad's rucksack.

I hope Grandad doesn't 'lose' Grandma.

Tuesday, 24th May

Because of the 'maths gifted' class I've become a loner. Hee-jeong, Dong-wan, Jong-gu. They're all in it. I'm not.

Before going home I stopped by the bungeo-ppang Hyung's stall for the first time in a while. He said sales were down because of the heat. He was quitting after this week. From June he's starting at a video game company. Composing music for the backgrounds apparently. Three-month contract.

'You do it because you love it? No. You do it to eat.' He said. That sentence sounded too familiar. I've heard it somewhere before...

Wednesday, 25th May

Yesterday after the gifted class Jong-gu confessed to Hee-jeong that he likes Hye-seon. Hee-jeong told Hye-seon and Hye-seon likes Jong-gu too. So our class has a second couple. Only Dong-wan has become a loner again. Spring is the season of love.

Grandad and Grandma came back from Jeju after three days. Grandma said they did 'Operation Fits of Laughter'. They decided to take dementia tests for both of them.

They gave me a black sweater bought duty-free in Jeju. A thick sweater for autumn. It's the start of summer and they give me a sweater! There must've been last year's stock on promotion. But I'm still happy.

Thursday, 26th May

The verdict. Grandad and Grandma are perfectly normal. The doctor said it often happens in unfamiliar places and there was nothing to worry about.

Dad suggested Grandad come live with us but Grandma refused 'I don't want to look after you anymore.'

Friday, 27th May

Our class won the girls' 400m relay. Hee-jeong ran fourth and made a spectacular comeback. She runs better than many boys. Dong-wan and Jong-gu gave everything but basketball finished third. Tug-of-war got knocked out in the qualifiers.

After the sports festival we went to play table tennis. Me, Hee-jeong, Dong-wan, Jong-gu, Hye-seon. Five of us. Jong-gu said a table had arrived at the Bamseom community centre. We dumped our adrenaline into ping-pong. Jong-gu played very well. It was Hee-jeong's first time but she learnt quickly. Dong-wan surprisingly couldn't even get the ball over the net. He said the ball was too light. Hye-seon even with explanations couldn't hold the racket properly. I'd learnt a bit with Grandad. Jong-gu challenged me. First game, we went to deuce but he won. The next two games I won back-to-back. Jong-gu had to pay for pizza and cola.

With Hee-jeong's satisfied gaze on me... I felt like I could fly.

Saturday, 28th May

After maths at Aunt Jeong-su's Hee-jeong came to my place. She envied our detached house a lot. Their flat in Bamseom is suffocating and the upstairs neighbours go thump thump. She

hates it. She saw Dad's bookshelf and looked shocked. Truthfully in our home the only thing to be proud of is books. And as decoration nothing is more useful than a book.

We also stopped by the bungeo-ppang Hyung's stall but he wasn't there. We'll probably see him again in autumn. Grandad and Grandma found Hee-jeong cute and pretty. Obviously...

After walking her home I came back and studied maths. I'm considering asking Mum to arrange English lessons too.

Sunday, 29th May

Mum called Aunt Jeong-su early. She said Byeok wanted to learn English and asked what to do. Aunt Jeong-su said to focus on school first as always. If I wanted spoken English she could introduce me to Uncle's English teacher. On the condition I came before 10:25.

At Aunt Jeong-su's Uncle was talking on the computer with a Black man. Uncle seemed fairly fluent. He sat me in front of the screen and introduced me. The man spoke to me but I understood nothing. For a few minutes Uncle translated then he stepped back. 'Now you manage.' For the next ten minutes the only word I said was 'Yes'. Twenty-five times. I don't even know if there were moments I should've said 'No'. Uncle behind me just snorted with laughter.

Thanks to him I'll do free talking with Mr Jamie every Saturday at 10:40 for an hour.

I feel like I'm clinging too hard to studying just to please Hee-jeong. This isn't me.

A foreigner moved into the neighbour's attic room. His skin is a bit dark. He looks Indian or Filipino.

Monday, 30th May

I dreamed I was drowning. I flailed shouting for help when Mr Jamie—staring at me—asked ‘Can you speak English?’ I yelled ‘Yes! Yes!’ Then he started speaking for ages in completely incomprehensible English. I woke with a jolt. ‘Oh no!’

Dreaming in English! That must be a sign my tongue will finally loosen.

Tuesday, 31st May

Our form tutor said next Friday there will be an English listening assessment. I should check if there’s anyone in the family who’s ‘possessed by a spirit’...

CHAPTER 4

June

Ho-yeon-ji-gi

Wednesday, 1st June

After school I went to the dentist with Hee-jeong. Her father gave both of us a check-up. While I was lying there with my mouth wide open he teased me. ‘So you’re my daughter’s boyfriend are you?’ The assistants burst out laughing too staring at me. He said our teeth were in excellent condition.

To celebrate we bought ourselves a chocolate each.

Thursday, 2nd June

This Saturday we’ve decided to grill meat and sausages in our garden. A small simple garden party. Dad rang Hee-jeong’s family and Dong-wan’s family himself and invited them for dinner. Aunt Jeong-su and Uncle said they already had plans and might arrive a bit late. Dad said that was fine.

I prayed to God that it wouldn’t rain on Saturday. It seems faith comes to me all by itself.

Friday, 3rd June

Jong-gu was absent. Our form tutor said he was ill. After school Dong-wan and I went to visit him. Just as we were about to ring the bell we heard angry shouting from inside. We ran away at once. Please let it be nothing serious...

Saturday, 4th June

I got up early. The sky was overcast. Luckily not pouring. I was sweeping the garden and tidying the flowerbeds when Dad told me to hurry or I'd be late for my lesson.

Today even maths went well. My conversation with Mr Jamie was fun. He'd had a car accident and can't use the lower half of his body anymore. He showed me his wheelchair. He speaks very slowly and clearly so I can understand. When I told him I liked 'April' by Deep Purple he sang the opening bars for me. I think we could become good friends.

Uncle says Mr Jamie works from home as an English teacher because of his disability. He teaches people online in Korea, Japan, France, Spain and other countries. Mr Jamie is really impressive. But he should probably lose a bit of weight.

When I got home Mum had made the house spotless. Dad came back from the supermarket with both hands full. They'd both changed into their 'special garden-party outfits'. Well garden or not we only have a tiny patch of green but still it counts. Today I even found Dad rather elegant. No belly modern haircut. Mum too looked slim and pretty. We've been so busy lately we hadn't really looked at each other.

Dong-wan's family arrived first. His mum brought a bottle of wine. Hee-jeong came with her parents. Her big brother didn't come. He says he hates it because there's no one his age. Her dad brought a bottle of 'top-shelf' spirits. Aunt Jeong-su and Uncle arrived about an hour later.

The dads cans of beer in hand grilled meat and sausages in the garden. The mums sitting under the parasol chatted ‘elegantly’ with glasses of wine.

We discovered that Hee-jeong’s father was actually three years senior to my dad at university. They say they never even crossed paths back then. Which makes sense. The chances of a philosophy student meeting a dental student must be close to zero.

The dads talked about Flash Girl and True Colors without noticing time pass. The mums went on and on about the children’s maths and English lessons. In the living room Deep Purple kept playing.

Around midnight the mums ‘collected’ their drunk husbands and took them home one by one. We shouldn’t have talked about politics. The moment that topic came up the dads started drinking twice as fast.

Sunday, 5th June

Early in the morning while I was cleaning the garden I greeted the man in the attic room. The neighbour who moved in recently. He introduced himself. His name is Sisina from Sri Lanka. Since I don’t often see foreigners I couldn’t guess his age. He was so handsome you could fall for him at first sight. Honestly he could be an actor.

He used to work in a factory in Ansan but recently changed jobs and moved to Gugil-dong. The factory in Ansan went bankrupt.

‘So you were paid all your wages properly? I’ve heard some bosses don’t pay...’

‘You know a lot. Yes I got everything. My boss was a good man.’

‘That’s good. My grandad says there are lots of bad people.’

‘Yes. But I’m lucky. This furniture factory in Gugil-dong was introduced to me by my old boss.’

His eyes were full of trust.

‘Sir one day you’ll tell me about Sri Lanka.’

‘Alright. Otherwise I’ll be late. See you.’

He spoke Korean unbelievably fluently. To the ear you couldn’t even tell if he was Korean or foreign. It reassured me. I don’t know why but I felt relieved.

Monday, 6th June (Memorial Day)

In the morning Hee-jeong suggested cycling along the Han River. Obviously better than watching the ceremony on TV. We rode as far as under Dongjak Bridge. Sitting on a bench we ate the inarizushi her mum had made. They were the best inarizushi in the world.

Hee-jeong took a smartphone and a Y-jack out of her pocket and plugged them in.

‘I bought it yesterday. A couple’s jack.’ She smiled a bit shy. ‘Get your earphones out.’

I plugged mine in she plugged hers. She pressed play and adjusted the volume.

‘It’s *Beethoven’s Violin Concerto...*’

Her voice was swallowed by the melody.

Clear gentle pure sound. The first movement ended then the second then the third. I felt as if electricity was running through my whole body.

‘Apparently Beethoven only wrote one violin concerto in his entire life.’

Hee-jeong looked slightly euphoric as if drunk on music.

‘It’s incredible. So this is Beethoven’s Violin Concerto?’

‘Yes. My brother plays it all the time.’

It felt as though time had stopped. Even the wind seemed to have stopped.

Tuesday, 7th June

I stopped by Kyobo and bought a CD of Beethoven's Violin Concerto. When I put it into the old stereo in my room it was exactly that piece. The one I'd heard with Hee-jeong. I turned the volume up. Caught by excitement I grabbed a pencil and even pretended to conduct. Mum called me for dinner but I didn't hear a thing. She opened the door. 'How many times do I have to call you?' I had to stop conducting.

Rummaging through Dad's shelf I found a music book with a funny title. *When Do You Applaud?* Apparently in classical music you don't clap just any time.

Wednesday, 8th June

From *When Do You Applaud?* I picked out a few quotations. My diary gained a bit of authority.

- '*Music tells its own story. All one needs to do is give it the chance.*' — Yehudi Menuhin
- '*The most wasteful form of expenditure is undoubtedly music.*' — Mauricio Kagel
- '*To believe one must understand music in order to enjoy it is a great illusion.*' — Manuel de Falla
- '*In this soundless world like a world of ghosts what we need is precisely music.*' — Ingeborg Bachmann
- '*He who has little curiosity makes few discoveries.*' — Goethe
- '*Music is the vibration of the universe and we are a part of it.*' — Ferruccio Busoni

Mauricio Kagel... no, actually, that one really won't do.

Thursday, 9th June

If I ever go to a classical concert I'd better not applaud. I feel like I could ruin the whole thing.

This evening we had dinner at Grandad's. After washing up I went for a walk with him. He says he has a problem these days. Grandma keeps nagging him to sign up with her for dance classes. In my opinion that really is a very serious problem. Soon they'll actually go to dance school!

On the way back I ran into Mr Sisina. Some kids from the neighbourhood were following him teasing him. I shouted 'You lot of hooligans!' and chased them off. Mr Sisina just smiled. He must be used to it. I felt unnecessarily guilty for him. Those kids...!

Friday, 10th June

English listening test. I have ears so I can hear. But I understand absolutely nothing.

1st. Go Dong-wan

2nd. Kim Hee-jeong Lee Jong-gu

Dong-wan is good in class good at sport and the most popular. If he runs for class president next term he'll be elected.

But I have Hee-jeong.

Saturday, 11th June

Hee-jeong's dad called my dad. He wants us to go to Dobong-san tomorrow. Dad pulled out the bad-back excuse saying he couldn't. I'll go as the family's representative.

I lent Hee-jeong *When Do You Applaud?* By Daniel Hope. I'd like to go to a classical concert with her one day.

Sunday, 12th June

For the first time in my life I climbed up to Ui-am on Dobong-san. I understood the true meaning of ho-yeon-ji-gi.

07.40 Wake-up.

07.50 Hee-jeong calls to check I'm up. Says not to eat breakfast and come straight over.

08.10 Dad drops me off at Hee-jeong's.

08.15 Her mum serves breakfast. I eat my fill.

08.20 She prepares inarizushi for lunch.

08.25 Hee-jeong's dad secretly steals two.

08.26 Hee-jeong takes two and gives me one.

08.28 Hee-jeong's big brother stuffs three into his mouth at once.

08.30 Her mum says there won't be enough. We'll have to buy kimbap at Dobong-san.

08.35 Her dad goes to the toilet.

08.40 We're also given Choco Pie, water, chocolate.

08.45 Her dad is still in the toilet.

08.50 He finally comes out.

08.55 He sets the GPS.

08.57 Departure at last!

09.40 Arrive at the Dobong-san park-and-ride. He pulls the bag from the boot and slams the door too hard. Everyone jumps. Especially him.

10.00 We look around the food market. We haven't even reached the entrance yet.

10.10 Purchase. Jokbal and kimbap. He drools over the makgeolli but doesn't buy any. He looks as if he's seriously considering hiring a driver. But I'm not sure.

10.20 We pass the market and head for the gates.

10.25 We study the map to find Ui-am. Walk a long time then reach a fork. Hee-jeong and I are right but her dad insists he's right. We follow his path. Soon we discover Hee-jeong and I were right. He mutters it's impossible that the map must be wrong.

10.45 He's puffing up to his chin. Break.

12.00 Arrive at the top of Ui-am. It's a bit steep. I hold her hand. Suddenly my heart starts beating 3.14 times faster. I think I'm having cardiac arrest. She's perfectly fine.

12.05 Souvenir photo.

12.30 Lunch. Her dad grumbles 'jokbal on its own is dry.' He looks jealously at people drinking makgeolli.

12.55 We dip our feet in the stream. Her dad calls it a 'foot bath'. Freezing.

14.40 Finish descending.

14.50 Set off for home.

15.50 Arrive at Hee-jeong's. Mum and Dad are waiting there.

16.20 Both families go together to the jjimjilbang.

Back home I put on *Beethoven's Violin Concerto* and collapsed.

Monday, 13th June

Mum says the travel agency is short-handed. She's hired two new employees. Every morning it's war before Dad goes to work. He really must hate it. According to Mum his neck and back hurt badly. An occupational disease. Sitting in front of a computer all day.

I think our sofa shares some of the blame too...

Tuesday, 14th June

Mum granted Dad a one-year sabbatical. Dad says he'll hand in his resignation tomorrow and leave the company before the end of the month. Mum asked if he didn't need at least a month for handover. Dad replied 'Handover of what?' That tells you how much he mattered at his company.

Dad declared he was transferring all his powers as head of the family to Mum. As if he had any powers to transfer in the first place...

Wednesday, 15th June

Dad submitted his resignation letter. In two weeks he'll officially be unemployed. So Mum is the boss, Dad is unemployed and I'm a student. What a dynamic family.

If anything happens I'll side with Mum.

Thursday, 16th June

Dad's face is glowing. What if his back pain wasn't just an act?

Grandma rang Mum after hearing the news. Mum reassured her. The agency is doing well. She said Dad had worked fifteen years without rest so a year off might not be such a bad thing. Mum really is classy.

But Dad isn't going to rest for more than a year right...?

Friday, 17th June

Dad called Hee-jeong's dad. He wants to go back to Dobong-san. I asked Dong-wan if he wanted to come but his family is travelling to Byeonsan-bando this weekend.

So we're repeating last week's team just adding my dad. I'm worried. Will he manage to climb? He doesn't even walk five hundred steps a day.

Saturday, 18th June

I sweated trying to explain last week's Dobong-san hike to Mr Jamie. When I said 'mountain climbing' he looked shocked. He asked if there really was such a high mountain near a big city. So I said 'Seoul has many many mountains.'

It was the first time in my life I'd strung five words together. Well. That's not the most important part.

Mr Jamie kept pulling stunned faces while talking about ropes, bivouacs and so on and I didn't understand a thing. He must've been so surprised he forgot to speak slowly.

Later Uncle explained. I should've said 'hiking' not 'mountain climbing'. Over there 'climbing' makes people think of rock climbing. Walking for a few hours is 'hiking'. And 'trekking' is hiking over several days.

Sunday, 19th June

My dad and Hee-jeong's dad decided to stop hiking for a while. In my opinion that really is the secret of good health.

07.00 Wake-up. Check the weather. Cloudy but fine.

07.15 Dad doesn't get up.

07.20 Dad says he won't go. Even Mum gets up to wake him. He still refuses. So Mum threatens to cancel his sabbatical. Dad jumps up.

07.25 Dad dozes on the toilet. We wake him.

07.30 Dad calls Hee-jeong. We'll arrive at 8:10. Hee-jeong says come at 8:20. Her dad isn't up yet. She's waking him.

07.40 Breakfast prepared by Mum. Dad barely eats. Mum insists. He finally drowns the rice in soup and swallows without chewing.

08.00 Mum packs water and fruit. She says we'll buy lunch at the market below Dobong-san.

08.20 Arrive at Hee-jeong's. Her mum prepares inarizushi.

08.25 Dad steals two.

08.26 Her mum tells him to stop. It's for the lunch box.

08.28 Hee-jeong's dad goes to the toilet.

08.35 He comes out.

08.45 Hee-jeong's dad sets the GPS.

08.48 Departure for Dobong-san!

09.30 Arrive at the car park.

09.40 Purchase. Jokbal, four rolls of kimbap and four cucumbers.

09.50 Argument about the route. Both dads want to climb up to Sinseon-dae. Hee-jeong and I say that's too much. Ui-am is enough. Her dad insists heavily. Today it's Sinseon-dae.

10.05 My dad is puffing up to his chin.

10.10 The other dad too.

10.55 After Dobong-san-jang people are resting. Hee-jeong's dad says this is Madang-bawi.

Hee-jeong and I share a cucumber. Dad takes out a folding knife to peel it. But we're already eating it with the skin. He puts the knife away embarrassed. Hee-jeong giggles.

11.10 We reach the real Madang-bawi. So the cucumber place wasn't Madang-bawi after all.

Hee-jeong and I decide to call it 'Fake Madang-bawi'. On the real one the view suddenly opens and ho-yeon-ji-gi is cultivated to the full. On the climb I hold her hand. My heart goes thump thump.

11.20 From Madang-bawi we set off towards Jaun-bong. The real hike begins. Both dads bathe in their sweat.

12.30 Arrive at Sinseon-dae. The last part is a bit scary. Hee-jeong isn't scared at all. Too many people to stay. Seoul spreads out in panorama. Souvenir photo.

12.35 Up there Hee-jeong gently takes my hand. My heart beats a million times faster.

12.40 Someone says it's 32°C in Seoul. Both dads at the same time have a serious dizzy spell.

13.00 Lunch. Inarizushi, kimbap, jokbal, boiled eggs and cucumbers. Both dads recover a bit of colour. They desperately want a glass of makgeolli. At the start of the valley foot bath. Feet frozen head frozen. But what bliss.

15.00 Descent finished. Photo in front of poet Kim Su-yeong's stele.

16.30 Traffic jam. Arrive at Hee-jeong's thirty minutes late.

17.00 Everyone to the jjimjilbang. Both dads go to the sleeping room and snore. It's so loud other men flee. Someone says 'Double cannon.'

20.00 My dad declares he won't go to the mountains for a while. Hee-jeong's dad joins the declaration. The mums applaud.

I fell asleep thinking of the touch of Hee-jeong's hand at Sinseon-dae.

Monday, 20th June

End of happiness start of misery. The final-exam timetable is out.

- Tuesday, 5 July : Korean, Social Studies, Ethics
- Wednesday, 6 July : English, Music
- Thursday, 7 July : Science, Chinese Characters
- Friday, 8 July : Maths

After school I went to study at Dong-wan's. There are eight subjects. I don't know where to start. Dong-wan told me to lock down Korean-English-Maths first then do the memorisation subjects more calmly later. So this week I'll focus on maths.

Korean and English scare me.

Tuesday, 21st June

Again at Dong-wan's after school. I wanted to focus on maths but worrying about Korean and English stopped me from making progress.

The 'rote-learning' subjects worry me too.

Wednesday, 22nd June

Aunt Jeong-su rang the house. This week 'maths only' she said.

Mum and Dad on the other hand show zero interest in my finals...

Thursday, 23rd June

Dad begs Mum in a nasal voice. He wants just one plane ticket to Europe. He even sings that he wants to go to Europe next month. Dad really has some nerve.

Friday, 24th June

I think Dad has lost his mind. He bought three travel books about Europe and laid them out conspicuously on the table so Mum would see. But Mum looked at the books and scolded me. 'Byeok once you've finished put these away!'

It's been so long since she's seen Dad read that she thought I'd spread them all out. I was about to explain but Dad quickly put everything away.

Saturday, 25th June

Aunt Jeong-su kept me the whole day. Maths in the morning then free-talking English with Mr Jamie curry at noon made by Aunt then more maths in the afternoon.

‘Eighty-seven points. But only if you make no silly mistakes.’

Aunt prophesied my maths score for the final exam. I felt like a Greek hero receiving an oracle. Eighty-seven is already enormous!

Dad made me a ‘secret’ proposal. During the summer holidays I should beg Mum to let us go to Europe. And he’ll follow ‘as my guardian’. I quietly put the Europe books Dad had bought back on the table.

Sunday, 26th June

Bombshell announcement from Mum! She’s going to give Dad a discounted plane ticket to Europe at the end of July. She says Dad has worked fifteen years for us and deserves to enjoy himself a little. Dad nasal. ‘Darling I love you.’ Mum nasal too. ‘Sorry it’s not a direct flight.’ Me nasal as well. ‘And me?’ And Dad. ‘You’re studying for finals.’

Dad traitor!

Monday, 27th June

Dad submitted his ‘sabbatical plan’ to Mum. Mum is reviewing the file.

Tuesday, 28th June

Dad’s ‘sabbatical plan’ was rejected at inspection. He’d forgotten the quit smoking part.

Wednesday, 29th June

The plan was finally approved. By a whisker. Phew. Tomorrow Dad goes to work for the last time and then he’ll be unemployed. And yet he’s proud. All thanks to Mum.

- Heo Su-jeong’s Sabbatical Plan -

1. Quit smoking.
2. Apply for the good health insurance discount and pass for sure.
3. Get up at 7 a.m. as usual.
4. Take charge of all housework (basic banchan, washing-up, food waste, shopping, cleaning laundry, etc.).
5. Never ask his mother to make side dishes.
6. Do not watch TV during the day.
7. Don't drink too much coffee. One cup a day!
8. Do 30 press-ups a day.
9. Get into shape to do more than 10 pull-ups.
10. Eat slowly.
11. No late-night meals.
12. Don't drink too much.
13. Don't swear while driving.
14. Cut toenails properly.
15. Be loyal to his wife Min Jeong-ran!

Not a single line about me... I'm not even a child picked up off the street...

Thursday, 30th June

Half the year has already passed. Time flies.

After school I was going to study with Dong-wan. As we were leaving Jong-gu was standing by the gate with an unfamiliar man. Worried we shouted 'Jong-gu!' Jong-gu and the man turned round surprised.

'Off to revise?' Jong-gu asked waving to us.

‘Yes. Want to come?’ Dong-wan said.

‘This is my brother. Say hello.’

His brother looked about five years older than us. It was the first time I’d learnt Jong-gu had an older brother. I’ve never been to Jong-gu’s house. I don’t think Dong-wan has either. And to be honest I don’t really want to. His parents are frightening.

Thinking about it I don’t know much about Jong-gu. I’ve never been the one to contact him first to meet. When he’s in a good mood he overflows with energy and is expansive. Otherwise he turns gloomy and silent.

‘Well I’m off. Take care of yourself alright? I’ll be back.’ his brother said.

Jong-gu hugged him. His brother patted his back.

The three of us walked without speaking. Jong-gu in front Dong-wan and I three or four steps behind. Jong-gu turned round. ‘My brother doesn’t live with us. Bloody hell.’

I didn’t know what to say.

‘He left home in Year 12. My dad used to beat him like mad. Bloody hell.’

He said that and walked on. Today Jong-gu’s shadow looked strangely long.

CHAPTER 5

July

When Paris Calls Us

Friday, 1st July

In English class Mr Miles said that July is called July because of Julius Caesar the Roman politician. After his death later generations named the month after him. And he added that August comes from Augustus Caesar, the first Roman emperor. Unfortunately almost no one in our class understood what that meant. Caesar and Augustus aren't Superman or Batman. How could these idiots possibly know?

From today my dad is officially unemployed. Is there such a happy unemployed man on Earth? Seeing him happy makes me happy too. The rest. We'll worry about that later.

Saturday, 2nd July

While correcting the maths homework she'd given me last week Aunt Jeong-su asked 'You managing alright?' I said 'Yes but Aunt. I'm always running out of time. Even in tests the clock chases me.' And she said 'That's because your basics aren't solid enough. Looks like I'll have to give you even more homework.' Argh!

In the afternoon I revised with Hee-jeong at her place. She has an unbelievable memory. She remembers perfectly everything she hears once in class. Why is it that I remember nothing?

Even though their only child is facing the final exam of his life Mum and Dad say tomorrow they're going on a little drive to Ganghwa-do just the two of them. When I asked them to pay a bit of attention to me as well Dad said 'Our educational philosophy at home is free-range grazing. I grew up like that too.'

I'll have to check that with Grandma.

Sunday, 3rd July

Grandma says she never raised Dad on 'free-range grazing'. On the contrary she regrets spoiling and doting on him too much. There. That's exactly what I thought.

Monday, 4th July

For the first time in my life—short as it is—I'm studying seriously and sitting an exam seriously. I've summed up my current state with an adult expression.

Do everything you can and wait for heaven's verdict.

Tuesday, 5th July

- First day of exams -

- Korean. You reap what you sow.
- Social studies. It's a 'Ppagasari subject'. Do you really need a reason?
- Ethics. I studied hard. So why did I mess it up? Do I have a moral problem myself?

Wednesday, 6th July

- Second day of exams -

- English. You saved me.
- Music. I absolutely don't understand why music needs a written exam!

Thursday, 7th July

- Third day of exams -

- Science. You can't be good at everything not even science. That's called living within your means isn't it?
- Chinese Characters. Easy. Thank you sir.

Friday, 8th July

- Fourth day of exam -

- Maths. Aunt Jeong-su's prophecy was wrong. I got 91.

I rang her to boast. 'I got 91 in maths!' She said if it really is 91 she'll buy me a present. Whatever I want.

Saturday, 9th July

Today there's neither maths nor English class. Aunt has gone on a trip to the East Coast with Uncle and Mr Jamie says he isn't feeling well. In life you need days like this too.

Hee-jeong came over. We watched Dad draw up his travel plan. At first glancing at Mum he said he'd go 'only' for two weeks just to get some air. But Mum said 'Europe is hard enough just to get to. You need at least a month don't you?' And Dad immediately changed it to a month.

Incheon – London – Brussels – Heidelberg – Frankfurt – Prague – Vienna – Venice –
Rome – Munich – Zurich – Interlaken – Zurich – Barcelona – Madrid – Paris – Incheon

Seeing the route Mum said ‘Do you think you’re twenty?’ Dad laughed a bit embarrassed.

‘Or just do one or two cities. One month. Or two.’

‘Two months? Really?’ Dad’s eyes almost popped out. ‘And the budget?’

‘With the severance pay maybe?’

‘Mum and me?’ I slipped in in a nasal voice.

‘You—when you grow up you’ll earn your own and go by yourself.’

Since they came back from Ganghwa-do last week Mum has changed. She’s far too kind to Dad. Something must’ve happened there.

Dad says he’ll ‘rethink’ the European itinerary from scratch. Disaster. At this rate I’ll spend the whole holiday scraping the floor of my room. Dad in Europe Mum at work and me alone on a ‘stay-at-home holiday’!

Sunday, 10th July

I looked for ways to attach myself to the Europe trip but the odds are ridiculous.

- Method 1. Hunger strike (15% chance. If I fast ten days 70%)
- Method 2. Mobilise my network (Grandad Grandma Aunt Jeong-su etc.) to pressure Mum (10%)
- Method 3. Hide in Dad’s suitcase (5%)

I can’t find a ‘reasonable’ solution. Red alert!

In the afternoon Hee-jeong called. She told me to bring Choco Pies and milk hide them in my bag so her mum wouldn't see and ask no questions. I did exactly as she said. I can do anything anything for Hee-jeong. Love needs no reason.

When I arrived Hee-jeong was on an unlimited hunger strike! She refuses to go to English camp during the holidays. She says she went last year it was rubbish and it didn't even help her English. Instead she's demanding a trip to Europe. Wow. She's got guts.

When I handed her the Choco Pies and milk she smiled very softly. I thought my breath would stop.

Hee-jeong says tonight her dad will eventually give in. And she told me to persuade Mum and Dad too. I said it's not that simple at my place. And she said 'Don't you want to go to Paris with me?'

Even if I have to fast ten days I have to go to Paris with Hee-jeong. Yes. From tomorrow hunger strike. Tonight I'll eat a lot just this once.

Monday, 11th July

Aunt Jeong-su's prophecy was right. Maths 87. I lost four points on short-answer questions.

I still haven't started my hunger strike. Even if I fast no one at home will notice. That's the problem.

Tuesday, 12th July

Hee-jeong finally won. Thanks to my Choco Pies.

Hee-jeong's mum called my mum's travel agency. Early August Hee-jeong and her dad want to go to Paris. Flights and hotel could they look into it? She says she won't come because she's afraid of flying. My God. What's so scary about a plane?

Dong-wan leaves for Mongolia at the start of the holidays. He'll stay about two weeks with his mum's family. Jong-gu is going to an English camp run by a university and Hye-seon too. The same camp as Jong-gu. Of course she hasn't told her mum about Jong-gu. Obviously. Even I wouldn't say that. It'd be a bit too shameless wouldn't it?

After the last period we played a basketball match against Class 4. Today Dong-wan and Jong-gu were literally flying. We won by over ten points. Even the girls from Class 4 fell for Dong-wan. And Hye-seon is completely mad about Jong-gu.

I know. I know that look of people in love...

Wednesday, 13th July

Dad's European plan is out. A whole month in Paris then off to Rome and another month there before coming back. Mum says we should pass through Milan and Florence between Paris and Rome. Dad said 'Oh really?' and Mum scolded him for not studying the trip enough.

And what about me? Why does nobody see me?

At this rate it might really happen. My dad, Hee-jeong's dad and Hee-jeong going to Paris alone. The situation is heading for disaster.

Thursday, 14th July

It's peak season. No hotels no flights. Good. Petrol is shooting up and they say Europe's in economic crisis. What trip to Europe honestly. And I don't understand how Hee-jeong's dad can leave his clinic closed for ten days. What about his patients? A responsible doctor shouldn't do that.

Friday, 15th July

Fine. Hee-jeong's dad's patients can probably endure toothache for ten days. Doctors are human too. They need holidays don't they?

Mum finally gave her permission. I can go to Paris with Dad. Hee-jeong is so happy she doesn't know what to do. The four of us are going. My dad, Hee-jeong's dad, Hee-jeong and me!

But finding flights and a hotel is like catching a star in the sky. Disaster. Even Dad is starting to feel the danger. Petrol rising endlessly the EU in crisis and yet still so many people want to go to Europe. I recommend they all go to Jeju instead!

Saturday, 16th July

After maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su's Hee-jeong and I ate kalguksu Aunt had made. Uncle listened to our story and said 'Then rent a studio or a flat in Paris.'

'A flat?' Hee-jeong and I asked at the same time.

'Yes. Studio flat. It's all the same.'

'But how do you rent?'

'In France the summer break start from June. Korean students rent out their studio or flat during summer. One month if it's short two or three if it's long. You rent a one-bed or two-bed. Or two studios.'

'Really?!' I shouted.

'Hey Heo Byeok! Calm down!' Aunt laughed.

Uncle rang my dad. My dad rang Hee-jeong's dad. Everyone said yes. Dad started rummaging like a madman through a Korean-students-in-France community site Uncle gave him. He sent twelve emails and made over twenty calls. Dad grumbled that students never answer. Are they in class? Sometimes when someone did answer a French woman said

‘Bonjour’ and went on in French. Dad let me listen. I know it for sure. Every time we couldn’t say a single word and hung up.

Result. Impossible to find anyone willing to rent just for August. Dad says. ‘Let’s wait a bit.’ Wait for what exactly?

Mum managed somehow to find four plane tickets. Depart for Paris on 1 August return on 12 August. And it’s a direct flight. In peak season. Mum really made a sacrifice.

It reassures me. I’m probably not a child picked up off the street.

Sunday, 17th July (Constitution Day)

Among the emails sent to Paris two promising addresses still haven’t replied. We’re betting everything on them. Well. Everyone except Dad. Dad says if he can’t find accommodation he’ll go alone in September off-season quietly.

I seriously wonder if he’s really my father!

Monday, 18th July

Jong-gu is depressed. What’s going on? Even when Dong-wan talks to him he barely answers. His eyes are red. In my head I started spinning all kinds of scenarios...

Maybe Jong-gu’s dad isn’t just a policeman but a spy. A police-spy. A sleeper agent like in the films. He’s infiltrated the police and feeds secret information to an enemy country. And his mum? Yes. She must’ve been a spy too at first. A spy doesn’t marry a woman who isn’t a spy. A spy couple! But then maybe she forgot her mission because of the big salary of the police chief and plunged into the pleasures of spending. Conflict in the marriage turned violent. And in all that the dad took it out on Jong-gu’s big brother. Because he can’t complain to anyone. If he reports to his superiors he could be killed for incompetence. If he reports to the police they’ll laugh at him. ‘It’s not April Fool’s!’ And besides he himself is

police. Who would he complain to? So the big brother fled the violence and the spy parents. But he can't betray them so he keeps quiet. And because he wants to see Jong-gu he sometimes sneaks to the school. That's why Jong-gu is so sad. So I have a friend who's the son of a spy? Should I report it? Or not?

I was imagining all this.

'Jong-gu what's wrong? Is there a problem?' Dong-wan asked again.

'I've got a swollen throat. I can't talk...' Jong-gu said painfully.

Tuesday, 19th July

Grandma signed up for dance school. Grandad who dances like a plank of wood signed up too. He probably had no choice. In front of Grandma, Grandad can do nothing. It's a family tradition.

Hee-jeong says my grandparents are 'so stylish' and wants to see the dance hall. I don't even dance but just the word dance makes me nauseous. Poor Grandad. But that's fate.

And from Paris. Still no news.

Wednesday, 20th July

Holidays. And finally the Paris accommodation problem is solved. In the end Uncle saved the day.

Dad had been dialling Paris wrong all along. You have to drop the zero between the country code and the city code. He didn't know just grumbled that 'students never answer'. And Uncle also told us that the French woman saying 'Bonjour' was an automatic message. A system announcement! When I heard that I shivered. Can we really go to Paris with Dad?

The people renting to us are a Korean couple who've been students in France for seven years. They also have a little daughter. They're spending all of August in Korea then

going back to Paris. School starts again in September there apparently. What luck. Anyway we're to meet them in Seoul on 28 July pay the rent and deposit and get the keys.

They sent photos by email. Three tiny bedrooms a tiny living-kitchen a tiny bathroom. And in the mail there was also a long list of instructions.

- Studio Instructions -

1. Address: 9 Rue Jacques Louvel Tessier, 75010 Paris, Apartment 101(Korean counting: 2nd floor). Métro Goncourt: 1-2 minutes on foot(Line 11). Métro République: 5-6 minutes on foot(Lines 3, 5, 8, 9, 11).
2. From CDG Airport: Take the Roissybus to Opéra, then take the metro to Goncourt, Exit 2.

In front of the exit there is a phone shop. Walk down and you'll see a café. About 30 metres to the left of the café is a large red gate.
3. Gate code: 3464(the entrance key will be given in Seoul).
4. Wi-Fi: NEUF_4EBC.
5. Wi-Fi password: gabyuff5ufbubduobxxe(Very long—please type it carefully without mistakes).
6. Be careful with the shower door: the glass can break.
7. Turn on the ventilation while showering(risk of mould).
8. Avoid splashing water on the wall; if it happens, wipe it dry.
9. Push the fridge door all the way closed; if you close it halfway, it may stay open.
10. Always double-check that the fridge is fully closed.
11. Clean the rice cooker pot only with a soft sponge.
12. Use the washing machine only during the day(neighbours complain at night).
13. If you make noise late at night, neighbours will complain.

14. Korean grocery Lucky Mart: near Bourse from Opéra(63 Rue Sainte-Anne).
15. Korean grocery OK Mart: 5 minutes on foot from Lucky Mart toward Opéra.
16. Products available: rice, kimchi, jokbal, sashimi, kimbap, vegetables, etc.
17. Around Goncourt live together French people, Black people, Chinese, Turks, Arabs and others. If you have racial prejudices, you cannot live here. Please keep this in mind. The neighbourhood is safe. Have a good trip!

I forwarded the email to Hee-jeong and ran to her place. On Google Maps we searched the address. When we entered it the big red gate appeared exactly like in the photos. With Street View we visited the area around the metro. We already felt as if we were in Paris.

That evening at home I started organising our itinerary using Dad's European travel books. But the section on Paris was far too thin. There were tons of pages on England Germany Spain. Everything we don't need. Why did Dad buy this book?

I ticked off one by one the places I wanted to go. Just that made my heart pound. But then Aunt rang and dumped a mountain of maths homework on me. And my excitement evaporated.

Aunt says maths homework comes before everything. Aaaah!

Thursday, 21st July

Hee-jeong's dad put up a notice at the entrance to his clinic. Closed from 28 July to 15 August for 'attendance at a dental conference in Europe'. What conference...

Once I finished the maths homework I went to Hee-jeong's. Dong-wan came too. He doesn't say it but I think he'd rather go to Paris than Mongolia. Who would choose a Mongolian desert over the Eiffel Tower and the Seine?

We hardly knew anything about Paris. So first we chose three films 'set in Paris'.
Uncle helped us pick. He seems to know far more than my dad.

- Movies -

1. *When Paris Calls You*(Tomorrow we've decided to watch it together at Dong-wan's.)
2. *French Kiss*(Hee-jeong chose this one.)
3. *Amélie*(I've seen it already but I decided to watch it again as revision.)

- Books -

1. *Places in Paris*(Uncle said he'd lend it to Dad.)
2. *Thinking of Paris*(This one too. Uncle said to give it to Dad. In the end he lent us nothing. He simply told us to go to the library and find books that suited our level. My uncle!)
3. Various travel guides(Uncle added that the National Assembly Library had lots of travel books.)

Dad starts his stop-smoking programme today. Mum warned him. If he fails he hands back his sabbatical. She also said that if Dad smokes in Paris I'm to photograph him. She even promised a paparazzi fee. 10,000 won per photo.

By the time we get back I may have enough money to go independent.

Friday, 22nd July

At Dong-wan's we watched *When Paris Calls You*. Disappointing. 'Paris' is in the title but Paris barely appears.

After the film as Uncle told us we went to the National Assembly Library. But they refused us entry. You need a letter of recommendation from the school head or a teacher-librarian. Excuse me. Aren't we Korean citizens too? We don't pay taxes yet but we will. This is outrageous. And we live nearby!

Hee-jeong asked 'Doesn't your mum's agency have loads of travel guides?' I said those are 'office books'. You can't borrow them. So we went to Kyobo. Every guide in the world was there.

When I got home Dad was watching *Amélie*. I was supposed to watch it tomorrow with Hee-jeong but I did my homework early.

I absolutely want to go to the Canal Saint-Martin.

Saturday, 23rd July

I told Uncle we'd been turned away from the National Assembly Library. He said that was impossible. Well it happened.

Aunt said my maths foundations were gradually building and praised me. Today I also did English properly. When Mr Jamie heard I was going to Paris he was jealous. He said one day he absolutely wants to go. I told him. 'Yes you should go one day sir.' and he burst out laughing saying my English was getting better and better. I got praised twice in one day.

After lessons at Hee-jeong's we watched *Amélie*. Impossible to tire of it. It's a film that makes you happy every time. Hee-jeong says she wants to go to the Canal Saint-Martin where Amélie skips stones. We made a list of must-see places.

- Must-see in Paris -

1. Eiffel Tower

2. Louvre Museum

3. Musée d'Orsay
4. Canal Saint-Martin
5. Musée de l'Orangerie
6. Notre-Dame Cathedral
7. Saint-Ouen flea market
8. Rodin Museum
9. Musée de Cluny
10. Montmartre
11. Walk from Île de la Cité to Boulevard Saint-Germain
12. Centre Pompidou
13. Arc de Triomphe
14. Maritime Museum
15. Walk around Le Marais
16. Tuileries Garden

Our trip feels too short.

Tomorrow we were meant to watch *French Kiss*.

Sunday, 24th July

I looked up what 'french kiss' means. In Korean we call it. 'a debate involving the exchange of tongues.' Even if I die I will never do that. Even with Hee-jeong. No. Sorry.

Hee-jeong called in the morning to tell me to come watch *French Kiss* but I pretended I had the flu and didn't go.

My nose feels itchy... as if it's about to get longer.

Monday, 25th July

Dong-wan left for Mongolia. Jong-gu and Hye-seon left for English camp. Grandad at dance school became 'the champion of the body'. But not in a good sense. 'champion of clumsiness'. Grandad, hang in there.

I told Hee-jeong we'd revise the travel plan at my place today. Because at my place there isn't *French Kiss* DVD. And Dad meanwhile is preparing absolutely nothing. Watching us plan he laughed 'You two are adorable playing at this.' Then he said 'You'll be in Paris. What plan? Wake up and go wherever you fancy.'

I genuinely wonder if I should go to Paris with Dad.

'Oh dear. My dad says exactly the same.' Hee-jeong said.

Whatever. Fathers are supporting characters anyway. The stars of this trip are Hee-jeong and me.

Tuesday, 26th July

Mum looked at our schedule and said it was too hard for my dad and Hee-jeong's dad. At this rate they'll collapse in two days. When I told Hee-jeong she said to come immediately to adjust the plan 'just a tiny bit'. When I arrived she'd already put the *French Kiss* DVD in. Aaaaah.

Her mum made homemade yoghurt. We ate it with spoons and let the film pull us in for two hours. *French Kiss* wasn't a horror film but a romantic comedy. Thank goodness. There weren't that many 'tongue-exchange' scenes. I'd worried for nothing.

After three films set in Paris I felt as if I'd been there several times. I even had the sensation there was no need to go in real life. It would save money too.

Back home Dad was reading *Places in Paris*. Seeing our schedule he must have had some inner shift.

Wednesday, 27th July

Even though it was pouring we did a final check of the schedule at Hee-jeong's in the evening. Her dad skimmed our plan diagonally and said 'Well done.' Then he said to my dad. 'A little soju?' And then even the mums joined in. The living room turned into a bar in seconds. From the start the objective had clearly been alcohol.

Hee-jeong's dad's clinic closes from tomorrow. He says it's the first time in his life he's taken a holiday this long. I felt a bit sorry for the dads.

Hee-jeong and I leafed through her brother's Impressionist art book.

'With the Impressionists I like the painters more than the paintings.' Hee-jeong said.

What does that mean? I didn't ask. I have to find the answer myself.

Mum and Dad were drunk. We left the car in the car park and went home by taxi.

Thursday, 28th July

The weather is bad. I'm uneasy. Dad paid the rent and deposit to the student couple and collected the keys. He gave one to Hee-jeong's dad and kept the other. I'm worried but I'll trust the two dads. They're not going to lose both keys at the same time... are they? Why do men look so reliable at work and so alarming the moment they leave work? Mystery.

In the evening we packed. On Mum's advice Dad and I packed light. Dad took only a small rucksack. A few clothes and toiletries. He also took *Places in Paris*. He seems to really like that book. And he took another book. *The Island* by Jean Grenier. Is he planning to go to the sea or something?

I called Hee-jeong. They'll pack light too. Very good. Safe journey. You can't travel with people who bring everything from gochu-jang to doen-jang can you?

Friday, 29th July

I stopped by Hee-jeong's in the morning and without thinking asked 'Are you moving house today?'

'See Mum! Byeok is asking if we're moving!' Hee-jeong shouted towards the kitchen.

I wasn't joking. When I saw Hee-jeong's dad's luggage I honestly thought they were emigrating. A suitcase the size of an aircraft carrier, a big rucksack and a small handbag. Just looking at it made me dizzy.

Hee-jeong's dad looks ready to set up a second household in France. Alert.

Saturday, 30th July

My mum called Hee-jeong's mum and persuaded her to cut Hee-jeong's dad's luggage in half. She said 'If we need something we'll buy it there.' But it didn't work. Hee-jeong's dad is a fervent believer in domestic products. That doesn't mean he's patriotic. He hates 'Made in China'. China as 'the world's factory'.

'With luggage that heavy you'll lose the children.' Mum said.

The final blow. Unanswerable.

Hee-jeong's dad reduced his luggage to half of half. Phew. Hee-jeong was about to restart her hunger strike.

I finished all the maths homework assigned by cold Aunt Jeong-su. Tomorrow morning I have to go to her place with Hee-jeong for checking. She says she can't 'let us off'. We're missing two weeks of maths. Mr Jamie told me to enjoy myself properly. He never gives homework. You just say what you want to say in the moment.

Sunday, 31st July

Early in the morning I went to greet Grandad and Grandma. Grandad gave Dad an envelope to help with travel expenses. Dad didn't even show it to me. He just wiped his mouth. How much is inside? It doesn't matter. In Paris I only have to photograph him every time he smokes. That money will inevitably become mine.

Grandma told me to listen to my father and come back safe. I had a moment of fog. Because at home Dad constantly tells Mum. 'Don't listen to what I say. Do what you want.' I answered politely. 'Yes.' I had no choice. Right now even raindrops have to be handled carefully.

In the afternoon I went to greet Hee-jeong's mum. She said 'Byeok please take good care of our Hee-jeong.' Hahahaha! That means she's recognising me as a son-in-law right? I answered confidently. 'Yes of course.' Hee-jeong smiled. I smiled too. And when we smile her mum smiles too.

It's already August. I'm happy.

CHAPTER 6

August

Mongolian Soy Sauce Again

Monday, 1st August

Arrived in Paris. In Seoul it's already 2 August but in Paris it's still 1 August. The fact that the four of us. Dad, Hee-jeong's dad, Hee-jeong and me. Made it all the way to our Paris flat can only be explained by God's protection. And if there's anything else it would be God's infinite love. My faith spontaneous as it is is getting deeper by the hour.

06.00 Wake up on my own. I spend the night having nightmares about the plane crashing. I doze on and off.

07.00 Dad shakes me awake. I jolt upright. He asks why I didn't sleep in the bed but on the floor. I can't say 'because I get travel-sick' so I answer. 'Just because.'

07.05 Check the weather. What if because of the rain the plane can't take off? Mum says planes take off even with thunder and lightning. I say if there's thunder and lightning it would be better if planes didn't take off.

07.20 Hee-jeong calls to make sure we're up.

07.30 Proper breakfast. Might be the last time I eat 'Korean-style'.

08.00 Leave for Hee-jeong's. Mum drives us.

08.25 Arrive at Hee-jeong's. Since we all know we can't leave until her dad finally comes out of the toilet we wait calmly. Her older brother wishes us a good trip and goes off to the study room. I feel a bit guilty. Then I forget. Mum tells Hee-jeong to take good care 'of the men'. I've been bundled as a set with them.

08.30 Mum goes to work.

08.45 Hee-jeong's mum yells at her husband to get out of the toilet or we'll be late.

08.48 GPS. Hee-jeong's dad has left his handbag at home. Passport and tickets are inside so Hee-jeong and I run back for it.

09.05 Finally leave for Incheon International Airport. Hee-jeong's mum grumbles. 'We're going to miss the plane!'

09.20 She drives at 60 km/h. I begin to doubt we are genuinely going to Paris today.

10.25 Arrive at ICN. Peak season. The airport is overflowing.

10.55 Get boarding passes and check in baggage. Dad has only one book in his little bag.

Places in Paris. I have only my phone in my pocket. Hee-jeong manages her father.

11.10 The security line is endless and it doesn't shrink.

11.25 Passport control. Dad registers us for the fast-track machine. We pass without queueing.

But I'm a bit disappointed. No stamp in the passport. Dad says we'll get a stamp on entry to France and I calm down instantly. Today Dad looks oddly seasoned.

11.30 Hee-jeong looks at my passport photo and says I'm handsome. I think she's joking because she's in a good mood.

11.35 Duty-free circuit. The two dads stare slack-jawed at the alcohol. I can't buy anything. It's too expensive. Hee-jeong buys nothing either.

11.55 Dad lingers by the cigarettes. The moment I pull out my phone to photograph him he gives up. Next time I'll have to do it secretly. Paparazzi fee or Dad's health. That is the question.

12.00 Wait at the gate. The plane is enormous. I can't believe something like that can fly.

12.30 Gate opens.

12.40 Boarding complete.

13.05 Scheduled departure but we don't depart. Thunder and lightning. My whole body tightens. I'm rigid as wood.

13.25 Captain announces there are too many aircraft in Chinese airspace and we're waiting. Dad says. 'Then we can just go via India.' People around us laugh. I'd like to laugh too but I'm so stiff nothing comes out.

13.35 Hee-jeong asks if anything hurts. I say no.

13.50 Captain says we'll take off in fifteen minutes.

13.55 Hee-jeong's dad complains he's hungry. Suddenly I'm hungry too.

14.05 Take-off. Ears clog. I swallow. I cover my face with a magazine. Hee-jeong takes my hand. It barely helps. I learn that I too have a fear of flying.

14.20 Seatbelt sign off. Tribute to the Wright brothers!

15.00 Meal. Bibimbap. Hee-jeong's dad asks for an extra heated rice. The flight attendant brings it. Then Dad asks for an extra rice too. They look like bears preparing to hibernate.

16.45 Turbulence. The plane shakes violently.

19.30 Hee-jeong wakes me. 'Eat something.'

20.00 Set my phone to Paris time. Because of daylight saving it's seven hours behind. Paris, 13.00.

15.00 (Paris time) Captain announces we're over Moscow. I wake with a start. Who exactly asked?

15.40 Hee-jeong gets up too. Three more hours and we arrive. Dad gets up washes his face brushes his teeth. He looks like someone who flies a lot. Yet I've never seen him go on a business trip... Is he an undercover spy disguised as a programmer?

16.00 Hee-jeong's dad wakes and goes into the toilet.

16.15 A flight attendant knocks on the toilet door. Maybe she's worried about an incident. Hee-jeong tells her it's 'an occupational illness'. The flight attendant can't hold back her laughter. Hee-jeong says she's going to file a complaint with the airline.

17.00 Still an hour before landing but everyone's already standing ready to bolt. If you handed them parachutes they'd jump immediately.

18.05 Landing announcement. The attendants force people back into their seats. There is always someone who never obeys and keeps wandering.

18.25 Safe landing. I discover what psychological stability feels like when both feet finally touch the ground.

18.30 Dad and I handle the luggage. Hee-jeong handles her father.

18.45 Entering France is almost nothing. Stamp and you're through.

18.50 Hee-jeong's dad disappears. Dad goes looking for him in the men's toilets.

18.55 Hee-jeong tells him he should warn us before wandering off. He says he was too desperate. He doesn't apologise. Not once.

19.05 Our bags still haven't appeared.

19.15 Finally retrieve the suitcases.

19.20 The two dads start discussing how to get to the flat. They could have discussed this on the plane. Honestly.

19.35 Decision. Roissybus to Opéra then taxi to the flat.

19.40 We can't find the Roissybus stop. Dad goes to the information desk and asks in very clear Korean. 'Where do we take the Roissybus?' Hee-jeong and I stand there with our

mouths open. And unbelievably a blonde French woman points the way using gestures. I think. Thank goodness we've met a French woman who knows Korean.

19.45 Dad asks a cleaner still in Korean. 'Is this where you take the Roissybus?' And even more unbelievably the man replies. 'Oui. Oui. Yes. Yes.' Hee-jeong laughs, I laugh, Dad laughs, Hee-jeong's dad laughs. We all laugh until our stomachs hurt. My father that fox.

19.55 The bus doesn't come. We wait with the blonde ladies.

20.05 Still no bus. The waiting group grows to about ten.

20.15 Hee-jeong's dad says we'll be too late. Let's take a taxi. We agree.

20.20 Walking towards the taxi rank. The Roissybus arrives. A violent moment of indecision. But Hee-jeong's dad decides. 'Taxi. Taxi's quicker.' We were properly stitched up. It's his first time in Paris. We regret listening to him immediately.

20.21 The taxi queue is monstrous. I write it into my brain. Never listen to Hee-jeong's dad again.

20.30 Finally get into a taxi. Dad says something to the driver. It is definitely not Korean. Dad sits in front.

20.35 Dad explains that in Paris even if there are only three passengers you can't necessarily sit in front. You need the driver's permission. Hee-jeong is stunned. So am I.

21.30 Paris appears. Hee-jeong and I look at each other and smile. It's still light as if the sun is refusing to set. I feel like I'm stepping into *Amélie*.

21.55 The big red gate in front of our building. We've arrived. The driver receives a generous tip.

22.00 In Seoul it's 5 a.m.

We lug the bags up and quietly tour the flat. It's small and narrow but warm. What impresses me most are the solid wooden pillars. Even the ceiling beams are exposed. It looks

like a house that's been standing for centuries. Nothing like our concrete apartment blocks in Seoul.

I share the largest room with Dad. Hee-jeong's dad and Hee-jeong each take a tiny room. Or rather room. They're the size of cupboards.

We did nothing in Paris and yet the first day is already over. Time stop it.

Tuesday, 2nd August

According to our original schedule today was the Louvre. But we missed the Louvre because we slept in too late. When I open my eyes it's 10.30. Only Dad got up early. He says he went out alone to look around as far as Goncourt and République stations. By the time Hee-jeong's dad finally emerges from the toilet it's the perfect time for lunch. At least we saved a meal.

'Five minutes from here there's a good restaurant. Let's eat there.'

'Oh yes? You said this is your second time in Paris? Or the third?'

'Second. But it was ages ago. I don't remember clearly.'

'Dad you'd been to Paris before? Why didn't you ever say?' I ask appalled.

'You didn't know? I thought you knew.'

'We didn't know.' Hee-jeong adds.

'You were babies when we came. I never had the chance to talk about it.'

And it's true. It hasn't been that long since Dad and I started having real conversations. When he was working I hardly ever saw his face.

'Look. You see Hôtel du Nord?'

'Hôtel du Nord. Isn't that the *Hôtel du Nord*?'

'Yes. There's the book and the film too.'

'Yes. I remember. I saw it a long time ago at an arthouse cinema.' Hee-jeong's dad lights up. 'So that's Hôtel du Nord. Incredible this place still exists.'

‘I didn’t know either but in the book Uncle lent me there’s a passage about it. Apparently it’s not a hotel anymore. Just a restaurant.’

‘That’s astonishing. Truly astonishing.’

‘I think I glimpsed it once walking along the Canal Saint-Martin. Back then I looked at it without thinking. But this morning I searched for it on purpose. It’s just behind our flat.’

‘Dad. That’s the Canal Saint-Martin?’

‘Yes. That’s the Canal Saint-Martin.’

‘Waaah!’ Hee-jeong and I shout at the same time.

‘Don’t tell me you were imagining the Panama Canal.’ Dad says laughing.

Hee-jeong and I glance at each other. The smile rises again. Found it. Canal Saint-Martin.

After a French lunch that’s a bit greasy and heavy we walk along the canal. Canal Saint-Martin is really tiny. Crossing from one side to the other takes less than thirty seconds. It’s impossible to tell where Amélie skipped stones. It all looks the same. But it doesn’t matter. We’re walking along Canal Saint-Martin. The two dads are affectionate like old friends. My father. I don’t understand him.

Dad says it’s the first day we shouldn’t push ourselves. Let’s just see a few things. Museums should be early morning otherwise you can’t get in because of queues. So we go to the Eiffel Tower. According to our schedule the nearest station was Bir-Hakeim. But Dad takes us to Trocadéro. Hee-jeong and I follow anxiously. We come out of the metro. The Eiffel Tower is suddenly there right in front of us. Dad was right. You could almost touch it. But there are too many people. Hee-jeong takes my hand. I squeeze hard. Not ‘for anything’. Just so I don’t lose her in the crowd. Hee-jeong’s mum asked me didn’t she? ‘Please take good care of our Hee-jeong.’

‘Do you like boats? Right next door is the Maritime Museum. Not too crowded and it’s really good.’

‘Dad that’s in our plan in two days...’

‘Is it? Then since we’re here we’ll go.’

Our schedule starts to derail. Hee-jeong and I decide to trust Dad.

The Maritime Museum is incredible. There are even life-size boats. Sailing ships, submarines, aircraft carriers and warships as models. Many are bigger than me. In one corner there’s a model-making workshop visible behind glass.

Dad explains one model. How they transported an obelisk from Egypt.

‘But wasn’t the obelisk a gift from Egypt? I think I heard that...’

‘The French say Champollion deciphered hieroglyphs and Egypt offered it as a commemoration. That’s the French version. I’d like to hear what Egyptians themselves would say.’

‘Yes. France and Britain grew rich by looting cultural property.’

Suddenly our trip turns cultured. These dad-to-dad conversations are unexpected.

And in this museum where there’s almost no one Hee-jeong still doesn’t let go of my hand.

Wednesday, 3rd August

With rice and banchan we bought yesterday at a Korean grocery near Opéra we make a simple breakfast. Hee-jeong’s dad sang all evening that after only one day he already wanted Korean food. Today he says he’s going to buy jokbal to eat. Ugh. Jokbal. Here it’s Paris. Paris.

Because Hee-jeong's dad spent thirty minutes in the toilet we give up on the Louvre again. Dad says the first Sunday of every month entry is free so we'll go on 7 August. I don't know when he prepared all this.

Because of the rain the streets are wet. Dried dog poo dissolves in the water and runs. The whole city smells of dog shit. Sometimes there's even human shit mixed in. Paris city of flowing shit. Unforgettable impression. And yet even in the rain homeless people sleep outside without seeking shelter. Hee-jeong gives a coin to every homeless person she sees. In Paris it feels like there's one every hundred metres.

Today we went to Montmartre. We also stopped by the café from *Amélie*. There were lots of Japanese women. Unlike the film there was no cigarette stand.

From the top of Montmartre I looked at Paris. No tall buildings. The view is open. On the way down we saw the sculpture The Man Who Walks Through Walls. I thought it looked more like 'the man stuck in the wall'.

Hee-jeong's dad wanted to pass by Montmartre Cemetery. François Truffaut's grave is there. Our schedule gets pushed to the side.

Hee-jeong's dad makes an icy joke. Truffaut like Romeo and Juliet isn't 'two people'. In the August sun we shiver. He says he dreamed of being a director but his family opposed it strongly. The two dads talk about Truffaut for a long time. I understand nothing. So Hee-jeong and I wander the cemetery holding hands. A cemetery in the middle of the city is strange. The coexistence of the living and the dead unsettles me.

And in that huge cemetery I find a familiar name. Berlioz. Of course I've never listened to his music. I only know the name. And obviously I can't remember where I heard it.

Thursday, 4th August

Mum calls to check the 'no smoking' clause. I report Dad hasn't smoked. Mum says when we get back she'll demand a health check for insurance. If he smokes even a single cigarette he fails and his sabbatical year is over. Dad darkens.

Today it didn't rain. But there are lots of clouds. Nothing like Seoul's sky. Here the clouds are low thick soft.

Hee-jeong says. 'These clouds look like a Magritte painting.'

Ugh. Who is Magritte?

Fourth day in Paris. I already feel like a Parisian. Foreigners no longer feel foreign. This morning we went to the Musée d'Orsay. On the top floor we saw the Impressionists. What can I say?

I liked Degas. I like his crooked framing. Hee-jeong stood for a long time in front of Van Gogh. She says her favourite is The Siesta. Eventually I came to prefer Van Gogh to Degas. And I decided. My favourite painting will also be The Siesta.

In a Manet who is that beautiful woman with thick eyebrows? She looks like Hee-jeong.

Friday, 5th August

Dad and Hee-jeong's dad say. 'Today we'll do a bit of walking.' As if we aren't already walking daily until our feet blister. What does 'a bit of walking' mean? I understood last night when they drank two bottles of wine with jokbal. Their chatter drove me mad.

We take an overground metro and get off at Corvisart. Then we follow Dad. Up a slope past a playground down a street with odd engravings painted on the walls. Dad talks nonstop about the Paris Commune, exile and bloody massacre. Hee-jeong and I don't understand adult stories. But I like this quiet lane. No tourists no crowds. The place is called Butte-aux-Cailles. An island within Paris. Yesterday we were on Île de la Cité and Île Saint-

Louis. They didn't feel like islands. Too many people you can barely move queues everywhere so in the end you do nothing.

When the sun gets strong the two dads want 'a beer'. They step into a tiny pub Le Diamant on the corner of an even tinier square. Hee-jeong's dad orders a Guinness. No Guinness. So they drink whatever draught the pot-bellied owner recommends looking disappointed.

Peaceful afternoon. We did well to flee the tourists.

But then. Arc de Triomphe, Champs-Élysées, Montparnasse, Pompidou, Saint-Ouen flea market, Orangerie and Rodin. When are we going? There aren't many days left.

Red alert.

Saturday, 6th August

Hee-jeong who loved Butte-aux-Cailles asks my dad where we're going today. Unbelievable. Even Hee-jeong betrays me.

Dad says. 'Today. La Santé Prison.'

Prison? Who's locked up there? Are we breaking someone out? And what about the Champs-Élysées?!

La Santé Prison is very impressive. A prison in the middle of the city with walls so high. Luckily near the wall there are several temporary public toilets. Hee-jeong's dad looks for a toilet at any hour. French food must be destroying his stomach. I take a photo of the prison and a man on the street gestures 'no' as if it's forbidden. It must be a no-photo zone.

From the prison we walk to Montparnasse Cemetery. We don't go up Montparnasse Tower. Dad says in Seoul we have towers everywhere. But the cemetery has Sartre.

At Montparnasse we meet several famous dead people. Dad explains in detail but I know almost no one. Sartre, Beauvoir, Serge Gainsbourg, Jean Seberg and Baudelaire 'the

poet with the softest name' but apparently his poems are frightening. I'll decide to read them in Seoul.

In front of Jean Seberg's grave Hee-jeong's dad looks like a man reuniting with an old love. And he says to my dad. 'Tonight a drink?'

As if he didn't drink yesterday.

Sunday, 7th August

If my friends ask what we saw in Paris I'll have to answer. 'a prison, cemeteries and hills.'

Total catastrophe. Aaah.

Fortunately today we went to the Louvre. Even if Hee-jeong's dad keeps repeating 'looted treasures' beautiful is beautiful.

06.00 Wake up. Dad tells Hee-jeong's dad to go to the toilet first.

06.30 The moment he comes out we each take turns showering.

07.25 Breakfast ready. We set only three portions. For Hee-jeong's dad breakfast forbidden.

07.45 Meal finished.

07.55 Washing up done.

08.00 Leave for the Louvre.

08.35 Arrive. Dad doesn't go towards the entrance by the Arc du Carrousel. He takes us somewhere 'odd'. There are hardly any people. Over at the Arc du Carrousel it's already a human tide.

09.00 Enter. Over there the queue stretches for hundreds of metres. Dad makes a V-sign with his right hand. Hee-jeong bursts out laughing. So do I.

09.10 Hee-jeong's dad goes into the toilet.

09.25 He comes out.

09.30 Hee-jeong sets a rendezvous. Everyone visits as they like. We meet at 12:30. Everyone agrees. Hee-jeong and I go to Denon Wing, Hee-jeong's dad to Sully and Dad to Richelieu.

09.35 So I won't be separated from Hee-jeong I take her hand first. Also because of her mum's request...

10.15 Wonder after wonder. In front of Michelangelo's *Rebellious Slave* and *Dying Slave* I'm speechless. The *Dying Slave*, could he not put on a bit of clothing? It's awkward in front of Hee-jeong. *Psyche and Cupid* kissing. Awkward too. My hands sweat.

10.25 *Winged Victory of Samothrace*. I flinch. It's enormous. A Chinese man touches it for a photo. Panic. The guard shouts 'S'il vous plaît!' but the man pretends not to understand and continues.

10.27 The guard finally roars 'S'IL VOUS PLAÎT!' and only then does he stop. And in the motion the guard's wig falls on the floor.

10.30 The guard puts his wig back on.

11.25 *Mona Lisa*. You can barely see her from a hundred metres away. Next to her another Leonardo portrait. A woman who isn't smiling. No one looks at her. Up close she has a truly unpleasant face.

11.55 My soles hurt. Paintings all of it. I just want a chair. But the chairs are monopolised by men with prominent bellies. Hee-jeong and I sit on the floor in a corner. I put down my handkerchief so Hee-jeong can sit.

12.15 We've seen everything we can. The paintings even begin to bore me.

12.30 Go to the meeting point. Nobody. We assume the two dads are lost. We search everywhere.

12.45 They're sitting in the café. And they ask why we're 'so late'. Honestly.

13.00 Light lunch at the museum café.

13.30 Hee-jeong and I head off again. The dads say. 'We'll take it easy. You go see what you want. Come back to the café.'

14.05 Egyptian department.

15.15 After Egypt I feel like becoming a mummy. My legs are numb.

15.55 We get lost. We keep landing in French classical painting. French landscapes. Saturation.

16.05 Everywhere men half-collapsed. Everywhere you can lean men with bellies already installed. Long benches occupied by ladies.

16.30 End room. Dead end. There a strange painting. A Pierrot with an unfunny face by Watteau. Hee-jeong half emptied stares at it. So do I. Hee-jeong photographs it. It was an adorable painting.

16.55 Return to the café. The two dads haven't moved an inch.

17.15 At the Korean grocery near the Louvre we buy a mountain of jokbal, sashimi, etc.

17.20 I say. 'Let's take a taxi.' Dad. 'A taxi for such a short distance?' The dads rested all day in the café so their feet don't hurt. Ours do. Dad refuses.

17.25 Hee-jeong tells Dad she wants a taxi.

18.05 Taxi. Arrive home.

After dinner I ask Dad. 'When are we doing a Seine cruise?' Dad replies. 'Byeok do Seoul people take a boat on the Han River?'

'No. So what?'

'You think Parisians take tourist boats?'

'But we aren't Parisians.'

'Exactly. It's a thing for bumpkins.'

Strategic retreat. I'll ask Hee-jeong later. Dad listens to Hee-jeong better than he listens to me.

Monday, 8th August

Hee-jeong's dad says the accumulated fatigue is too much and we should rest all day. What! After already resting all day yesterday at the Louvre he wants to rest again? We ate lunch at Hôtel du Nord then Hee-jeong's dad went back to the flat. Dad Hee-jeong and I went out for a walk. Hee-jeong's dad told us to come back before sunset. But in Paris in summer the sun is endless. It doesn't start getting dark until after ten p.m. So does he mean we should come back or that we shouldn't come back?

Walking along Canal Saint-Martin we saw a boat cross it. It moved so slowly it looked as if it would take days to cover the canal.

We followed Dad from Goncourt station towards the 'Chinese quarter'. Truly just as the Korean students said this place looked like an exhibition of human races. From Arabs to Chinese. People of all kinds lived there dressed in a thousand different ways. The market looked like a traditional market in Seoul. What struck me though was the number of men sprawled in cafés all day. Don't they work? Or do their wives earn the money? Strange people.

Dad suggested we go into a café for coffee.

Tuesday, 9th August

Red alert. I scraped my ankle on a rusty nail and had to get three stitches. We were supposed to go to the Musée de Cluny today but I slipped heavily on an enormous amount of freshly deposited dog poo. As I slid my ankle hit a nail sticking out of an abandoned chair. Hee-jeong's dad looked at the wound and said it wasn't deep but it would be best to get a tetanus jab.

Thanks to the help of a kind Arab man we were able to go straight to the emergency department at Hôtel-Dieu Hospital near Notre-Dame around Saint-Germain. Without him we would probably have wandered for ages before finding the hospital.

Luckily this Arab man had seen with his own eyes me slipping on dog poo and then impaling my ankle on the nail so he could explain everything in detail to the doctor. The doctor looked at the wound and said it was nothing then asked me to wait. Wait? When life and death are at stake? I wonder if he really has a medical degree.

Dad tried to thank the Arab man by offering him something but he refused politely. While I waited in the waiting room Hee-jeong held my hand firmly. In truth I was so shocked I couldn't even feel the pain in my ankle yet.

Eventually the doctor put me in a wheelchair and took me to the treatment room. Hee-jeong's dad came in with me. I got a tetanus injection and three stitches. The doctor said that fortunately there was no danger to my life. We left the hospital with a simple prescription for disinfectant. Seeing me limp out Dad called me 'dog poo'. Ugh. While I was being stitched Hee-jeong carefully cleaned my shoes covered in dog poo.

My ankle throbbed so much I said we had to take a taxi but Dad told me to stop being precious. Luckily Hee-jeong's dad managed to catch a taxi and we returned comfortably to the flat. At home Hee-jeong looked after me. In the end getting injured may not be entirely bad.

But today we didn't pay the hospital bill. I'm afraid I'll be arrested at the airport.

Wednesday, 10th August

We've already been in Paris ten days and so far we've visited frightening prisons, depressing cemeteries, quiet hills and hospitals reeking of alcohol. Yes, we saw the Louvre and Orsay but this trip feels unreal as if we're under a spell. And now I have to walk with a limp. The overall look is miserable.

Today I really wanted to do something meaningful. Something that resembles an actual trip. For example admire the Eiffel Tower at night or take a Seine cruise. Or at least go up the Arc de Triomphe and walk hand in hand with Hee-jeong along the Champs-Élysées.

But Hee-jeong's dad had severe diarrhoea and couldn't go out. After taking the emergency anti-diarrhoea medicine he'd brought it finally calmed down.

Hee-jeong and I walked along Canal Saint-Martin. Canal Saint-Martin. I'm sick of it now.

Thursday, 11th August

It's our last day in Paris. Since Hee-jeong's dad was better early in the morning we climbed the Arc de Triomphe walked the Champs-Élysées and took a Seine cruise. But contrary to my expectations everything was rather ordinary. I already missed the quiet lanes of Butte-aux-Cailles. Walking along the high walls of La Santé Prison felt more pleasant. In the afternoon we saw Monet's large canvases at the Orangerie. Monet looks as if he had a white veil over his eyes. Why are his paintings so blurry? Napoleon said everything great is beautiful didn't he? In any case the paintings were big.

To see the Eiffel Tower lit up we ate dinner at home before going out. It was our first evening without alcohol. And we finally understood why we'd never seen Paris at night until now.

We got off at Trocadéro to see the Eiffel Tower at night. In the packed crowd we barely managed to take one souvenir photo. Then we saw the night view of the Champs-Élysées once more from the Arc de Triomphe. Still I kept thinking about the quiet alleyways of Butte-aux-Cailles.

'It's too crowded. I don't like it. Do you?' Hee-jeong said.

'Yes. Me too. I prefer Butte-aux-Cailles.'

'Me too. I like the wall of La Santé Prison or Montparnasse Cemetery better.'

'Isn't that strange?'

'Your dad seems to really know things.'

On the way back Hee-jeong's dad bought two bottles of a grand cru. How could you spend the last night in Paris without alcohol?

Friday, 12th August

My head hurts from the hangover. Hee-jeong's dad offered a glass of wine to his future son-in-law. I had trouble refusing my future father-in-law's request so I drank it in one go. After that I remember nothing. I hope I didn't do anything stupid... But why is Hee-jeong who drank with me completely fine? She must be more resistant to alcohol. Family trait presumably.

Dad accompanied us to the airport. Since I didn't know what to say as I left him I shouted 'Don't smoke!' Dad smiled a bit awkward. What is he thinking? I realise I don't really know my father.

Fortunately nobody mentioned the Hôtel-Dieu bill at exit control. The officer looked totally uninterested in his job. After all where's the joy in stamping passports all day?

At the Charles de Gaulle duty-free shop I bought a pen set and a keyring shaped like the Eiffel Tower. Hee-jeong's dad bought her a white sweater she can wear in autumn as a souvenir of Paris. Hee-jeong held the sweater against her chest and asked if it was pretty. Of course it is.

So our Paris trip ended. But Aunt Jeong-su isn't going to propose a maths lesson tomorrow is she? Please.

Saturday, 13th August

I'm too tired to write anything. Because of the time difference I can't even sleep. And the sky is overcast. My whole body feels heavy and sore.

Sunday, 14th August

Mum told me to go and greet Grandpa and Grandma. Grandma saw my ankle and stroked my head saying, 'My little puppy you had a hard time didn't you.' Grandpa asked what I liked most. I answered the quiet time on that hill called Butte-aux-Cailles. Warm light and a silence as if time had stopped. More than the famous tourist-packed places of Paris that spot is what stayed somewhere deep inside me.

In my room I was sorting the Paris metro tickets museum stubs and so on when Dong-wan called. He asked how Paris was. I only said 'It was good.' I couldn't tell him about Paris's prisons, cemeteries, hills, the running dog poo, the homeless people and the gloomy hospital. Those kinds of stories have to be told slowly face to face.

On my way back after greeting Aunt Jeong-su and Uncle I stopped by Hee-jeong's. Her mum welcomed me warmly. Her older brother wasn't there. He must have gone to study. Hee-jeong said she'd suffered the time difference all day yesterday too. If it hadn't rained she would've gone cycling on the Han River...

We spent time flipping through Impressionist art books. Seeing reproductions of paintings we'd seen in real life felt strange. And Hee-jeong said 'The paintings we saw at Orsay were in 3D but in the books they're 2D.' Listening to her the images looked a bit flat.

Soon it's the new term. Aaah.

Monday, 15th August (Liberation Day)

Without Liberation Day today would have been the first day back at school wouldn't it. I applaud warmly Korea's independence on 15 August 1945. A day so important and full of meaning should become a three-day weekend. Well if that's too long two days would do.

Dong-wan and Jong-gu came to my place. Dong-wan had spent two weeks in Mongolia and Jong-gu had had fun at English camp with Hye-seon. I told them about Paris. The prisons, cemeteries, hills, dog poo, homeless people and the hospital. Of course I told

them about the Louvre and Orsay too. But these idiots had no interest in my serious Paris story. They kept asking whether I'd kissed Hee-jeong.

I need friends at my level.

Tuesday, 16th August

First day back. Obviously Hee-jeong's and my Paris trip is the topic. The boys surrounded me and the girls surrounded Hee-jeong. I explained with dignity that my dad and Hee-jeong's dad were senior and junior from the same university. They were travelling together and by a twist of fate Hee-jeong and I came along. It sounded slightly off but it wasn't a complete lie was it? But they were only interested in one thing. Whether I kissed Hee-jeong in Paris. Honestly. That's a secret. There's the dignity of a young lady isn't there. Do you think I'm going to shout it everywhere you morons?

On the way home after school Jong-gu pushed Dong-wan to run for class representative.

'Dong-wan do it this time. You'd make a good rep.'

And miracle. The words 'bloody' and 'proper' and swearing had disappeared from Jong-gu's mouth.

'Hey Lee Jong-gu. You don't swear anymore?' I asked.

'Yeah. Hye-seon kept lecturing me at English camp so I decided to stop.'

'Oh yeah?'

'Even without swear words we understand each other perfectly.'

'Well done Lee Jong-gu.' I said 'And Dong-wan you really should run. You're popular.'

'I'm not very confident...' Dong-wan said.

'Why?' Jong-gu asked.

‘Because. I’m only half Korean.’

Dong-wan’s face darkened a little.

‘Hey what does ‘half’ even mean? Nobody even calls you Mongolian soy sauce anymore. You’re fine.’ Jong-gu insisted.

Dong-wan said he’d talk to his parents.

I’d never known Dong-wan thought of himself as ‘half Korean’. I thought I knew him well. Apparently I don’t. People don’t easily show what they carry inside. I’ll have to ask Hee-jeong what she thinks. Dong-wan as class rep. What would that look like?

Wednesday, 17th August

Hee-jeong says Dong-wan would be a good class rep. And he’s popular with the girls. Only Dong-wan doesn’t realise it.

Hee-jeong herself had been elected deputy rep last term and she did it unwillingly. She says she doesn’t want to wear that kind of ‘decoration’ anymore. Instead she wants to study more with me.

Exactly. Then why am I not running?

Thursday, 18th August

Pushed by Jong-gu Dong-wan finally entered as a candidate. Jong-gu and Hee-jeong endorsed him. I’m Dong-wan’s desk neighbour so I deliberately didn’t put myself among the endorsers. Shin Bo-ram and Yoo Ha-neul ran too. And at the very last minute Cheol-uk—nice boy—was nominated and ran as well. Surprising. Cheol-uk is introverted. He isn’t particularly good in class nor particularly good at sports. And yet people like him. Hee-jeong says Cheol-uk listens very well to other people. That’s why the girls like him.

Anyway the election is next Wednesday. In my opinion Dong-wan will win by a landslide. But Cheol-uk is a variable. We can't relax.

I studied maths for the first time in ages. But the formulas felt so alien. As if I was seeing them for the first time. Catastrophe. Aunt Jeong-su said she'll test us on Saturday on everything we learned.

Friday, 19th August

Since this morning diarrhoea. I didn't eat anything strange but my stomach hurt. The moment I got to school I ran to the toilets. And there I heard a strange conversation.

'Hey you know the Mongolian soy sauce from Class 3 is running?'

'Yeah it's well funny isn't it?'

'Proper. He's good at studying good at sport sure but bloody hell... still... how can a Mongolian soy sauce be class rep?'

'Ah bloody hell it's not even funny seriously.'

'And what next? After that the 'Vietcong' in Class 1 runs for student council?'

'The kids in Class 3 are pathetic. Seriously haven't they got anyone else?'

It was as if I'd swallowed ten anti-diarrhoea tablets. Everything stopped at once. I tried to see who was speaking through the gap in the stall door but I only saw the backs of heads. When I finished and opened the door they'd disappeared. Disgusting blokes. But I didn't tell anyone. Because in our class there isn't anyone that nasty.

Saturday, 20th August

Thanks to the maths i studied late last night I barely passed Aunt Jeong-su's test. She said from now on we'll move to a harder workbook. Hee-jeong praised me. 'You worked hard.' These days life has flavour again.

I also had a good time with Mr Jamie for the first time in ages. I told him my bizarre experiences in Paris. He said that rather than only going where everyone goes finding a place of your own that stays in your heart—that is also the pleasure of travel. Thinking about it Butte-aux-Cailles might be exactly my place.

I told him I'd been in a wheelchair in Paris. That I'd been scared. He told me to be careful so I never get back on one again. Once is enough. You must never return. Yes sir.

From next week Hee-jeong will also study English with Mr Jamie. She saw me stammer out a few sentences and decided she'd learn with him too. Good. When I study maths Hee-jeong studies English. When I study English Hee-jeong studies maths. We are a perfect duo.

But once we're back in Korea I no longer have a chance to hold her hand!

Sunday, 21st August

Since Dad isn't here all the little household chores are mine. After breakfast I was sorting recycling to take out when Mr Sisina greeted me.

'Byeok you're back from Paris?'

'Hello sir.' I said smiling. 'Yes It was good.'

'Well done. I heard there are many Sri Lankans in Paris too. I'd like to go one day.'

'Yes you should. In Paris there are many Black people, many Asians and many Arabs.

Near where we stayed there were hardly any French.'

'The French may have all gone on holiday?'

'Oh is that possible?'

'How would I know?' He burst into bright laughter.

Mr Sisina always has a smile at the corner of his mouth. What can possibly make him so cheerful?

Then he asked ‘Byeok is there a bus from here to Guro? Direct?’

‘A bus? The metro is fast—you’ll be there quickly.’

‘I didn’t ask the metro. Do you know the bus number?’

‘Take the metro. It’s only a few stops.’

‘Yes but I don’t really like the metro...’ His smile vanished.

‘Why?’ I asked.

‘When I take the metro people move away from me. That... that does something to me.’ His face darkened.

‘I’m sorry sir.’ I said without thinking as if I should apologise.

‘You—why? It’s fine. Don’t worry.’ The smile came back softly.

‘Wait a moment. I’ll ask Mum the bus number to Guro.’

‘No no. It’s fine. I’ll take the metro.’ He stopped me. ‘See you.’ And he hurried out of the alley.

I didn’t feel well. The nasty men insulting Dong-wan in the toilets a few days ago flashed through my mind. And that very brief shadow that had passed over Mr Sisina’s face stayed in my heart.

Monday, 22nd August

It’s hot and yet Jong-gu and Hye-seon are still holding hands. Aren’t they hot? Dong-wan says. ‘If you’re jealous you’ve already lost.’ Jealous me? Why would I be jealous!

This weekend should I suggest to Hee-jeong that we at least go to Namsan since Dobong-san is too far?

Tuesday, 23rd August

Hee-jeong says after the gifted maths class she argued with some girls. Some of them said 'How can a boy with Mongolian blood become class rep?' Hee-jeong too stunned asked what that had to do with anything. They said Dong-wan is good at studying popular sure but as class rep 'still it's impossible'. Hee-jeong asked what they meant and they said a Mongolian soy sauce as class rep is unthinkable.

Catastrophe. Maybe we were wrong to push Dong-wan to run.

Wednesday, 24th August

Cheol-uk became our class representative for the second term. Dong-wan got only six votes. So apart from our group of five only one person voted for Dong-wan. Dong-wan's face was dark. Jong-gu even apologised to him. But Dong-wan said it wasn't our fault. He even consoled us telling us not to worry too much. I don't know what to say to Dong-wan. I can't see a path. What do we do?

Thursday, 25th August

Cheol-uk ran the class meeting and did it very well. He isn't good in class he's introverted so I'd never really noticed him but today I saw him differently. Of course Dong-wan would also have been excellent as class rep.

Today I thought this. What if later Dong-wan became a judge? He would surely want to be fair and impartial. But wouldn't people discriminate against him even more saying Mongolian blood runs in him? On the other hand if Dong-wan became a mover a factory worker an ordinary employee he might face less discrimination. The more Dong-wan used his abilities the greater the discrimination would become. That's what I feel.

Why didn't our classmates recognise Dong-wan? Not long ago they begged him to explain hard maths problems they pleaded with him to play basketball. Why did they change?

I know Cheol-uk is kind and good but that doesn't give any reason to hate Dong-wan does it? If Dong-wan hadn't run would they still be treating him the same way as before? Nobody says it openly but I can feel the way people treat Dong-wan is no longer the same.

Then Mr Sisina—how hard must it be for him in Korea?

Friday, 26th August

After school there was a basketball match. Class 4 asked for a rematch because of the previous game. Dong-wan didn't play. Nobody suggested he play and he didn't look like he wanted to.

Of course we lost.

Saturday, 27th August

Dad called from Paris. He still seems to be hanging around weird parts of Paris. Last Sunday he says he went to the Paris racecourse. He suddenly wanted to see horses run. Yet in Seoul he'd never once set foot in a racecourse. Dad is strange. He must not have lost all the travel money on betting...

At bedtime I kept thinking about Dong-wan so I called him in the end. 'Dong-wan tomorrow—shall we cycle by the river?'

'I've got no energy.'

'Then... the cinema?'

'The cinema's crowded. I don't like it.'

'Pizza, burger?'

'It's fine... but sorry. If you don't want to go alone go with Hee-jeong. Not with me.'

This can't continue. Red alert. I have to find Dong-wan a girlfriend or something.

Sunday, 28th August

Eating breakfast alone with Mum feels strangely empty. It's like Mum doesn't even miss Dad.

I asked when Dad would come back. Mum replied 'How would I know?' What if Mum and Dad's marriage has a problem...? No. That can't be... can it?

Monday, 29th August

Since this morning I've been in a foul mood. Cheol-jin called Dong-wan Mongolian soy sauce so I put him in his place. This week Dong-wan and Cheol-jin are on classroom duty.

And Cheol-jin says to Dong-wan. 'Today the Mongolian soy sauce wipes the board.

Tomorrow I'll wipe.' The moment I heard it I shoved Cheol-jin against the wall and told him if he said that word even once more I'd beat him up. Cheol-jin got scared and avoided my eyes.

Something's wrong. I'm worried.

Tuesday, 30th August

Cheol-jin's mother came to school. The form tutor called me into the staff room and told me to apologize to Cheol-jin. I refused. I said it was Cheol-jin who should apologize to Dong-wan. Cheol-jin's mother screamed 'What kind of child acts like this!?' And I answered 'He's right there.' The teachers in the room stared at me stunned.

When I explained that Cheol-jin started it by calling Dong-wan Mongolian soy sauce the form tutor still said it was wrong to hit a classmate. So I said I hadn't hit him. But I added that if Cheol-jin kept lying next time I really would hit him. At that moment Cheol-jin's mother screamed even louder and tried to hit me. Without Mr Kim Su-yeong I don't know what would've happened.

From today I will never again call Mr Kim Su-yeong 'Ppagasari'.

Wednesday, 31st August

Hee-jeong told me I behaved well by not hitting Cheol-jin. If I'd hit him the situation would have got worse. In reality Cheol-jin's mother's intervention flipped the class atmosphere completely. Students whisper that Cheol-jin is a liar and a loser and that his mother stuck her nose in where it didn't belong. According to Hee-jeong our classmates praise me. They say I held to my convictions to defend a friend without backing down.

Thanks to Mr Kim Su-yeong whom we called 'Ppagasari' Cheol-jin's mother's madness calmed down and Cheol-jin finally had to apologize to Dong-wan. In our class nobody calls Dong-wan Mongolian soy sauce anymore.

But I'm still uneasy. I'm afraid of living with people who don't think like me. If Cheol-jin hadn't simply avoided my eyes and if he'd wanted to fight. What would have happened? Just thinking about it scares me. I might have ended up living with the whole class—no the whole school—as enemies.

All of a sudden I feel like I've become an adult. But this dark heavy mood. What is it? What is Dong-wan thinking right now? What did his mother say to him? And his father. What does he feel?

Tonight I miss Dad. Dad is probably on a train somewhere between Paris and Milan...

CHAPTER 7

September

The Sweater

Thursday, 1st September

September is an important month. It's Hee-jeong's birthday month. On 22 August it was exactly our hundredth day together but with the class-rep election I was so tied up that I let it pass. Luckily Hee-jeong doesn't seem to care much about that sort of anniversary. I rather like women who are broad-minded.

Still I'll have to make it up to her on her birthday. The question is. What should I give her?

Friday, 2nd September

On the way home Hee-jeong asked me very seriously whether I really liked her. Of course I said yes. In truth I wanted to say I loved her. But I was afraid of putting too much pressure on her, so I just said I liked her a lot. Then she hesitated for a moment and said 'So why did you let the hundred days go by?'

Alert.

Alert.

Alert.

Saturday, 3rd September

My chest hurts terribly. Near my nipple I can feel a small lump. What if it's a tumour? They say Wu Zixu in China went grey overnight. I feel like I've grown a massive tumour overnight. Is this how I die? I'm sorry Hee-jeong! Because of that blasted class election I forgot our precious hundred days...

After school Aunt Jeong-su made soybean noodles for lunch. As I picked at my food my uncle asked what was wrong. I said it was nothing. But true to his job as an editor and proofreader he wouldn't let it go. I finally confessed that my chest had hurt since yesterday. Hee-jeong burst out giggling. While I'd spent the night growing a tumour...

My uncle pressed my chest once then declared

'Your chest is growing. All boys go through this at puberty. Don't worry.'

'Really? It's not a tumour?' I asked.

My uncle laughed out loud. Aunt Jeong-su even spat out her noodles laughing. Tears welled up in Hee-jeong's eyes. Everyone was laughing so hard it looked like a collective facial spasm.

When I walked Hee-jeong home she gently took my hand. For her birthday I'll have to pluck the stars from the sky.

Sunday, 4th September

Dad is in Rome. I hope he isn't climbing the seven hills one by one. I wish he'd be back before Chuseok.

I took a book from his shelf called *The Double Helix*. Just seeing the title I thought it was about a mechanic making bolts and nuts. I'd mixed up helix with screw. Have I been reading so little lately that I've become dyslexic?

The Double Helix is really gripping. It's a bit shameful to admit but I enjoy this sort of gossip. And learning that the people who cracked DNA were such clumsy types surprised me. Scientists may not be that extraordinary after all.

Monday, 5th September

Barely back at school and we're already talking about midterm exams. Today the timetable came out.

- Wednesday, 21 September : Korean, Social Studies
- Thursday, 22 September : English, Science
- Friday, 23 September : Maths

Last term my science grades were disastrous. From today I've decided to study one hour a day. Watson and Crick managed it. So why not me?

Tuesday, 6th September

I underestimated science. I think I'm going to pay for that.

Wednesday, 7th September

I studied science at Hee-jeong's. Thanks to her I've at least learned the alphabet of science.

Thursday, 8th September

It's cooler in the mornings and evenings. The heat has eased. Hee-jeong's birthday is approaching but I have absolutely no pocket money. Isn't there a gift that's elegant and cheap at the same time?

Friday, 9th September

From tomorrow it's the Chuseok holiday but Dad is still in Rome. Yesterday he went to the Via Appia. One of those roads that supposedly all lead to Rome. In the photos he's very tanned. He looks healthy. And happy. When Dad is happy I am too.

What is he looking for over there? What is he seeing? I keep wondering.

I picked two books from his shelf just because I liked their titles. I opened them briefly then frightened put them back. One is called Jang Jeong-il's Reading Journal the other Reading Happily. Who are these people reading a book a day and then writing a review every time?

They must have committed some grave sin to deserve such cruel punishment. Better to stay well away from those books.

Saturday, 10th September

Unable to sleep at dawn I took out those two frightening books again. They're hard. I don't understand much but I at least grasped these two passages. I quote them here to boost the literary prestige of my diary.

Last year what I did with the greatest zeal was collect jazz CDs. In just over a year I bought more than 250 originals so I had less time to go to bookshops. But how happy my heart was! I was afraid of spending my life buying books I would never read. And

now an even more frightening ghost has appeared. Down with books! Let's collect a thousand records and open a jazz café!

(Reading Journal, Jang Jeong-il, 1 January 1994)

Whenever I reread my own writing I feel the distance between sentences is immense.

The silence between them grows more and more frightening.

(Reading Happily, Kim Hyun, 16 June 1986)

They say these days opening a café leads to bankruptcy. How can I warn Mr Jang Jeong-il? And if silence between sentences is frightening why not use conjunctions? I'd like to tell Mr Kim Hyun—if he were still alive...

Reading other people's diaries aloud in mine makes me feel strangely better.

Sunday, 11th September

Tomorrow is Chuseok. I went to Grandpa's to run errands which kept me busy all day. Mum was also very busy with Grandma preparing the holiday food. Now Mum is lying down saying she's exhausted. I offered to massage her shoulders but she refused. Mum has stamina of steel. She never complains. Between work and home it must be hard for her too.

Monday, 12th September (Chuseok)

Why isn't there gift money at Chuseok? I wish there were a tradition of ritual greetings too.

Because of our family's tight budget my love life is in a critical phase.

Grandpa tells me to wear the sweater he bought in Jeju now that mornings and evenings are cooler. But it's still a bit warm...

According to Grandma, Grandpa has discovered a hidden talent at dance class. He's extremely popular among the grandmas. Late-blooming passion for dance can be dangerous they say... I'm worried.

And now Grandpa has even bought a pair of white shoes!

Tuesday, 13th September

I don't know why this Chuseok feels so flat. It's probably because of midterms. Or maybe because Dad isn't here.

After sitting at my desk revising all morning my backside is on fire. Leaning against my bed I looked at the postcards I bought at the Musée d'Orsay. My favourite is Van Gogh's The Siesta. Every time I look at it I relax. Hee-jeong loved it too. We stood in front of it for a very long time at Orsay.

'Are you very tired?' I asked the man in the painting.

'Shh.' He lifts his hat and puts a finger to his lips. 'My wife is sleeping.'

'Sorry to disturb your rest.'

'Yes today the sun is perfect for a nap.' he murmurs leaning against the haystack.

'But have you chosen a gift for Hee-jeong?'

'Not yet.'

'There aren't many days left. What will you do?'

'That's the problem. I don't have much money and I don't even know what she really likes.'

'But you went with her to the Musée d'Orsay. Think carefully about what she likes.'

'Hm... She likes books, music and paintings. She's a good student but I don't think she truly likes studying.'

'And what else?' he whispers.

‘What else?’

‘She loves you.’

‘Yes I think so.’ I say smiling foolishly.

‘Don’t try to give her something expensive. Show her your heart.’

‘How?’

‘That’s for you to think about.’ He glances at his sleeping wife. ‘Women like jewellery of course but they like a man’s heart even more. If a woman is happier with jewellery than with your heart it’s better to leave her.’

‘When I heard you reading the other day your voice was nice.’ says the woman yawning—she must have woken up.

‘I’m sorry I disturbed you.’

‘You did disturb me. But it’s all right. Time to get up. Read her a book. Give her a book you love and read it to her.’

‘What book?’

‘That’s for you to think about.’ She taps her head.

‘Sherlock Holmes maybe?’

‘Better *Aesop’s Fables*! Aesop!’ the man laughs shaking his head.

A gust of wind rises. His hat flies into the sky. The man and woman run after the dancing hat. I start laughing.

‘Answer the phone—it’s Hee-jeong.’ Mum says shaking me.

Hee-jeong suggests that on 24 September after lessons at Aunt Jeong-su’s we have lunch together and go to the cinema.

Of course. It will be your birthday.

Wednesday, 14th September

Grandma is determined to quit dance class. She had a fierce row with Grandpa over those blasted white shoes. Yesterday he wore them to dance class and the grandmas wouldn't leave him alone. Since Grandpa seemed to enjoy it a little Grandma's mood flipped completely. She says now even when she goes to class she doesn't get a chance to dance with him. Grandpa spends over thirty minutes getting ready before going. I don't see the problem. Even when you're old it's good to stay smart. And white shoes are far more elegant than dull black ones.

When I said 'It's not Grandpa's fault he's stylish handsome and a good dancer. And it was Grandma who first suggested dance class.'

Mum replied 'You're still too young to understand.'

Too young? Really? I understand plenty of things too. Being old doesn't mean you know everything. I don't get why adults always judge by age.

Grandma is staying at our place now. Exams are next week. If my grades drop I'd like to say it's entirely Grandpa and Grandma's fault!

Thursday, 15th September

Grandpa has capitulated. He's decided to throw away those cursed white shoes. Honestly that was predictable. Without Grandma Grandpa would starve or drown in filth within days. He rarely eats anything but what Grandma makes. I've never seen him eat out. Dad says even when he was working he always carried his own lunch. And Grandpa changes his underwear two or three times a day. I know this directly from Grandma so it's reliable. If Grandma doesn't go home Grandpa's hygiene will go to red alert and he might die miserably. So it's not just white shoes—even glass slippers he'd throw them away.

It seems my fussiness is hereditary. I'm certain of it having read *The Double Helix* by James Watson.

Friday, 16th September

Grandpa and Grandma have signed up for the table tennis club. Table tennis carries love...

Poor grandmas from dance class.

Saturday, 17th September

Out of the maths problems Aunt Jeong-su gave us I missed only one. Aunt and Hee-jeong were surprised. So was I.

Aunt said 'Our Byeok takes after me—he's got a gift for maths.'

That remark is genetically very sound. I state it with confidence having read *The Double Helix* by James Watson.

'Good thing he doesn't take after his mum or he'd be hopeless at maths.' my uncle added.

'What? Mum was bad at maths?'

'Yes your mum was one of those who gave up maths.' Aunt said laughing.

Genetics really is a very opaque science.

Sunday, 18th September

A soft autumn rain falls.

When it stops the air will turn cooler.

I will wear the sweater Grandpa and Grandma bought.

Dead leaves will litter the streets.

And one corner of my heart will feel empty.

As the burning summer fades away

only the cold dreary autumn rain

soaks the road the air and my heart.

Monday, 19th September

Bloody autumn rain!

Stop it for a bit!

Tuesday, 20th September

By focusing so much on maths and science I've neglected Korean and social studies. Since I handle advanced Korean pretty well I should manage. As for social studies my class attitude was good so I'll probably scrape through.

Even telling myself that I'm still a bit worried.

Wednesday, 21st September

The morning temperature suddenly dropped to 12 degrees! I feel like my grades will drop just as sharply. Catastrophe.

- First day of exams -

- Korean. I don't understand why my grades don't rise when I speak Korean so fluently.
- Social studies. Out of respect for Mr Kim Su-yeong I think I did better than the class average.

Thursday, 22nd September

- Second day of exams -

- English. I've finally proved that English lessons with Uncle Jamie have absolutely nothing to do with school exams.

- Science. Not a satisfying mark but it's gone up a little.

Friday, 23rd September

- Third day of exam -

- Maths. What a strange catastrophe! From now on if someone asks which subject is easiest for me I'll have to answer. maths. Later when I'm a writer and someone asks 'You were good at Korean at school weren't you?' I'll reply 'No. I was good at the subject I hated most. maths.' It's a tragedy.

But exams are over. Let's set grades aside with panache. Tomorrow is finally Hee-jeong's birthday. Let's do our best!

Saturday, 24th September

I'm crushed. Hee-jeong has caught a cold. She also missed maths and English class today. As soon as lessons at Aunt Jeong-su's ended I called her. At first I couldn't even recognise her voice. She was so hoarse she sounded rough almost masculine. Strangely I found that voice very attractive.

She says we probably won't be able to meet today. She doesn't want to pass the flu to me. I don't mind at all. I wished her happy birthday on the phone.

Sunday, 25th September

As soon as I woke up I called Hee-jeong. Luckily her fever had gone down and her throat was a bit better. I swallowed breakfast in a hurry and ran to her place at the speed of light. Since it was a little cool I wore the black sweater Grandpa and Grandma had bought me. Hee-

jeong opened the door saying I might catch her cold by coming but I could see she was happy. I knew it.

Her mum said my sweater was really very black. Hee-jeong ran a hand along my sleeve and said it felt very soft. Then she came back from her room with a white sweater. The one her dad had bought her as a souvenir during our trip to Paris.

We sat on the living-room sofa drinking hot cocoa her mum had made. Her dad came out of the bedroom looked at us and said we looked like two cats. I liked that image. Two cats. How warm. A black cat and a white cat. I felt good. At least until he turned on the television and started answering every question on a quiz show wrongly. Hee-jeong's mum told us to go and play in her room. Perhaps she wanted to prevent paternal authority from being completely ruined by a total absence of correct answers. I'm used to it so it didn't bother me.

In her room I gave her the book I'd brought for her birthday. *Mr Sommer's Story* by Patrick Süskind. A beautiful tale with fresh watercolour illustrations. Leaning against the wall I began to read softly from the first page.

'In my old tree-climbing days – a long time ago now, many many years have passed since then, I was just over three foot four, my shoe size was a child's ten, and I was so light I could fly – no, that's no exaggeration, I really could fly – or nearly, or let's say it was within my power to fly, if only I'd put my mind to it and tried as hard as I could. I can clearly remember the time I all but flew...'

As I read quietly Hee-jeong closes her eyes. I keep my eyes on the book but I can feel it. She draws up her knees and rests her head on my shoulder. I go on reading. Hee-jeong smiles. I still don't look but I feel her smile.

When I read the part where Mr Sommer walks through hail Hee-jeong notices white fibres from her sweater clinging to my black one. She removes them one by one. When they're gone I resume reading.

She leans in again. The white fibres return to my black sweater. Hee-jeong laughs and removes them again. Because of us Mr Sommer stays under the hail.

When she's finished I read calmly. Hee-jeong gently slips her arm under mine. The white fibres cling to my black left sleeve. I laugh. She laughs too.

And I keep reading very softly.

Monday, 26th September

I've caught the flu. Impossible to write a single line.

Hee-jeong, Dong-wan, Jong-gu and Hye-seon wanted to come and see me but I stopped them. I don't want to become a missionary of death.

I've got chills and my throat is on fire. I really feel like I'm dying.

Tuesday, 27th September

Second day off school.

I don't understand why I caught the flu.

If I die I must tell Mum to bury me in my black sweater.

Wednesday, 28th September

A letter arrived from France. Mum says it's from the Hôtel-Dieu Hospital in Paris. It's the bill for my emergency treatment. Of course they weren't going to treat me for free! Just an injection and three stitches and they're asking for €83.46. They take me for a mug.

But why did a letter sent on 11 August only arrive now? Mum looked at the envelope and said our address was strange. On closer look the country was written as 'Dem. People's Rep. of Korea'. Mum burst out laughing and asked if I'd pretended to be North Korean in Paris. Ouch! The National Intelligence Service might arrest me for subversive activity.

If I do get hauled off by the secret service I'll pin it all on Hee-jeong's dad.

Thursday, 29th September

In the end the Hôtel-Dieu medical bill will be covered by travel insurance. Still it's outrageous. Changing my country to North Korea as they please! Hee-jeong's dad says he clearly wrote 'REPUBLIC OF KOREA' at the hospital. And he swears he's never seen the term 'Dem. People's Rep. of Korea' in his life. I really want to sue Hôtel-Dieu.

In the midterms Dong-wan's grades dropped a lot. Jong-gu came first, Hee-jeong second. My grades also went up but I still have a long way to go. To reach Hee-jeong's level I'll have to work even harder. For her can't I make that effort?

Dong-wan says he doesn't care about the class-rep election anymore but to my eyes that's not true. There's still something bitter left in him. That's normal. I don't have a clear conscience either. Lately caught up in my relationship with Hee-jeong I've neglected Dong-wan too much. Sorry my friend.

If there's one piece of good news it's that Dong-wan is seeing Min-a. She's quiet and reserved and they say she was the one who gave him a vote at the election. It's not official. Probably just a trial phase. Good luck!

Dad finally comes back the day after tomorrow.

Friday, 30th September

That Dong-wan bloke is actually a huge pumpkin-seed muncher. I was wondering why his grades had dropped so much. He spent all his time tutoring Min-a in maths, English and science at the expense of his own work. No wonder he never once suggested studying together during exams.

And apparently he wasn't seeing Min-a after the class election but before it. So since before the summer holidays. That's really not on. Pumpkin seeds fine. But a specimen like this is unheard of. Ever since he got a girlfriend he's neglected me this much! What an affront!

Unless he went horse-riding in Mongolia with Min-a over the summer?

A parliamentary inquiry will be needed.

CHAPTER 8

October

Mr Sisina

Saturday, 1st October

Dad is back. His face is deeply tanned his beard wild. He looks fit. His face is like that of a boy with no wrinkles and no worries. Alive. Nothing like when he used to go to the office. It does me good to see Dad's happy face.

We've decided to throw a small welcome-back party in the garden tomorrow evening. Dad wanted to do it on National Foundation Day (the 3rd) but Mum said we all had work and school the next day and should think of other people for a change. Dad seems to have lost all sense of weekdays and public holidays.

Dad has invited Hee-jeong's family and Dong-wan's family. Grandpa and Grandma are coming too. Of course Aunt Jeong-su and her husband as well. I asked Dad if we could also invite Mr Sisina and he said yes. If only I had the number of the bungeo-ppang Hyung I'd have invited him too. What a shame. The garden is far too small. It's going to be a disaster. Perhaps we should just chop down all the flower beds.

Sunday, 2nd October

I got up early and checked the sky first thing. Thankfully it's perfectly clear.

I started by finishing the maths homework Aunt gave me, so I can enjoy myself today and tomorrow without guilt. It's amazing how I've changed. I've decided to call this. the power of love.

Dad slept in. Probably jet lag. Mum did too. They were noisy all night. My ears had quite an adventure. In my room on the second floor I listened to Deep Purple while reading Van Gogh. *Letters to His Brother* which Hee-jeong lent me. Reading it I think I finally understand what she meant when she said 'With the Impressionists I like the painter more than the painting.'

Whatever the 'literary dignity' of my diary I'm copying here a letter that moved me deeply.

To Theo

The duty of a painter is to plunge into nature and pour all his feelings into his work with all his strength. Only then does it become a painting others can understand. If one paints in order to sell one can never reach that goal. It is nothing but deception of the eyes of those who love art. A true artist will never do such a thing. If one works seriously a day will come when one gains people's sympathy.

July 1882

Now I finally understand why Van Gogh didn't sell a single painting in his lifetime.

In the evening there were fourteen of us in our garden. Mum, Dad, Grandpa, Grandma, Aunt Jeong-su, my uncle, Hee-jeong, her mum, her dad, Dong-wan, Dong-wan's dad, Dong-wan's mum, Mr Sisina and me. It was cramped but not enough to justify chopping down trees.

Hee-jeong came wearing her white sweater. And of course I wore my black one. Aunt Jeong-su looked at us and said we looked like two cats. That strangely pleased me. I stayed well away from the barbecue afraid the smell might seep into the sweater. Dong-wan quickly struck up a friendship with Mr Sisina. I learned that Mr Sisina had gone to university in Sri Lanka but had to drop out because of his family's financial troubles. He's married and has a daughter. He showed us her photo. She was truly adorable. He said that if he could earn money in Korea until next year he would go back to Sri Lanka and open a nice restaurant. I truly hope his dream comes true.

Grandpa and Grandma were affectionate. It was as if peace had returned since those cursed white shoes were thrown away. As always the mums started talking about the children's studies. This is the only time my mum ever says a word about my grades. In this kind of atmosphere Aunt Jeong-su is always the boss. Actually even without this atmosphere Aunt Jeong-su is always the boss. It must be because she comes from the jungle Tarzan-style. The dads began bickering about Flash Girl and True Colors and as usual it ended in a political debate. Around midnight the mums led the drunk dads away one by one.

When everyone had gone a great emptiness came over me. On my left sleeve there was a strand of wool from Hee-jeong's white sweater. I didn't remove it. I left it there.

Monday, 3rd October (National Foundation Day)

Last night I had a strange dream. I was in a white room. On the desk there was a box. From the ceiling drops of water fell. Tap. Tap. Tap. The room smelled of rusty iron. I stood up to see what was inside the box and the chair toppled over. One leg of the chair was broken. I pressed the broken leg back against the chair and wrapped it three times with a white bandage. Then I looked inside the box. It was full of envelopes. On each was written. Dem. People's Rep. of Korea.

After hearing my dream Dad said ‘You have stupid dreams almost every day.’ I was relieved thinking it was just another idiotic dream when Dad casually added ‘Next time dream of pigs. Might bring some money into the house.’

Come to think of it is Dad planning to live forever as a holiday-maker? If I ever dream of pigs I’ll sell the dream to Mum. She seems more reliable than Dad.

Tuesday, 4th October

The holidays are over. Everyone goes back to routine.

Mum to the office

me to school

Dad to home as usual.

Wednesday, 5th October

I don’t know what’s got into Dad. He is doing a massive clean-up in the basement. He says he’s going to throw away everything useless. When Mum used to tell him to throw things out he always refused. Now he’s scraping mould off the walls and washing them with diluted detergent. He even changed the bare light bulb hanging from the ceiling. It almost looks decent now. He’s left only an old table and a worn armchair down there.

Dad also pulled out an old hi-fi system from the storeroom. An antique that doesn’t even play CDs which we hadn’t used in ages. He plugged in the speakers and searched for a frequency. In the basement reception was poor. When he stuck the antenna out of the window the signal finally caught. FM 93.1 a classical music station. A piano melody flowed softly.

‘So?’ Dad asked.

‘It feels like a black cat might appear.’

‘Meow.’ Dad imitated a cat.

‘We have a garden. Why don’t we raise a dog?’

‘Because Dad is afraid of dogs.’

‘What?’ I thought I’d misheard.

‘I’m scared of dogs. When I was little I got bitten once. Since then I’ve been afraid of all the dogs in the world.’

‘Even tiny cute puppies?’

‘Yes. Even them. They scare me.’

Grandma sometimes calls me ‘my little puppy’. I hope Dad isn’t afraid of me.

Thursday, 6th October

Jong-gu got told off by his dad. Apparently his father is against him going out with Hye-seon.

‘At your age a girlfriend?’ What universe does he live in?

I advised Jong-gu to switch to ‘private settings mode’. He said he was already in private mode. You can’t even reset! I knew it. Ever since he’d been walking around holding hands everywhere it smelled of trouble.

Friday, 7th October

Since her birthday Hee-jeong keeps holding my hand. With the cool weather I can’t decently push her away. That’s a gentleman’s courtesy. Between looks and manners, manners come first right?

After school I went to Grandpa’s. In front of the building the bungeo-ppang Hyung was selling again. He’d worked four months on a temporary contract at a video-game company. It was meant to be three months but the project ran late so he did an extra month. From this week he’s back to bungeo-ppang. Now that it’s cold it earns him more than the game job did.

If he's back at his stall his music still hasn't broken through. That's sad.

Saturday, 8th October

Mr Jamie told me my English has improved a lot. These days he's drawing. During hours without English lessons he wondered what to do so he started sketching household objects one by one in a notebook. Not many yet but he draws every day steadily.

He showed me his pen and coloured-pencil drawings. A coffee grinder, a fountain pen, an ink bottle, a key ring, a sharpener, a lighter and an ashtray. When I said he drew really well he smiled a little shy. Seeing the lighter and ashtray I asked if he smoked. He said he did after his car accident but he'd quit. I congratulated him with all my heart.

I wish my father would quit completely too. Soon Mum will inspect him. For the peace of our family I hope he passes the test cleanly. And for Dad's sabbatical year as well.

Sunday, 9th October (Hangeul Day)

When Dad said he was afraid of dogs it was a blatant lie. I need to check carefully whether his nose has been growing lately. I rang Grandma to ask if Dad had been bitten as a child and become scared of dogs. She said she'd never heard of such a thing.

I went down to the living room to demand answers and Dad in his usual nasal voice was begging Mum to let us raise a puppy. Mum looked worried. Raising a dog isn't a simple hobby it's a big responsibility. I backed Dad up saying that if we had a dog burglars wouldn't come in. Mum replied that a stray dog if you feed it kindly opens the way for burglars. So I said 'Then not a stray. A Jindo!'

Dad said pure-bred Jindos are hard to find and if we adopt it's better to take a mongrel with a bit of Jindo blood. Mum asked 'And who's picking up the poo?' Dad answered 'Obviously Byeok.'

We reached a gentleman's agreement. We raise a puppy.

- Gentleman's Agreement for Raising a Puppy -

- The puppy lives in the garden. Only in heavy rain or extreme cold may it sleep at the entrance. It is not brought into the living room or bedrooms.
- Byeok cleans the kennel regularly. Of course Byeok picks up the poo. When Byeok isn't around Dad does it.
- The puppy is washed often.
- When taken out the puppy must always wear a lead.
- The puppy is never used to threaten people.

Mum Dad and I went to the pet shop to buy a puppy. I chose with extreme concentration a dog that looked clean and if possible would not poo much. Dad said that if the dog was too big it would be hard to train so we should get a very small puppy and train it up. He spoke like a canine expert.

Among all the puppies we finally found the one we clicked with. With its round little head it didn't seem to have a single drop of Jindo blood. It looked gentle as if it could get along with us. But if you looked closely it was a typical stray. Of course the seller assured us that it was nonetheless a 'distant cousin' of the Jindo.

We decided to believe him and paid. When the little thing got into our car it sighed with relief. I was happy. I felt as if we already understood each other.

We named our new family member Baduk. When Mum said 'What about 'Aji'?' Dad sniggered 'And his family name would be Kang?' Dad laughed so hard he nearly caused an accident. At that moment laser beams shot out of Mum's eyes.

When I see Dad laugh I think he looks a bit like Baduk.

Monday, 10th October

Hee-jeong and Dong-wan came to see Baduk. Hee-jeong hugged him saying he was like an adorable doll. Ah... if only I were Baduk.

Dong-wan says he'd like a puppy too but in a flat it's not possible. He says that in Mongolia every house has a dog and dogs there are very fierce. So 'Have you tied up the dog?' would be a Mongolian greeting.

I also showed them Dad's workshop. He's painted the walls a sea blue. We aired it for days so the paint smell has almost gone. Dong-wan said it was really nice.

'But what work do you do here?' Hee-jeong asked eyes full of curiosity.

'A job? I don't know that myself.'

'A workshop. And you don't know what work he does?' Dong-wan asked baffled.

'Yes. Now you mention it. I've never asked what kind of workshop it is.'

They were laughing when Dad came in carrying a box. He carefully opened it and took out an old machine.

'What's that?' Hee-jeong asked first.

'Oh that? It's a turntable. Before CDs or MP3s we listened to music on this. Wait a second.'

Dad connected it to the old hi-fi. Then he went to the storeroom and brought a cardboard box. The one Mum always told him to throw away or sell. Yet Dad kept it in the best spot as if it were treasure. A box never opened. There are five more like it in the storeroom. Dad opened it and pulled out a huge object like a picture book. A big square of thin paper with a beautiful illustration.

'Wow!' we cried.

'What is it?' Dong-wan asked.

‘It’s a vinyl record. You put it on the turntable and music comes out. Want to listen?’

‘Yes!’ all three of us said.

Dad placed the record. Lively clear harmonica music filled the room. When the track ended Hee-jeong said ‘Oh... it sounds like it’s raining?’ Dong-wan looked outside. ‘That’s strange. It’s not raining.’ Dad burst out laughing.

‘The title is Before the Rain. So after the music... the rain falls.’ He showed us the sleeve. Lee Oskar’s *Before the Rain*.

We listened to a few more tracks in the workshop. Fresh light music. Dad taught us how to handle vinyl. He told Hee-jeong and Dong-wan to come and hang out in the workshop often. It was a happy moment.

But what ‘work’ does Dad actually do in this workshop? I didn’t ask.

Tuesday, 11th October

I finally understand where the saying comes from. ‘What are you doing training a mutt or what?’

Wednesday, 12th October

I finally grasp the true meaning of. ‘He can’t even tell pee from poo.’

Thursday, 13th October

Apart from not yet distinguishing pee from poo our Baduk is quite cute and clever. He’s just still a baby. If we train him well he’ll surely become a distant cousin of the Jindo.

Today when the delivery man rang the bell Baduk barked woof woof! That means he can already tell family from strangers right?

Friday, 14th October

In the evening I took Baduk out for a walk. The bungeo-ppang Hyung said he looked like ‘Gromit’. But really. Gromit cleans the house and washes windows. Our Baduk can’t even tell pee from poo.

When I got home Mum was giving Dad a cooking lesson. Since Dad has to take care of the house during his sabbatical it’s only right that he also makes side dishes. He was writing Mum’s instructions one by one in a notebook. Stir-fried anchovies, soy-braised beans, seasoned dried pollack strips, bean-sprout salad and seasoned spinach. They looked like a couple in love. Until Dad broke a premium plate.

Mum says she’ll deduct the price from Dad’s pocket money.

Saturday, 15th October

Hee-jeong’s brother has passed the first round for art school. If he passes the CSAT and the interview he’ll become a student. Wow! That must be amazing. He did nothing but work and draw in the workshop and now he’s proudly through. But he can’t relax. These days, interview is said to be the hardest part. Curiously he doesn’t seem worried about the CSAT. He’s strong in schoolwork. Lucky him.

After maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su’s Hee-jeong came to our place. To listen to music on Dad’s old hi-fi. The vinyl records Dad has taken out of the storeroom are over five hundred. Rock, jazz and classical. It’s varied. Like Baduk’s appetite Dad’s musical taste has no prejudice. After all he was once a huge fan of Flash Girl.

‘So what work do you do here?’ Hee-jeong asked my father.

‘A job? Well. I read I listen to music. In future I want to watch films too. Why?’

‘No. Just curious.’

‘And you don’t earn any money?’

‘No. No need. Byeok’s mum earns money. I’ll earn some later slowly.’

‘So Dad what do you do?’

‘I told you. I keep the house, listen to music, and read. Why?’

‘Usually dads go out to earn money...’

‘That’s true. But when you grow up you’ll understand. Don’t try to understand everything at once my son.’

When I grow up what will I understand? I’m curious. But never mind. Dad is happy now. And he spends time with me. These past months I’ve spent more time with him than in all the years before. He no longer says he’s tired or that his head is full. He no longer collapses on the sofa. I love Dad’s sabbatical year.

At dinner Mum said she’d arranged a health profile check for Dad with the insurance company. Next week a nurse will come to the house.

Sunday, 16th October

I helped set up Dad’s workshop. To keep the basement dry I put charcoal in small baskets and placed them around. Afraid it might get cold in winter we also bought a small stove in advance. We hung a few pictures on the wall. One was a photo of stars called the Whale Nebula. Dad says he found it on NASA’s website. He also hung a Miles Davis record sleeve.

Dad’s workshop now looks like a nice café from a TV drama. At noon Mum came down and said ‘It’s nicely done.’ She sank into the armchair and asked Dad to put something on. Dad searched the vinyl for a long time then put on *Symphony No. 9* by someone called Mahler. Strange music flowed from the speakers.

‘When your dad was a student he loved classical and jazz so much.’

‘Really? And Flash Girl?’

‘When we were going out your dad talked only about music and books. He looked very cultured very classy.’

‘Seriously?’

‘Of course. He was very popular with the female students. And in the end your mum won him. Your mum followed him everywhere really.’

Dad is saying things he shouldn’t.

‘Anyway if you fail the anti-smoking test your sabbatical is over got it?’ Mum threw back as she went upstairs.

Dad looked nervous like someone in withdrawal.

Monday, 17th October

Mr Sisina was attacked by local thugs. As he was walking a dog ran at him. He told the owner to watch his dog and the owner insulted him. ‘dirty little black’. Then suddenly punched him. Luckily the bungeo-ppang Hyung saw it. The police came asked a few questions then said to ‘settle it amicably’. The thug who hit Mr Sisina wasn’t even twenty. Just a kid. And the police are truly ridiculous. Instead of arresting the attacker they tell them to negotiate nicely. If Mr Sisina had been American or French would they have done the same?

Mr Sisina was in shock. Treated so unjustly he cried in rage. My heart tightened and I felt guilty. Dad drove him to hospital. In A&E they treated the wound near his eye. Since he said his jaw hurt badly the doctor asked him to bite on a stick. When he couldn’t the doctor suspected a cracked jaw. They took an X-ray. Thankfully no fracture.

Dad had him admitted first to stabilise him. Dad contacted Hee-jeong’s father to recommend a hospital with proper wards. A doctor friend of his worked there. In the evening Hee-jeong’s dad and Hee-jeong came to visit. Dong-wan’s dad and Dong-wan came too as

soon as they heard. Mr Sisina had a big wound in his heart. And he cried again thanking everyone.

Dong-wan's dad got angry as if it had been Dong-wan who was attacked. He made calls everywhere. Soon after a lawyer arrived at the hospital. The company lawyer of Dong-wan's dad's firm. In an impeccable suit he asked Mr Sisina for the sequence of events. He also called the bungeo-ppang Hyung to check details. He said there must be CCTV cameras nearby and ran off to the scene.

Fortunately he obtained footage from a bakery camera next to Hyung's stall. Watching it everything was exactly as Mr Sisina and Hyung had said. When he heard the video had been secured Mr Sisina burst into loud tears again.

The lawyer said he would immediately draft the complaint and file it in court with the video as evidence. The hospital issued only a three-week medical certificate. Even with connections four weeks was impossible. Dong-wan's dad said it was a shame. It should have been four weeks. But Hee-jeong's dad said no. When it's no it's no.

We decided to entrust the whole procedure to the lawyer. Given how fast he'd secured the evidence he looked competent. And dressed that well he really looked like a lawyer.

Today my father Hee-jeong's father and Dong-wan's father were all extraordinary.

Tuesday, 18th October

The thug's parents came to the hospital where Mr Sisina was admitted. The thug's father is said to be chief of staff to the president of a large brokerage firm. As soon as he entered the room the rude man blurted out. 'How much do you want?' My father shouted for him to get out immediately.

The lawyer called us. He has launched both criminal and civil proceedings. He told Mr Sisina not to worry about anything and to focus on recovery.

Wednesday, 19th October

Dong-wan's dad says he'll submit a petition to court. He's only met Mr Sisina once but he's helping him like a best friend throwing himself into the case. My father wrote a petition too and gave it to Dong-wan's dad. He says he'll submit both tomorrow.

I read the petition Dad wrote. It was very moving. Mum read it too and said 'You can see the level he had back in his university days.' My father really is a mysterious character.

Thursday, 20th October

A detective came to Mr Sisina's room to take his statement. But the trial hasn't started yet. Why does it take so long? Dong-wan's dad is contacting journalist friends. He says he'll teach them a lesson. My father called my uncle. But my uncle being a proofreader said he doesn't do reporting. Dad asked him at least to introduce a society-page journalist. My uncle replied that he was too busy to respond to every denunciation. According to him three weeks of medical certificate is a bit weak. Dad shouted 'Then how badly do you have to be beaten before a journalist moves?'

Dad exaggerated a little.

Friday, 21st October

Mr Sisina has been discharged. He's more stable but psychologically he's suffering a lot. The thug probably won't go to prison. It's his first offence. Frustrating. He ought to eat prison rice.

Dong-wan heard from his dad that the prosecutor chose a summary procedure. No public trial. The judge will decide after reviewing documents. The decision will come by next week at the latest and it will probably just be a fine. Ah... the law is far the fist is near!

Dong-wan's dad is also preparing a civil suit and apparently he shouted at the lawyer. 'Get ten billion won!' With ten billion Mr Sisina could go back to Sri Lanka immediately. But my dad says such an amount is impossible. At best hospital fees and a few coins of moral compensation.

Mr Sisina's hospital bills aren't covered by any health insurance because he was hospitalised due to an assault. The money has to be recovered from the attacker. In the meantime Dong-wan's dad has paid everything.

Saturday, 22nd October

In the morning I studied maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su's then stopped by Mr Sisina's place. But he wasn't there. He'd gone back to work today. I hope he pulls himself together soon and returns to a normal life.

Mr Sisina's case has pushed many things into the background but there's good news. Dad passed the anti-smoking test at once last Wednesday. Strangely though his blood pressure was too high. They measured it twice. Normally it's fine but that day it was very high. Probably stress from the test. Mum is happy. She says the couple's trust hasn't been broken. The final decision on Dad's health profile will be made next week. I don't know why it's so important but I hope Dad passes as Mum wishes. Has Mum ever been wrong?

From my experience Dad is sometimes right but Mum is always right.

Sunday, 23rd October

I listened to music alone in Dad's workshop. I carefully took out his cherished vinyls one by one just to look at them. The track I liked most was 'My Road' by Lee Oskar. On harmonica. No matter how much I listened I never tired of it.

In an empty basement listening to music alone and reading *World Masterpieces of Mystery* from Dad's shelf. It was a bit chilling. "The Man from the South" by Roald Dahl made me jump. In such a bright atmosphere a terrifying reversal suddenly emerges. I thought he was a children's writer but he had such dark power in him.

Monday, 24th October

As expected the thug got only a three-million-won fine on the grounds that it was his first offence. Dong-wan's dad exploded 'Even a passing dog would laugh at that!' They say that normally so calm a man has been jumping around in rage since morning. But since the prosecutor won't appeal there's nothing we can do.

I was reminded of the class-rep election and it made me sad.

Tuesday, 25th October

Hee-jeong and I submitted an application to take part in volunteer work during the winter holidays. When I feel this depressed Hee-jeong is my only pleasure in life.

Wednesday, 26th October

In the evening Dad went out to see Hee-jeong's dad and Dong-wan's dad. He says Mr Sisina's case is settling well so he's buying a drink. Dad came back late completely drunk. Everything is fine except I'm a bit worried about the people who'll go tomorrow to get their teeth treated by Hee-jeong's dad. I hope he doesn't accidentally pull out a healthy tooth.

Thursday, 27th October

Hee-jeong says her dad didn't drink a single beer yesterday. Because of the dental clinic he never drinks on weekdays. I worried for nothing.

Dad has definitively passed the insurance health profile test. So we'll get about 30,000 won off the monthly premium. And on top of that we got 600,000 won back from what we've paid so far. Mum gave that money to Dad as pocket money. Dad was as happy as if he'd won the lottery.

The maths problems Aunt Jeong-su gives me are getting harder and harder. I spent three hours trying and couldn't even solve them all. Is she trying to make me a doctor of maths or what. I miss the days of salt-water problems.

Friday, 28th October

Today I talked a lot with Grandpa. He says discriminating against others wasn't originally human nature. Primitive humans didn't kill or discriminate. According to him humanity started becoming bad around 6000 BC with the birth of early civilisations. When cities appeared in Mesopotamia humans began to dominate and discriminate against other humans. Once rooted this malice spread over the Earth in an instant.

Grandpa said that during colonial times the Japanese discriminated terribly against Koreans and that they still discriminate against Koreans in Japan. But he also said that we in Korea discriminate against other Asians. He said America is very racist too. It's just that because expressing racism is punished it hides and becomes invisible. He added that Europe is very racist as well. Only since we don't live there we don't see it. But everywhere it's the same he says.

Grandpa said he himself suffered much discrimination because he was from Jeolla. Today it's no longer so open but he says this regional discrimination still remains rooted underground in society.

He told me that when our great-grandfather was taken away for forced labour Japanese often said to him. 'You're not really like a Korean.' And Grandpa himself often

heard. 'You're not really like a Jeolla.' Each time he didn't know whether it was a compliment or an insult. He says he suffered a lot among people full of prejudice.

He told me that no matter whether others discriminate or not I must never become someone who discriminates. I promised I never would. Grandpa said that even if the other is different from me he is human and deserves respect as such. He said doing big things socially is important but it's these small things that make the world better.

I don't understand exactly everything he means. But I know one thing for sure. It's not because Dong-wan's mother is Mongolian that Dong-wan should be discriminated against. And it's not because Mr Sisina comes from Sri Lanka that he should be discriminated against.

Saturday, 29th October

Dad booked four tickets for a classical concert. Not Dad, Mum, me and Baduk. Baduk is replaced by Hee-jeong. Dad bought the tickets as a birthday present for Mum. Programme is Mahler's *Symphony No. 9*. The one that nearly set the house on fire last time.

Dad suggested going together with Hee-jeong's dad and Mum but they flatly refused. Hee-jeong's dad said 'True Colors or Flash Girl fine but Mahler... not for me.' Hee-jeong's mum has no particular interest in classical music. It seems the artistic sensibility of Hee-jeong and her brother doesn't come from their parents.

Dad says he got four 'Category C' seats at the Arts Center Concert Hall. I thought that meant not front row. Maybe third?

Sunday, 30th October

Hee-jeong and I listened to Mahler's *Symphony No. 9* in Dad's workshop. But even before the end of the first movement I felt ants crawling all over me. I was dying of impatience.

Even Hee-jeong eventually said ‘What is this music?’ I put on *My Road* by Lee Oskar instead.

My anxiety finally calmed. Hee-jeong said it was much better too.

I nearly ruined a golden Sunday afternoon because of Mahler.

Monday, 31st October

The ‘Category C’ seats at the Arts Center Concert Hall weren’t the third row. They come after VIP, R, S, A and B. They’re the cheapest category. We have to listen from way up at the top on the third floor. Aaah! And Category C costs only 10,000 won.

‘Do you think I’m the boss of a huge conglomerate?’ Dad said proudly. And he told me if I didn’t feel like going I could just not go.

I wonder if it’s worth travelling all the way to that distant Arts Center just to listen to Mahler’s weird music.

All day the radio keeps playing ‘The Forgotten Season’ by Lee Yong.

CHAPTER 9

November

The Workshop

Tuesday, 1st November

From the very first day of November bad news. In Mr Sisina's civil case, the court has ordered the attacker to pay only four million won in compensation. That sum includes medical fees five days' lost wages and a little moral damage. Dong-wan says it wouldn't even cover the lawyer's fees. Luckily his father told Mr Sisina not to worry about the legal costs.

Dad is in the workshop endlessly typing something on his laptop. It can't be another petition for Mr Sisina. So what on earth is it?

Wednesday, 2nd November

Jong-gu's older brother was waiting in front of the school gate. But Jong-gu was absent today. He'd caught a heavy cold from exhaustion and stayed home. When Dong-wan tried to ring Jong-gu on his phone his brother said it wasn't a good idea. He only told us to get along well with Jong-gu then left. His back walking away with regret looked terribly lonely. There are far too many unhappy people in this world. Why is that?

Thursday, 3rd November

Dad spends all day in the workshop looping Mahler's *Symphony No. 9*. No matter how often I hear it I don't get used to it. I don't understand why anyone would listen to music that doesn't even have a tune.

While Dad sits on the sofa listening I do maths at his table. Mahler doesn't bother me at all for studying. Since it doesn't catch the ear it doesn't disturb anything. What a strange kind of music.

In the evening Mum came down and joked that two raccoons were now living in our cellar. As always Dad gave up the sofa to Mum. Thankfully he didn't start talking about his university days.

Friday, 4th November

A miracle happened today. I solved a maths problem that even Hee-jeong couldn't solve. I shall say nothing about her surprise and delight. I must absolutely thank Aunt Jeong-su. Thanks to the problem she taught me last week I earned praise from Hee-jeong.

Saturday, 5th November

In the morning after finishing maths and English I went to Dong-wan's. These days whenever we gather there are six of us by default. Me, Hee-jeong, Dong-wan, Min-a, Jong-gu and Hye-seon. Dong-wan's mum said that because of us their Engel coefficient was rising. Engel coefficient isn't that some sort of population density index?

Sunday, 6th November

For Mum's birthday, Mum and Dad have gone on a trip to Sokcho for three days and two nights. From today I have to stay two days at Grandpa's. Mum and Dad got up at dawn

making a big fuss supposedly to pack. I would have packed everything last night. I don't understand why for such an important birthday I'm the only one being left out. They're not trying to make a second child are they?

Monday, 7th November

In the morning I stopped by home to give Baduk his breakfast then went to school. My heart felt a little heavy that I couldn't take him to Grandpa's yesterday, but Baduk knew nothing of that. He just had his head buried in his bowl. I also served him a well-filled lunch in advance then left.

After school I went back to give him dinner. Then I took a book by Romain Rolland from Dad's shelf. *The Life of Beethoven*. And went to Grandpa's. With the classical concert on 9 December I'm becoming more and more interested in classical music. After dinner I read *The Life of Beethoven*. It was gripping. I feel as if Romain Rolland wrote it in a state of excitement. You often hear Beethoven had a dreadful temper but I didn't know he was such a noble person.

I was deeply moved by *The Heiligenstadt Testament*. A musician who can no longer hear. It's unimaginable. There's a striking passage so I copy it here.

I am not in the habit of correcting my works once they are finished. Up to now I have never altered anything for I am convinced that such changes destroy the very character of the work.

Composition and maths may be similar. When I go back to a problem I've already solved to correct it I always end up getting it wrong too!

Tuesday, 8th November

Today is Mum's birthday. Since Mum and Dad have both gone to Sokcho I feel a bit put out. This morning I went to feed Baduk. He at least looks put out by nothing. That pet-shop seller who said a distant cousin of the Jindo. That was surely a lie.

I bought flowers as a birthday present for Mum. In a good mood Mum kissed me on the cheek. Yet I'm grown up now. I don't need Mum's kisses anymore. Unless it were a kiss from Hee-jeong. That would be another matter.

Mum and Dad brought back piles of cuttlefish from Sokcho saying it was top quality. They also bought several jars of salted cod roe. They gave all of that to Hee-jeong's family and Dong-wan's. At Aunt Jeong-su's they even added specially a jar of salted cuttlefish, a jar of salted fish tripe, a jar of salted gills and a jar of salted baby cuttlefish. At Grandpa's instead of cuttlefish they gave dried fish and salted cod roe. Since Mr Sisina wasn't home I left a bag of dried fish at the entrance to his rooftop room with a note. In the evening Mr Sisina came to thank us.

Dad freed from side dishes hums as he rearranges the fridge. For a while our banchan will be salted cod roe, salted cuttlefish, salted tripe, salted gills, salted baby cuttlefish and fried eggs. Aaah!

Wednesday, 9th November

Cheol-jin was playing a game in class and the form tutor confiscated his smartphone. It had already been taken once in science class a few days ago. After that lesson he'd gone to the staff room and just about got it back. And today he's lost it again.

Cheol-jin, even if the teacher warns him a hundred times it never sinks in. The form tutor said 'One more time and your parents will have to come to school to collect it.' I think that's a very wise decision.

Dad keeps on writing something in the workshop. But what is it?

Thursday, 10th November

On the table in Dad's workshop there's a sheet of paper pinned up with these words.

- *The Thumb's Eye*
- *The Vanishing Point*
- *The Audacious Day of Mr Hwang Manduk Naturally Shy*
- *The False Singers*
- *Mr Imugi Part-Time Lecturer and the 007 Briefcase*
- *The Man Who Was Left with Nine Card Holders*
- *The Mystery of Mister Lee*

But what on earth can all this be?

Friday, 11th November

Mum rang to say she'll be home very late because of work. So Dad and I went to have dinner at Grandpa's. We took Baduk too but Dad tied him up in front of the entrance. It was Baduk's first time in a block of flats and he looked very uneasy. And then he started sniffing every single pair of shoes one by one. What a mutt! Though come to think of it he looks a lot like my father who always sniffs his socks when he takes them off.

After dinner Grandpa Dad and Baduk went out for a walk. Dad walked with Baduk and I walked with Grandpa. Grandpa patted my head and said 'Byeok you've been working hard especially at maths and your grades have improved a lot. That makes your grandpa very happy.'

I replied 'Yes. I don't really know how it happened. I didn't exactly plan it.'

Grandpa smiled 'It's because of Hee-jeong isn't it?'

'Ah yes...' I was surprised and stammered.

Then I quickly changed the subject like deflecting an arrow. 'But Grandpa... is Dad a good son? A filial son?'

Grandpa answered without hesitation. 'Of course. Your father is a good son.'

I insisted on purpose. 'But Dad doesn't work he doesn't earn money and he can't even give much pocket money to you and Grandma.'

Grandpa laughed 'No Byeok. You don't know yet. Your father is writing now. He's always wanted to write. Until now he worked in a company just to live because we had to eat. And now he's finally doing what he wants to do. Don't you think your father is classy?'

'Really?'

'Of course. And when he was little your father did everything he could to make me happy. We raised him in real happiness. That's enough. Grandpa has nothing more to ask for.'

The gentle smile at the corner of Grandpa's lips spread all the way to me as if it stuck to my face. What is this feeling of fullness?

Saturday, 12th November

Jamie asked how my life had been lately. I told him about Baduk our new family member and that we were going to a classical concert next month so I sometimes heard Mahler. Well. Saying 'I listen to Mahler' is an exaggeration. Every time I go down to the workshop I just catch a few bars that's all. Jamie seemed to understand my clumsy English. When I talk with him I use my hands and eyes more than my mouth. Sometimes I even use my whole body.

He told me that before he was in a wheelchair he sometimes went to concerts. But now even going out alone for a walk in the park isn't easy.

Of course sir. At the hospital in Paris when I was sitting in a wheelchair in A&E you were the first person I thought of. I only said that in my head. Because even with gestures I don't think it would have got across.

Jamie is preparing a trip to Boston with his wife before winter comes. Not long. Three nights and four days. It's not very far from New York so they decided to try it for the first time.

After studying at Aunt Jeong-su's I went to hang out at Hee-jeong's. Since her brother seemed to have done very well in his exam the mood in the house was joyful. From the atmosphere you'd think he'd already been admitted to art school. Good. When he goes to the Prado Museum next year I'll have to follow Hee-jeong!

Sunday, 13th November

This morning it's very cold.

Autumn deepens.

Dead leaves roll in the street.

Dad rolls in the workshop.

Baduk rolls in his kennel.

And I roll over my desk crushed by maths homework.

In the afternoon I went to the bookshop to buy a book to read to Hee-jeong. I leafed through this leafed through that... and in the end chose a book by Patrick Süskind. *The Pigeon*. It's thin. Perfect.

Monday, 14th November

This Friday our school is holding the autumn festival the Bamseom-je. After classes everyone is busy rehearsing dance and singing. Total commotion. I do nothing. I have no particular

talent. I was born a bad singer and a bad dancer. Staying quiet and not bothering others already counts as helping with the organisation.

Hee-jeong on the other hand will be exhibiting a painting. The art teacher asked her specially. No one asked me to write a poem. In any case I don't intend to become a poet so I don't mind.

Tuesday, 15th November

The Pigeon by Patrick Süskind is a sad story. I was glad to find familiar places like the Seine in Paris or Montparnasse Cemetery but the content is horrible. Because of a single pigeon the hero is pushed to the brink of suicide.

I hope he doesn't die.

Wednesday, 16th November

I woke with a start. In my dream a swarm of pigeons was chasing me and I was running like an idiot. That's definitely a bad sign. Something bad is going to happen for sure.

Thursday, 17th November

I knew it. Today the final exam timetable was posted. That damned pigeon must stand for exams. To say that a pigeon symbolises peace. That's pure rubbish.

- Tuesday, 6 December : Korean, Social Studies, Ethics
- Wednesday, 7 December : English, Music
- Thursday, 8 December : Science, Chinese characters
- Friday, 9 December : Maths

Hee-jeong showed me the painting she'll exhibit at the Bamseom-je. It was fantastic and dreamlike. On the left and right people were gathered all wearing pointed hats like strange hoods. In the centre smoke rose and spread like a cloud. At the bottom was the head of a huge snake pierced by a great blade and a figure as if the owner of the sword seemed to be suffering terribly.

Hee-jeong almost avoided colour. She used only pen and black paint. It was frightening and bizarre. What on earth can be in Hee-jeong's head to imagine something like that?

In *The Pigeon* Jonathan went back to his flat after *The Pigeon* left. Good. I can finally breathe too. I'll be able to focus on revision. I'd better stop reading books for a while.

Friday, 18th November

Because of the rain the Bamseom-je was held in the school gym. Hee-jeong's painting was pushed into a corner and displayed as best it could be. The headteacher and deputy head jumped. 'But what is this painting?' The art teacher explained well but couldn't stop it being shoved aside. Adults find it healthy when children imitate celebrities by dancing and singing.

That night lying in bed I suddenly thought that the very fact the headteacher and deputy wanted to push the painting away was exactly what Hee-jeong was trying to express. She had painted people's prejudices.

The pointed-hat people were the mass of normal people. The snake was Mr Sisina or Dong-wan. The owner of the sword was someone bad. And she'd made everything dark with only pen and black paint.

Tomorrow I must ask Hee-jeong.

Saturday, 19th November

Hee-jeong heard my interpretation and burst out laughing. She said ‘You interpret more than the dream itself.’ According to her the painting was just a reproduction of a dream she’d had a few days ago.

No, no! In Hee-jeong’s unconscious there must be thoughts like that. I thought again. The pointed hat symbolises the KKK and the snake represents a powerful force. In Harry Potter too, Voldemort and Harry both speak snake language and have mysterious power right? And then... um...

And what if as Hee-jeong says it really is just an interpretation bigger than the dream?

Sunday, 20th November

Autumn is ending. In Seoul the temperature has dropped below zero.

Hee-jeong and I studied at my place for the finals. Since my Korean marks weren’t good last time we decided to do a little every day. We also decided to learn chinese characters in small doses because they don’t go into my head easily. Science is hard so we need to review it now and then. Music isn’t simple either. Better start early. Social studies can’t be neglected. Even with ten heads it wouldn’t be enough. The easiest subjects are maths and English. Something’s wrong.

In the afternoon I read a little of *The Pigeon* to Hee-jeong. The first pages were a bit awkward. At the start Jonathan’s wife gives birth to a boy only four months after marriage then runs off with a fruit seller.

Every time I read this book aloud I feel my body tense. Probably because the atmosphere of *The Pigeon* is very different from *Mr Sommer’s Story*. But strangely *The Pigeon* attracts me more.

Monday, 21st November

Jong-gu's parents are in the middle of divorce proceedings. The father absolutely refuses to divorce and the mother has packed her bags saying she can't live under the same roof anymore. Even today they argued violently over compensation and Jong-gu's custody.

Jong-gu says he doesn't want to follow either his mum or his dad. I feel sorry for Jong-gu.

Tuesday, 22nd November

Today is Grandma's birthday. I bought her a rose and gave it to her with a card. 'Thank you Grandma. Please always stay healthy!'

Wednesday, 23rd November

Jong-gu has run away. What happened? Dong-wan tried calling Jong-gu on his mobile but it was switched off. Hye-seon spent the day sniffing on the verge of tears.

Thursday, 24th November

Jong-gu has come home. Yesterday he went to his older brother's place but his brother sent him back. His brother probably isn't yet in a position to feed and house him. Still it would be nice if they could live together.

But Jong-gu's face is much brighter than before. What promise could his brother have made him?

Friday, 25th November

According to Dong-wan if Jong-gu's parents divorce Jong-gu has decided to follow his mother. That way he can live with his older brother. In fact Jong-gu's brother had sometimes

met their mother in secret without the father knowing. And the mother had also quietly helped her eldest son with money.

When Jong-gu ran away he spent a night with his brother and that's when he learned all this. His brother asked him to hold on just a little longer and above all. If their parents divorce to follow their mother no matter what. Then the three of them could live under the same roof. The mother the older brother and him.

That must be what made Jong-gu's face brighter. My heart hurts.

Saturday, 26th November

After maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su's Hee-jeong and I went back to my place. Dad is still writing something in the workshop. And Mahler's *Symphony No. 9* is still looping. Every time I go in it's the same music. Not long ago Dad used to slump on the sofa watching Flash Girl absent-mindedly... it's incredible.

Hee-jeong asked my father curious. 'Doesn't it bore you to listen to the same music every day?'

He replied 'Huh? What music?'

I added 'This music. You only ever play Mahler's music.'

He said 'No I'm not listening to it. I just let it run.'

'Huh!' Hee-jeong and I cried at the same time.

He explained 'Mahler's music doesn't go into the ear so it doesn't bother work. Music with a nice melody gets in the way of work.'

Dad's work isn't solving maths problems but he's like me. Hee-jeong looked at the paper stuck in front of Dad's table and asked 'What's that? The Thumb's Eye, The Vanishing Point and The Audacious Day...?'

Dad's eyes lit up. 'Oh that? That's the story I'm writing at the moment. I heard something in Rome this summer. Want to hear it?'

'Yes!' we both said.

Dad began. 'They say there was this. Among the people I met in Rome there was someone from Palermo in Sicily. Sicily is a bit like Jeju for us. Anyway the man was called Toto and he always walked around with a huge umbrella. An umbrella as big as a parasol. One day I asked him if such an umbrella wasn't heavy. And Toto said he had no choice. A few years ago he'd travelled in the Sahara and under the blazing sun his shadow had burned then evaporated. Since then he'd searched for his shadow everywhere but never found it again. So that nobody would notice he always walks under an umbrella. And then one day he learned there were other people who'd lost their shadows. If you go to Saint-Germain in Paris. Ah you've been there too. The place where Byeok stepped in dog poo and slipped. Anyway there's a club there called Beldejour. When the full moon hangs over the Eiffel Tower the people who've lost their shadows gather there. According to Toto someone went on an expedition to Antarctica and his shadow froze solid there. He had to come back leaving it behind. Someone else took a nap on a beach in Montpellier and had his shadow stolen. And the strangest case is a man called Benjamin. On a day of fierce wind his shadow flew off into the sky. Terrible really. But recently someone has appeared who supposedly owns more than ten shadows. A certain Count Olivier. Toto is convinced he's a shadow thief. Soon they're going to form a pursuit team to catch him. I wanted to join but since I still have my shadow I can't become a member. So I came back home. That's all.'

Alert! Dad is weird!

Sunday, 27th November

Mum says Dad is perfectly normal. The story he told Hee-jeong and me is the content of the novel he's writing at the moment. Every evening Dad tells Mum what he's written. Mum says she's bored to death.

Well that's her problem. For me at least what a relief. I almost had to go visit Dad in a psychiatric hospital.

Dad says that when his book comes out and he gets royalties he'll become rich. Mum replies that compared with the novel that sentence is even harder to believe.

Monday, 28th November

Dong-wan's father called my father and Hee-jeong's father. He suggested that at the end of the year the three families go on a trip together. All the dads said yes.

But they haven't chosen the destination yet. And of course they didn't even ask the mums' permission. I wonder if they really have the right to decide like that as they please.

Tuesday, 29th November

The holidays haven't even started and Mum and Dad are already talking about where to go. While their one and only precious son has his finals. A matter of life and death. Right under his nose they have absolutely no interest in it. I'm free-range. Left to grow like a plant.

I'd quite like Sokcho. Watching the first sunrise of the year there with Hee-jeong... that would be so beautiful. And our love would deepen.

Wednesday, 30th November

Only one week left before the exams. Dong-wan studies with Min-a almost every day.

Between love and friendship Dong-wan chose love without the slightest hesitation! Hee-

jeong went straight home because her brother was going to help her revise. Jong-gu and Hye-seon study together in a study room avoiding the eyes of Jong-gu's father.

If there were no exams could we not study? I don't know. I don't dislike studying but I really hate exams. I want to live in a world without exams.

CHAPTER 10

December

When Should One Applaud?

Thursday, 1st December

It's already the last month of the year. So many memorable things have happened but I've decided to think about them after the end-of-term exams. For now I just have to do well. Hee-jeong has no reason to love a boy who's rubbish in class. And if someone were to say to her 'What? Your boyfriend isn't even in the top ten?' how would she feel? No. Impossible.

Apart from chinese characters and science my marks should be decent. Still with the studious mood in class these days you never know. In my classmates' lives once you take away school private academies and video games there isn't much left. I don't go to academies and I hate games so my life is much more dynamic.

Luckily my close friends don't go to academies and don't like games much either. Well. Maybe it's the other way round. Maybe we became friends because none of us go to academies and none of us like games and we had no other choice.

Friday, 2nd December

In autumn dead leaves rolled everywhere.

And now winter rain soaks them through.

I think of the homeless in Seoul and in Paris.

I hope this winter won't be too cold.

There's so much money and food in the world. If only there were free canteens everywhere. Then poor grandpas and grandmas wouldn't have to wander from dawn collecting cardboard...

Saturday, 3rd December

I got into the lift to go to Aunt Jeong-su's and a high-school girl—at least she looked like one—spat on the floor of the lift. So when people say morals have collapsed in the age of heroes it's not just a figure of speech.

I solved all the maths problems Aunt had given me. She says I'm a hundred times better than the pupils in the gifted class. I know she's not just saying that to please me. Wasn't it only recently that I solved a problem even Hee-jeong couldn't?

Mr Jamie still hasn't managed to go to Boston. He keeps postponing and now winter has come. He plans to go next spring. Travelling in a wheelchair probably isn't as easy as it sounds. I encouraged him. 'Keep at it sir. In spring it'll be warmer and even better.'

Sunday, 4th December

Because Aunt Jeong-su summoned me I went over early in the morning to do maths. In the lift I ran into the family of that high-school girl who spat yesterday. Her mother was blocking the buttons with her body so I struggled to press the button for the 7th floor. Once I'd pressed it I hurried to stick myself in a corner.

The girl's father shouted 'Aren't you going to press it or what?!'

The mother said 'Press what?'

The girl yelled ‘What on earth are you doing!’

The father muttered ‘Honestly. What’s wrong with your mum these days?’

The mother said ‘Oh dear my head...’ Only then did she press the button for the 12th.

I thought my legs would give way. When I told Aunt Jeong-su she said there were lots of nasty kids around these days. My uncle added that it was all the parents’ fault. Aunt gave me a glass of red ginseng juice and I came back to my senses. They’re much richer than we are. They drink red ginseng juice like water by the crate. Supposedly it stops you catching colds...

Aunt said that if I get 100/100 in maths in these exams she’ll buy me whatever present I want. I’m staking everything on maths.

Monday, 5th December

Tomorrow is finally the decisive day.

Maths wait for me!

I’m coming!

And you weekend where Mahler awaits... hurry up and come!

Tuesday, 6th December

- First day of exams -

- Korean. Clearly studying paid off. My mark will go up a lot.
- Social studies. I studied seriously out of respect for Mr Kim Su-yeong. It should be good.
- Ethics. Far too easy. Is it normal that there was no discrimination at all?

What if I ended up top of the class? That would be awkward. I’d have to keep it secret.

Wednesday, 7th December

- Second day of exams -

- English. The paper was far too hard. I'm not the only one who found it tough right?
- Music. Might as well sit it singing!
-

Well at least I no longer have to worry about coming top. In fact I had no reason to worry in the first place.

Thursday, 8th December

- Third day of exams -

- Science. Was it a bit easy today? In any case studying was worth it.
- Chinese Characters. The teacher must have set an easy paper because he's afraid the subject will disappear. There's no other explanation!

The hope I abandoned yesterday is fluttering again. Even if I'm not first there's still a ranking right? Tomorrow it's maths. The easiest subject. I mean... easy maths? Have I gone mad?

Friday, 9th December

- Fourth day of exam -

- Maths. That last question... the teacher must have made a mistake setting it. Why put out something like that? Unless he mixed it up with a third-year paper I'm finished!

In the evening I went to a performance of Mahler's *Symphony No. 9* with Dad and Hee-jeong. Mum couldn't come. Too busy. For the first time in my life I went to a place called the Arts Center. We parked then walked for ages uphill. Later I learned Dad had parked on the opera house side not the concert hall side. Thanks to him we wandered shivering for more than twenty minutes looking for the hall. Good thing Mum didn't come.

Dad looked very smart. Well-cut suit immaculate coat. Hee-jeong wore a white sweater, a duffle coat and a furry hat. I had a black sweater, a wool coat and a white bun-shaped hat. In that sense we were all respectable. Well. Hee-jeong wasn't just respectable. She looked like an angel. Among hundreds of people she shone the brightest. I wanted to wear a badge saying Kim Hee-jeong's Boyfriend.

At the ticket desk the clerk asked Dad's name.

'Heo Su-jeong.'

She searched in a box but our tickets weren't there.

She asked again. 'You are Mr Heo Su-jeong?'

He replied 'Yes. But it's Category C.'

'Ah yes sorry.' After placing the pre-printed envelopes for VIP and R seats on the counter she printed our Category C tickets on the spot and handed them to us.

Hee-jeong giggled. I was a bit embarrassed but pretended nothing had happened.

Dad said without caring at all that we were in C. 'It's fine. At the Arts Center C seats are the best. Dad's been here loads of times. I know what I'm talking about.'

I asked 'Then why did you park anywhere?'

He replied 'Do students have cars? It's my first time driving here that's all.' Thinking about it he wasn't wrong. We were about to see whether C seats really were the best!

The stairs up to the third floor were steep and high. On the way Dad said ‘Honestly it’s much more fun to come to a concert with a C ticket you paid for yourself than with a VIP or R invitation. I swear!’ That too we were about to test.

On the balcony near the third-floor stairs there was a lounge for VIP clients of a bank. Drinks food smartly dressed people in small groups... clearly guests. I understood at once. Maybe Dad was right. Even a thatched hut if it’s mine is the best. Our C seats cost ten thousand won but at least we’d paid. We’d come truly for the music! After a month of being fed Mahler to the point of nausea.

Our seats were at the extreme end far right. It was cramped. No place to put coats except on our laps. The musicians came up one by one and started tuning. Dozens of people tuning at once. What a racket. And to the side of the stage there was a ladder. The concert was about to start and they hadn’t even removed it. I found that outrageous.

The conductor arrived. From my seat he was the size of a fingernail. And I could only see the back of his head! Yet the moment he raised his baton the orchestra’s sound rose up to this distant third floor with astonishing clarity. Nothing like Dad’s old player or the rubbish stereo in my room. Even the majestic sound I’d heard in Dong-wan’s dad’s study couldn’t compete. This was real music filling the whole hall.

Midway through the first movement a musician climbed the ladder with a mallet in his hand and struck a long metal bar. Ding... ding... A deep heavy sound rang out. It was a funny sight. It left more of an echo in me than the music itself.

At the end of the first movement during the interval latecomers came in looking for their seats. Couldn’t they have arrived a bit earlier? Some terrified by the second movement even grabbed their coats and fled straight out of the hall. During the break Dad told me the instrument played on the ladder was called the bass chime.

The second movement began. It was much brisker than what I'd heard in Dad's workshop. The strings were unbelievably soft and light as if they might fly. The winds were crisp without any distortion. This wasn't the same music as in recent weeks. It was another music. Real sound raw sound living music.

By the time the third movement started I had pins and needles all over. The music felt less new. The excitement had faded. I'm trying to be honest. So I tried to count the musicians to concentrate. But from my seat I couldn't see the cello desks so I couldn't count properly. Roughly there must have been about a hundred.

Towards the end of the fourth movement I was desperate for the loo. Mahler is Mahler. Sitting still for over eighty minutes isn't easy. I hoped the percussionist would climb the ladder again to strike the bass chime once more but it didn't happen. I'd like to recommend to all composers that symphonies be kept under sixty minutes.

At last the fourth movement ended. It was time to applaud. I know perfectly well. I've read Daniel Hope's book *When Should One Applaud?* I clapped with all my strength. The more I clapped the more I felt my stress evaporating. The stress of these past weeks of exams melted into the applause. I stood up to clap. People on the first and second floors stood too. We clapped until it hurt until the conductor came back several times. Everyone seemed to be letting off steam. Many were surely clapping out of relief as well. That mad music was finally over. You could even feel sighs of deliverance mixed into the sound of hands. I know. Honestly if that long boring music hadn't ended... what would we have done?

When I stopped clapping, palms swollen, hunger hit me.

Saturday, 10th December

When I woke up Dad immediately put Mahler's *Symphony No. 9* back on. Compared with last night's excitement the old machine's sound felt rather dull. Yet I had the feeling I knew

this music well. The winds once so shrill now sounded almost warm. Mahler's music had become familiar to me.

In the morning at Aunt Jeong-su's during maths she told me that the last problem on the test... I'd already learned it. Then she opened the exercise book and pointed 'Isn't it exactly this one?' I had nothing to say. My present evaporated into thin air. I begged 'I only got one wrong, couldn't you give me even a small present?' But Aunt refused. In these matters she's always a blade. No compromise she never changes the criteria. On the other hand what she promises she keeps. So as she said I console myself by thinking. Next year.

Sunday, 11th December

In two weeks it'll be the winter holidays. Wow. I'd love to go back to Paris with Hee-jeong but that's impossible. Luckily as soon as term ends we've decided to go to Sokcho with Hee-jeong's family and Dong-wan's family. We went there in spring on the school trip but that doesn't count. It's null and void. We'll leave on 30 December watch the first sunrise on 1 January then return to Seoul. Mum and Dad don't really fancy going back because they were there not long ago but Hee-jeong's family and Dong-wan's family insisted on Sokcho. Of course I didn't take my parents' side. That's the price. They went to Sokcho without me.

Should I get into Hee-jeong's family's car? Or Dad's? Actually there's nothing to think about. I get into whichever car Hee-jeong gets into.

Monday, 12th December

The winter holidays are still too far away. Exams are over and yet I wish the headteacher would declare with flourish that the holidays are open.

Tuesday, 13th December

The headteacher is off with a nasty flu. In that case I'd like the deputy head to declare with flourish that the winter holidays are open.

Wednesday, 14th December

At breakfast Dad said the secret of the universe would probably be cracked soon. Usually Mum would say 'Just eat' but this time she asked 'What do you mean?' Dad explained that at CERN in Europe they'd already found the Higgs boson—the God particle—and that it was only a matter of time before they discovered dark matter and dark energy.

I asked what the Higgs boson was. Dad said it was a hypothetical particle proposed by a scientist called Higgs and that it was discovered in 2012. He added that without the Higgs boson the universe would collapse. He said dark matter makes up 27% of the universe and dark energy 68% but all of it is still wrapped in mystery. If that veil were lifted we'd understand the origin of the universe we live in.

Honestly I can't understand any of it. Even without dark matter and dark energy we live perfectly well. Why go hunting these things so desperately? And if it turns out they don't exist what then?

I went to bed then got back up. Because of this dark matter and dark energy business I couldn't sleep. If they don't exist the universe collapses. And if the universe collapses that means it's over with Hee-jeong too. No that won't do. I have to help find them as well. But where do you even look?

Thursday, 15th December

At breakfast Dad said it would probably be difficult to find dark matter and dark energy for now. So I decided to leave them alone for now as well. But then Dad suddenly said 'They say the universe might have eleven dimensions... how on earth are we supposed to prove that?'

I would very much like Dad to go back to working in a company.

Friday, 16th December

In science class Jong-gu asked Ms Kim Nan-ju if it was true the universe keeps expanding. The teacher said ‘Jong-gu you’ve been watching the news recently haven’t you? Physicists who won the Nobel Prize showed that the universe is expanding faster and faster. But why it’s speeding up nobody knows yet. Researchers hope a lot of questions will be answered when they uncover the secret of dark matter and dark energy. Whoever among you discovers them could win a Nobel Prize.’

The words dark matter and dark energy felt oddly familiar. Which makes sense. I’d been wracking my brain for days trying to find them. So without thinking I raised my hand and asked a question I shouldn’t have. ‘Miss... and when will the eleven-dimensional universe be proved?’

The whole class burst out laughing. The teacher smiled and said ‘We’ll study that later.’ because the bell had just rung.

Since then the pupils have been calling me Eleven Dimensions.

Saturday, 17th December

Hee-jeong asked where I’d heard the universe had eleven dimensions. So I told her what Dad said at breakfast the day before yesterday. And then Hee-jeong said ‘My dad believes in the eleven-dimensional universe too. He says there could be as many universes as you like in addition to ours. In another universe there could be people exactly like us except there we might not be pupils but teachers. And we might have three hands instead of two with an extra hand on our chest. He says the whole universe is made of particles and the combination of particles is basically a question of probabilities. If the universe has eleven dimensions it’s

because six tiny dimensions are added onto our four familiar ones. So small you can't see them. And then one more dimension made of a huge membrane. So that makes eleven but our eyes can't see them.'

Of course all of that came from her father. Hee-jeong says she's heard it so often she can practically recite it now. She didn't even breathe while she was talking. I thought I was the one who was going to suffocate.

Honestly who cares how many dimensions there are? The love between Hee-jeong and me is far more important. Sherlock Holmes didn't even know the Earth goes round the sun and he didn't even know it was round. And yet how many cases did he solve? I need to let go of the universe's dimensions.

Sunday, 18th December

Jong-gu called first thing in the morning. 'Good morning Mr Eleven Dimensions.' I wanted to rip the battery out of my phone in one clean motion.

Monday, 19th December

A traffic accident happened on the pedestrian crossing in front of school. Two first-years coming to class were hit and the emergency services 999 came. Luckily their lives aren't in danger but they'll have to walk on crutches for a while. The cause is ridiculous. The driver was looking at his texts instead of the road. That idiot didn't even notice the lights had gone red and didn't brake.

Our form teacher lectured us during morning assembly. There are too many people looking at their phones while driving and everyone needs to be more careful.

The smartphone curse? Whenever people do something they're always doing something else on their phone at the same time. In the cinema during a film while driving walking down the street. Did Steve Jobs imagine humans would end up like this?

Anyway it's sad. In a few days it'll finally be the winter holidays and those kids won't even be able to enjoy them.

Tuesday, 20th December

Heavy snow fell from dawn. In the garden it piled up to knee height. You couldn't even open the gate. If only school had been cancelled just for today! The bus didn't come. I shivered at the stop for over twenty minutes. I arrived late. But most of the latecomers were from Gugil-dong so we didn't get told off.

Wednesday, 21st December

Here is this year's Christmas present list. To buy everything I think I'd need to put on a mask and rob a bank.

- Christmas Present List –

- Hee-jeong: A scarf (It absolutely must be wool).
- Mum: Lotion (Luckily the brand she uses isn't expensive. Good skin is definitely genetic).
- Dad: A nail-clippers set (He strictly needs this).
- Grandfather: A set of socks.
- Grandmother: A set of socks.
- Aunt Jeong-su: Volume 1 of One Day (I asked her frankly on the phone. Aunt hates useless gifts more than anything. Better to ask straight out and buy what you're told).

- My uncle: Volume 2 of One Day (No need to ask him. Just buy what Aunt picked).
- Dong-wan: A Christmas card and a diary (A recommendation to write a diary in the New Year).
- Jong-gu, Hye-seon, Min-a: A small notebook each (This is a gift significantly beyond what you deserve).
- Mr Sisina: Warm woollen gloves (Compared to Sri Lanka just how cold is Seoul!).

Thursday, 22nd December

I emptied my entire piggy bank to buy the Christmas presents. To make it worth it I need to draw up the list of gifts I want to receive as soon as possible.

- Christmas Gifts I Want to Receive -

- Hee-jeong. From you I want nothing but love. If it's a kiss on the cheek I will accept it gratefully.
- Mum. A Pelikan fountain pen would be nice.
- Dad. What can you expect from an unemployed father? A bicycle would do. I want to keep it at Aunt Jeong-su's and in spring I want to ride it with Hee-jeong. I don't want to keep borrowing Hee-jeong's brother's bike.
- Grandfather and Grandmother. A bicycle helmet would be nice. Hee-jeong's brother's helmet is too big. I want to stop wearing it.
- Aunt Jeong-su. She teaches me maths for free. I can't ask for anything more.
- My uncle. He earns loads so he should buy me the latest smartphone. It will bring him inner peace. I'm his only nephew on earth aren't I?
- Dong-wan. I leave it to your conscience.
- Jong-gu, Hye-seon, Min-a. Prove you have a conscience!

- Mr Sisina. Save up quickly and go back to your family in Sri Lanka. When I'm an adult I'll come and see you.

I stuck the list of gifts I want in a very visible place on the fridge door. This Saturday is the start of the Christmas holidays so no maths or English lessons. I wish Christmas came twice a year. Three times would be even better.

Friday, 23rd December

I don't understand why nobody reacts to the wish list I stuck up. Have Mum and Dad already got presbyopia?

Saturday, 24th December

Mr Sisina gave me black tea sent from Sri Lanka. He said he'd also given some to Hee-jeong's family and Dong-wan's family. I gave him warm woollen gloves. Seeing him happy made me happy too.

Sunday, 25th December (Christmas Day)

It's Christmas. In our house nobody believes in Jesus Christ as a god but nobody really hates Jesus either. What did Jesus ever do wrong? The problem is the people who believe in him.

As soon as I woke up I gave Mum and Dad their Christmas presents. Mum was pleased to have an extra lotion on top of the one she normally uses and Dad was pleased to have his own nail clippers. In fact whatever I gave them they'd be happy.

Mum and Dad handed me a small box with a bicycle key inside. They said a bicycle was waiting for me at Aunt Jeong-su's and that I must ride only on the cycle paths of

Bamseom and along the Han River and nowhere else. In our neighbourhood of Gugil-dong there are no cycle lanes so I promised I'd never ride there.

With the bike key in my hand I wanted to dash straight to Aunt Jeong-su's but first I stopped by Grandfather's. I gave Grandfather and Grandmother a set of socks each. They were delighted. They said I could check my present when I got to Aunt Jeong-su's. I hurried over.

I gave Aunt Jeong-su *Volume 1 of One Day* and my uncle *Volume 2*. Aunt gave me a Pelikan fountain pen. Wow. My uncle gave me black ink. It looks like that miser is trying to buy yet another house. The pen Aunt gave me is a Pelikan M150. The filling system is unbelievably simple. I didn't get ink on my hands at all and it holds a lot. My uncle explained in English that the nib is an EF nib. Which must mean it's very fine. You only have to draw one line to understand that. I have the feeling my uncle will give me nothing but ink for ten years. I'll have to take measures soon.

I tried riding the bicycle Mum and Dad gave me—picked up from my uncle—but it was so cold I didn't even make it a hundred metres. Even wearing the helmet from Grandfather and Grandmother I was freezing so I retreated back to Aunt's. Until spring the bicycle will stay on Aunt Jeong-su's balcony.

After leaving Aunt's I went to Hee-jeong's. Her mother made us hot cocoa. While drinking it I gave Hee-jeong a scarf. Hee-jeong gave me a men's skincare set and everywhere it said in huge letters For Men and HOMME. Whoa.

Goodbye Johnson & Johnson baby lotion.

Farewell Nivea.

Monday, 26th December

Hee-jeong came to school wearing a white wool scarf round her neck. If only I were that scarf.

Tuesday, 27th December

Aunt Jeong-su and my uncle have decided they're coming on the Sokcho trip too. They wouldn't suggest we do maths in Sokcho would they?

Wednesday, 28th December

From today it's the winter holidays. But after school I went to Aunt Jeong-su's with Hee-jeong. Aunt said if we skipped maths this week too that would make two weeks in a row. So today we do maths. My mind was miles away and being forced to solve maths problems made me mad with boredom. Hee-jeong however doesn't seem to care. She solves everything perfectly.

Aunt gave me a mountain of maths homework. I have to come back tomorrow morning for marking. Ah... what a life.

Thursday, 29th December

Yesterday I spent the entire day doing Aunt Jeong-su's maths homework. I completely wasted the first day of my holiday. Early this morning I went to get it checked. Me. Approved. Hee-jeong. Approved too.

Hee-jeong and I went to see a film we'd been waiting for since last week. At the cinema entrance the older girl checking tickets asked how old we were. We said fourteen but she didn't believe us. We had to show our student cards. She looked like she had a cold. I don't put on Nivea like a little kid anymore and yet I'd generously applied the for men products all over my face. She clearly couldn't tell the difference.

When I got home I packed my bag for Sokcho tomorrow. At first I wanted to travel light because it's only two nights but since we're going by car there was no need. Mum saw my things and told me to remove half. So I took out a spare pair of jeans, a spare padded jacket, duvet parka, spare trainers, hiking boots, a small daypack, spare towels, spare underwear, pyjamas and so on.

Friday, 30th December

We decided to travel as twelve people in three cars. Luckily I'm not in Aunt Jeong-su's car. Our car has seven seats so there will be five of us in it.

- Car 1. Hee-jeong's dad, Hee-jeong's mum, Hee-jeong's older brother
- Car 2. Dong-wan's dad, Dong-wan's mum, Aunt Jeong-su, my uncle
- Car 3. Dad, Mum, me, Hee-jeong, Dong-wan

07.00 Everyone meets in the car park of Hee-jeong's apartment. Baduk was taken to Grandfather's early in the morning.

07.05 GPS set departure. We decide to drive without worrying about the others.

07.10 The road is already busy. Dad says they're people heading to the East Coast to see the sunrise.

07.15 Mum starts dozing. We speak quietly and Dad says he doesn't mind if he talks loudly. Mum eyes closed says she does mind. Dad corrects himself. She minds.

07.40 We enter the motorway.

08.05 Mum wakes up saying she slept well. She asks why we're so quiet. She says Dad can talk now. But when it's time to talk we have nothing to say. I think I need to learn to drive quickly.

08.15 Hee-jeong starts dozing her head against my shoulder.

08.25 Half-asleep Hee-jeong takes my arm.

08.30 Dong-wan is dying of jealousy.

09.45 Hee-jeong shakes me awake. I'd been sleeping with my mouth open.

09.50 We arrive at the village below Baekdamsa. All twelve of us have breakfast at a dried pollack soup restaurant. The non-drivers each have a glass of makgeolli. Dad doesn't drink because he has to drive. One glass becomes two and we lose a lot of time.

11.10 We pass through the Misiryeong Tunnel. We stop take souvenir photos.

11.15 A two-shot photo with Hee-jeong majestic Ulsanbawi behind us. We both do V-signs.

11.20 Hee-jeong's older brother and Dong-wan also take a V-sign photo. I am not jealous at all.

12.00 We arrive at the Seoraksan condo. I panic for a moment thinking we'll share the same space with Aunt Jeong-su. But Dad says we'll sleep in groups according to which car we came in. Hee-jeong and I approve vigorously. Dad whispers in my ear. 'You'll repay me later.'

Room 507. Mum Dad me Hee-jeong's dad Hee-jeong's mum Hee-jeong's older brother Hee-jeong

Room 508. Dong-wan's dad Dong-wan's mum Dong-wan Aunt Jeong-su my uncle

14.00 Lunch. Naengmyeon. The adults love it saying Sokcho naengmyeon is delicious. Hee-jeong and I don't quite understand the taste and eat very little. Hee-jeong's older brother eats extremely well.

15.40 We arrive at the Seoraksan car park.

16.10 We decide to take the cable car up to Gwongeumseong.

17.15 We reach the top. The wind is fierce. I say all the trees have Elvis Presley hair—slicked back. Hee-jeong bursts out laughing. She says she's cold and clings hard to my arm.

18.00 Back to the Seoraksan car park.

18.45 At Sokcho Central Market we buy sashimi and various seafood.

18.50 Cars 1 and 2 leave first for the condo.

19.10 Car 3 leaves too carrying the prepared fish.

19.40 Dinner. The dads drink soju and beer with the sashimi. The mums drink wine with elegance. Hee-jeong's dad gives a beer to Hee-jeong's older brother to praise him for working hard. He downs it comfortably then drinks with the adults. Dad says he has to drive tomorrow so Mum allows only three shots of soju. Dad saves one shot as if it were an entire bottle.

20.40 Hee-jeong Dong-wan and I play cards.

22.00 Dong-wan says he'll go to sleep first and returns to Room 508. What a friend. Quick on the uptake and wonderfully so.

22.30 The heaviest things in the world. Eyelids. I'm exhausted and can't play any more. I wash and go to bed.

Saturday, 31st December

07.00 I'm the first up and take a shower just in case the bathroom gets crowded.

07.15 Sitting alone on the sofa I watch TV. A documentary about travelling in Spain is on.

Hee-jeong comes into the bathroom her face all crumpled.

07.30 Hee-jeong returns and sits next to me perfectly dressed. Southern Spain doesn't look cold even in winter. I think I'd like to go to Spain on a honeymoon with Hee-jeong. Of course I don't say it. But Hee-jeong suddenly says a honeymoon in Spain would be nice. A smile spreads across my face.

07.45 The adults get up and start washing.

08.00 Hee-jeong's dad comes to the sofa and watches the documentary with us. He asks Hee-jeong, 'Shall we go to Spain next year?' Hee-jeong and I answer, 'Yes!'

08.35 We go to Haksapyeong for breakfast. We eat sundubu and gomchi soup. Gomchi soup costs more than twice the sundubu. The adults order it as a hangover cure from last night.

Hee-jeong's mum says in the past nobody even ate gomchi. They threw it away. It was soft ugly cheap fish. Now it's rare and very expensive.

09.40 We set off for Naksansa. We pair up to walk around. Dong-wan pairs with Hee-jeong's older brother. I walk with Hee-jeong taking the icy sea wind full in the face.

10.45 Hee-jeong's dad discreetly signals Dong-wan's dad. 'A shot of soju?' Dong-wan's dad looks at his watch and signals back. 'Too early.' Sophisticated communication with no words. It's like sign language. It must be a language you learn naturally once you become an adult.

11.05 My uncle says it's cold and we should stop walking. The mums agree. My uncle suggests, 'Shall we go somewhere warm for a shot of soju with some yangmiri?' Aunt Jeong-su snaps. 'Alcohol in the morning?' My uncle alarmed says he was joking.

11.10 Everyone gets coffee in the Naksansa car park.

11.20 We head for Hwaamsa Temple in Goseong.

12.00 We arrive at Hwaamsa. They say the original name was Hwaomsa and that the temple was founded in the Silla period. And astonishingly. The very spot where Hwaamsa stands is said to be the far end of Geumgangsan. I thought Geumgangsan existed only in North Korea but apparently not.

12.20 Aunt Jeong-su stares at the fermentation jars for a long time then finally lifts a lid. Hee-jeong rushes over too to see what's inside. I signal for Aunt to stop worried a monk might scold her but she doesn't care at all.

12.35 Aunt Jeong-su Hee-jeong and Dong-wan climb onto Subawi Rock at Hwaamsa. It's slippery so they don't go very high.

13.10 Lunch. We eat mulhoe in a coastal village in Goseong. The dads desperately want soju but the mums refuse. We decide we'll drink in the evening.

14.05 Hee-jeong's mum Aunt Jeong-su Hee-jeong and I don't go back to the condo. We go to Yeongrangho Lake. The others return to the condo for a nap.

15.00 We arrive at Yeongrangho. We go to Beombawi Rock. But it doesn't look like a tiger rock. It looks more like a dinosaur egg. Hee-jeong and I promise not to call it Beombawi anymore but Dinosaur Egg Rock. We invent a word that's only ours.

16.05 We arrive at Yeonggeumjeong. The East Sea spreads out. Vast and fresh. I ask Aunt Jeong-su. 'For us it's the East Sea but for Japan it's the West Sea. So why does everyone have to say East Sea?' Aunt Jeong-su pulls a stern face and says. 'The original name is East Sea. We can't abandon it. If we give it up and call it something else Japan will claim even more strongly that Dokdo is their territory. And even the undersea place names could be imposed according to Japan's will.' Hee-jeong's mum adds that Dokdo and the East Sea issue is an extension of Japan's invasion war on the peninsula and that by Japan's claims that war isn't really over. I'm stunned and say I don't understand. Then she explains that Dokdo was the first land Japan took when it launched the Russo-Japanese War even before the Eulsa Treaty and that it was the starting point for invading the whole peninsula. She says Japan apologises all the time but they're just words without sincerity. And that Japan's claims over Dokdo and the East Sea are used to justify its past colonial domination of Korea. It's sovereignty we can never give up. When I go 'Wow!' she tells me that at university she did activities in a Dokdo study club. My future mother-in-law is unbelievably classy.

16.25 Thanks to Dokdo and the East Sea I'm completely frozen.

17.30 We buy sashimi and local specialities at Sokcho Central Market then return to the condo.

17.55 Dinner begins. The dads drink soju with the seafood. Since Mum will drive tomorrow Dad also drinks a few beers. Hee-jeong's older brother drinks extremely well with no distinction between soju and beer.

19.55 We go back to the room and I read a book with Hee-jeong. Well. I read and Hee-jeong listens.

22.30 Since we're going to see the sunrise tomorrow everyone goes to bed early.

CHAPTER 11

January

Operation Cat Rescue

Sunday, 1st January

The new year began but nothing really changed from yesterday. From six in the morning everyone was fussing about going to watch the sunrise. At seven we left the condo and went to Yeonggeumjeong. The car park was already rammed. After we somehow managed to squeeze the car in we found a decent spot with a good view. At 7.20 there was still no sign of the sun. Then my uncle suddenly yelled ‘There it is!’ but it wasn’t the sun. It was the light on a squid-fishing boat.

Around 7.40 the sun finally started to haul itself out of the sea. Hee-jeong and I held hands and looked at each other and laughed.

We took a few quick souvenir photos then got straight back into the cars for Seoul. Aunt Jeong-su had put the fear of God into us. If we dawdled we’d spend hours just getting out through Misiryeong Tunnel. By the time we were speeding towards the tunnel the sun was already high over our heads. We got through Misiryeong without any trouble and had breakfast at the dried pollack village in Yongdae-ri. This time nobody asked for soju. With

the exception of my dad the other dads go back to work tomorrow. When you remember you've got a job alcohol must taste like nothing.

Thanks to my uncle we didn't hang about and left quickly. Result. No traffic. And we got back to Seoul safely.

Monday, 2nd January

Mum went to work, Dad wrote in his workshop and I made my resolutions for the year.

- New Year's Resolutions for Mr Heo Byeok -

- Be loyal to Hee-jeong!
- Don't run on the stairs.
- Don't eat too fast.
- Stand up straight.
- After reading put books back on Dad's bookshelf.
- Don't abandon a book halfway. Finish it.
- Cycle carefully.
- Clean Baduk's kennel properly.
- Help people in trouble when I see them.
- Listen to my parents. Especially Mum.
- As for Dad. Listen but filter what he says.
- Work seriously at school.
- Study a bit of music and art.

Tuesday, 3rd January

Mum saw my New Year's Resolutions and praised me. She found No. 10 listen especially to Mum very cute. And No. 11 filter what Dad says also very cute.

She told Dad to make one too. Dad resisted 'What am I a child?' He said he'd already submitted his sabbatical plan and that was enough. The more Dad lives like a carefree grasshopper the more solid his confidence becomes.

Mum insisted 'That was that. Now you need New Year's Resolutions as well.' Dad just laughed 'Alright alright.' Mum said if he didn't write one she would do it for him. Dad agreed calmly. So Mum decided this.

- New Year's Resolutions for Heo Su-jeong -

- If you eat like an animal you'll end up a pig.
- If you don't brush your teeth after eating you'll end up with dentures.
- If you spend blindly you'll end up a tramp.
- If you don't listen to your wife you'll end up single.

Mum printed it out and put it up in Dad's workshop and in the bedroom. Dad looks worried. Especially about No. 4. It seems to be physically shaking him.

Wednesday, 4th January

Hee-jeong and I went to volunteer at a nursery run by the district office. During the holidays we decided we'd go every Wednesday from 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. In truth volunteering just means helping the teachers gather the little ones, helping them eat their snacks, helping them play, tidying the shoe cubbies they trash, helping with lunch, helping with cleaning and wiping filthy windows, shovelling yesterday's snow and that's that. Ow. My back. Hee-jeong got properly exhausted after going yesterday. Alert.

Thursday, 5th January

This morning I went to see Hee-jeong. She'd slept well and she didn't look as worrying as I'd feared. Her mum made us hot cocoa and we drank it together before I went home.

When I got back Baduk had vanished. The gate was firmly shut and there was no trace of him anywhere. When I asked Dad he said he didn't know either. He'd been in the workshop all morning. Apart from the gate there was nowhere Baduk could possibly have gone out. I turned into Sherlock Holmes and searched the entire house. Nothing had changed. Only one thing bothered me. Baduk's food bowl had disappeared as well. When I pointed it out Dad said we might have had a dog thief. At that my legs gave way and I dropped onto the floor.

Dad and I wandered around the neighbourhood for over an hour and found no sign of Baduk. I cried so much my eyes were swollen. Dad offered to buy me another dog but it didn't comfort me. Baduk is not replaceable.

Exhausted we opened the gate and Baduk came running towards me from the yard tail wagging. Dad and I stared at each other stunned.

'Baduk where have you been?'

Woof. Woof. Woof.

I hugged him delirious with relief but Baduk tried to wriggle free tugging at my trousers with his mouth. Then he ran towards the back of the house. He turned around and barked as if calling us. Dad and I realised something was off and followed him. Under the back wall Baduk had slipped through a small hole. The little criminal had dug himself a secret exit without telling us. He wasn't secretly sleeping outside at night was he?

Baduk kept barking on the other side of the wall. We couldn't climb over so we ran round through the gate and chased after him. He stopped in front of a drain cover and barked signalling us to come closer.

Inside a mother cat and her three kittens half dead with exhaustion were huddled together. Dad took off his coat and gently wrapped the kittens. The mother growled for a moment but Baduk barked at her and she calmed down. I did what Dad did and wrapped the mother cat in my coat. Baduk meanwhile retrieved his bowl that had fallen into the drain. We rushed home.

Dad found the cleanest cardboard box in the storeroom cut an opening and set up a warm blanket inside. We washed the mother and the kittens in lukewarm water then dried them with a hairdryer. I warmed four small saucers of kitten milk just right. After handing the cats over to us Baduk strolled around the living room and the upstairs bedrooms as if touring a museum. Since he normally lives outside in the yard he'd never been in the house. I hope he didn't feel betrayed when he discovered the living room's comfort.

When Mum came home from work she asked why Baduk was in the living room. Dad sat her down on the sofa first then told her the whole story. She let out a long sigh. I thought she was discouraged because now we had cats as well but I was wrong. When she saw the cats in the box she softened and praised Dad me and especially Baduk—the hero of the day.

Baduk even got a special meal. After that he had to go back out to his kennel in the yard. Sorry Baduk. In our house Mum distinguishes very strictly between duty and privilege.

Friday, 6th January

In the morning Dad and I blocked up Baduk's secret passage. He looked genuinely disappointed but we had no choice. Saving cats is admirable but sneaking out and spending the night outside is unacceptable. A timid owner might even feel betrayed wouldn't he?

I warned him. If he starts roaming outside on his own again I'll put him on a lead even in the yard. I told him very sternly that I too had learned to distinguish strictly between private life and service. He lowered his head miserable as if he understood.

Saturday, 7th January

After maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su's Hee-jeong came to my house. On the way I told her about Baduk's feat. She laughed and said he must be a distant cousin of the Jindo.

Dad made us fried rice for lunch. Apart from instant noodles it's the dish he does best. He can make a few basic side dishes because Mum taught him but it's more food for survival than food for flavour. Since Dad started running the household my nutrition has frankly become seriously unbalanced. Anyway. Because he'd studied fried rice for ages focusing on one single dish it was delicious. Hee-jeong said it was the best fried rice in the world. Dad revealed his big secret today. You have to use cold rice. What? Are there people out there making fried rice with hot rice?

After lunch the two of us went down to Dad's workshop. He tried to yank the New Year's Resolutions off the wall in a panic but it was too late. Hee-jeong already had a grin from ear to ear.

She loved my resolutions for the year. Especially No. 1. Be loyal to Hee-jeong. She looked very proud. And because she was happy my own heart felt like it was overflowing.

Dad played us an album. *Time Out* by Dave Brubeck. One track felt instantly familiar. 'Take Five'. That lively piece the bungeo-ppang Hyung had introduced me to. Seeing Hee-jeong and me getting into it Dad told us the composer was Paul Desmond. He added that when Brubeck and Desmond work together it produces masterpieces but when they each release solo albums the music becomes strangely flat.

Perhaps the Brubeck and Desmond relationship was like the one between Hee-jeong and me.

Sunday, 8th January

The kittens are recovering quickly. Mum and Dad can't decide whether to keep them or not. To be honest Dad and I aren't really in a position to say let's keep them since Mum is the one supporting Dad, me and Baduk. She said we'd postpone the decision until the cats were completely better.

Monday, 9th January

These days Dad does nothing but loaf about in his workshop. When Mum comes home and asks 'So did you write well today?' Dad replies 'Yes I'm working hard.' But when I go down and look he's listening to music or reading. Of course according to Dad all of that counts as work.

Tuesday, 10th January

Hee-jeong and I talked a lot about the future. She's torn. A general high school or an art school to prepare for fine art.

I said 'With your grades couldn't you even go to a science high school?'

She replied 'My mum hates that kind of school.'

'Why?'

'She says if you're going to study and then work in a company anyway it makes no difference. And because she worked for a long time she tells my brother and me that the best thing is to do what we like.'

'But everyone wants to go to a science high school don't they?'

‘Only strong students go there so the competition is even harder. So if I don’t want it she doesn’t want to send me.’

‘Really?’

‘Yes. And I don’t like it either. When I look at my cousins—good universities and they still struggle to find jobs. And when they finally do work all they say is they’re absolutely shattered every day.’

‘The bungeo-ppang Hyung said something like that too.’

‘I think like your dad doing what you really want is best. My dad also says one day when the time comes he’ll make a film.’

‘Seriously?’

‘Yeah. Apparently with a small camera you can film by yourself and edit on a computer. And you don’t necessarily need actors to make a film. I don’t know what he’ll shoot but I’m looking forward to it.’

‘Dong-wan says he wants to be a judge.’

‘Yeah that would suit him wouldn’t it?’

‘It would.’

‘I’m hesitating too. Maybe I’ll go to art school like my brother. He told me I’ve got talent and I should go to a studio.’ Hee-jeong’s face went a bit serious. ‘My mum and dad agree. But I don’t know if I truly want to make art.’

‘Why? You draw well.’

‘Other than art homework and that poetry-and-drawing exhibition I haven’t actually drawn that much. I don’t think I have that desire yet, to draw on my own or to express something. My brother thinks about drawing twenty-four hours a day.’

‘When did he start?’

‘Since the summer of Year 11, he’s gone to a studio. My parents weren’t against it but one teacher was—he said it was a shame because my brother was good in class. And you Byeok?’

‘Me? I don’t know yet.’

‘You have a very nice voice when you read.’

Today I decided. My dream is to become a voice actor.

Wednesday, 11th January

Whatever happens I will never become a nursery teacher. I thought I was going to die. All morning Hee-jeong and I ran after the little ones. They never get tired. Endurance of steel. I ought to find out what their families feed them at home. At this rate if I volunteer a few more days I’ll end up being volunteered myself.

When I got home the kittens had turned the living room into a complete mess. They’d ripped a sofa cushion open and the white stuffing was all over the floor like snow. I was already in pieces and then I completely finished myself off with cleaning.

Thursday, 12th January

In the end I got ill. I feel as if my whole body has been beaten up. Nursery teachers. Honestly I respect them. I still haven’t done the maths homework Aunt Jeong-su gave me. I’m just hoping I’ll be ill only until Saturday morning no longer.

Friday, 13th January

I called Aunt Jeong-su to say I wanted to miss tomorrow’s maths lesson. She said if I was that irresponsible what was the point of studying. Better to skip forever. When I told her it wasn’t that, but that I was ill she told me to stop acting and come tomorrow with the maths

homework without fail. Thank goodness she didn't have children. The person who would have been my cousin would've turned into a rebel from being nagged to death.

I spent the afternoon doing the maths homework. Strangely once I finished everything it felt like the illness disappeared. I'm afraid people will think I was only ill because of the maths homework.

Saturday, 14th January

After maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su's Hee-jeong and I ate the dumpling soup she'd made. While we were eating I told her I was wondering what I'd become later.

'Don't think about what you want to become. Think about what you want to do.'

My uncle said something unusual. Something not very him. 'Yes your aunt is right. If you chase becoming you get bored quickly. What matters is what you do Byeok.'

Hee-jeong said 'Really? I don't quite understand.'

My uncle was serious. 'If you become a journalist just because you want to be a journalist you become nothing. What matters is what kind of journalist you are. You need an aim. What do you want to do as a journalist? There are loads of journalists. Even if you become one nothing changes. What matters is what you do.'

'Dong-wan says his dream is to be the most impartial judge in the world.'

My aunt asked 'That's a dream. Well said. Byeok what do you want to do?'

'Me... I don't know yet.'

My uncle smiled 'Then think calmly. You're still in secondary school.'

Hee-jeong asked Aunt Jeong-su. 'Miss when you were young did you have a dream?'

She replied 'Of course. I dreamed of being a pilot flying a plane. But my family was poor. Even when I got into university on a scholarship I couldn't go. I only entered university six years after finishing high school. And when I finally graduated I couldn't get hired

because of my age. I was already thirty. I had to be independent and earn a living so I ended up teaching maths to students. I had a dream but reality pushed me there. And yet today I'm happy.'

'Then that's fine.' my uncle said.

'And you sir?'

He answered 'Me? My dream was to marry your Aunt Jeong-su.'

Hee-jeong asked astonished 'Really?'

He said 'Yes. At university she was the prettiest and the brightest in our school. For a whole term I followed her around calling her Noona. The seniors in my department wanted to date her but me—fresh back from the army—I ended up going out with her. Until graduation the seniors bullied me. I thought I was going to die honestly.'

'Wow. You're incredible.'

He glanced at my aunt then continued 'Yep. They say the brave wins the beauty. The seniors liked her but they couldn't even speak to her. Byeok you know it. Your aunt isn't like everyone else. I wasn't scared. I asked her straight out to go out with me.'

'Madam is that true?'

'Of course. Before he dated me your uncle only got Fs. But the moment we got together he got a scholarship until graduation. I told him. If you want to date me become a scholarship student. Then you'll finish your studies and get a job. I told him I'd marry him if he became someone who could earn his own living. And would you believe it. The hopeless student became a scholarship student overnight. Then he got a job as soon as he graduated.'

'In your family nobody objected to you marrying an older woman?'

He burst out laughing. 'Object? Why? They were delighted! It's just that I was a bit immature.'

Right. It's decided. From today my dream is to marry Hee-jeong!

Sunday, 15th January

It's Dad's birthday. I gave him a Moleskine notebook. The one he'd wanted for ages. It's just a notebook but it costs enough to make your eyes pop out. Still I told myself it must be essential for an author's life so I gathered my courage. As expected Dad was delighted. He signed the notebook and then looked triumphant as if he were already a famous writer. Mum gave him a book by Genji Maruyama. *The Resolution of a Novelist*. The colour drained from Dad's face. What kind of book is that?

Mr Sisina took the mother cat and the three kittens. He decided to raise all four at the factory where he works. We all got into Dad's car and went to the factory. Of course Baduk—the number one hero of the rescue—came too. It was a kitchen furniture factory. And unlike what I'd secretly feared it was huge and very clean. Mr Sisina led us behind the factory and showed us a cat house he'd just made. It was bigger and cleaner than Baduk's kennel. Dad and I felt reassured and handed over the four cats. Baduk looked very satisfied too.

Monday, 16th January

Genji Maruyama is truly an extraordinary writer. Just reading a few pages of *The Resolution of a Novelist* made it feel as if an electric current ran through my whole body. When I've finished it I'll think again about my dream. It was like finding a lighthouse in the middle of the ocean.

Dad needs to understand Mum's deeper intention in giving him this book. Even to me it looks like Dad is writing a novel but he's terribly short on novelist's resolution. And his sabbatical is already half over. What on earth is he thinking? Unless Dad thinks that since half still remains he has plenty of time.

Tuesday, 17th January

Dad keeps writing something in the workshop. When will a finished work finally appear? Is he still writing the story about the shadow thief? I'm curious. He looks like he's found his resolution again.

Reading *The Resolution of a Novelist* I found a passage that could become the lamp in my heart. I think I was too impatient. If someone asks me from now on what my dream is I'll quote this.

At that time I had already given up becoming a sailor. But I wasn't dejected. Because I had made no effort to become a sailor it couldn't be called a failure. In a way it also meant my possibilities were still wide—infininitely—open. If I discovered a path that felt right I could throw myself into it with all my strength. So until I find that path I decided to live quietly.

At last I feel a little calmer. I put *The Resolution of a Novelist* down and spent the evening reading Sherlock Holmes. This book is at my level and it's exciting. Life has become pleasant again. I worried for nothing.

Wednesday, 18th January

I went to volunteer at the nursery. Now that I'm getting used to it it wasn't very tiring today. The little ones listen well to what Hee-jeong and I say. Now I can see they really are adorable. That said I have no desire whatsoever to become a nursery teacher.

Lunar New Year is approaching. It's the biggest season of the year. I'll have to go and greet all the adults. Even the ones I never contact normally. If not now when would I? Of course it's absolutely not because of the New Year money.

Thursday, 19th January

Wow! My Samchon is coming back to Korea. He's Dad's younger brother. Six years younger. He went to Beijing three years ago for work as an expatriate. Now he's wrapped everything up and is returning to Seoul for good. The first year he came back to Seoul almost every month but since last year he's been so swamped he even worked Saturdays and Sundays. It's a bit of a shame. I should've visited him in Beijing at least once.

He really needs to get back before Lunar New Year. Of course not for the New Year money. It's just that on a holiday you do it with family don't you?

Friday, 20th January

It's Grandfather's birthday. I don't understand why everyone's birthdays in our family are bunched up in winter. To show my respect I gave him a set of handkerchiefs. Since he washes his hands often it's the most useful gift.

Happy birthday Grandfather. Please stay healthy always.

Saturday, 21st January

My Samchon came back. As soon as I finished studying at Aunt Jeong-su's I ran to Grandfather's. When he saw me my Samchon held out his hand to shake mine. Wow. He really is different. I no longer like being patted on the head. I'm a man who uses skincare that says For Men and HOMME.

Even though it isn't Lunar New Year yet he'd already given me a thick envelope of pocket money. He said 'Here. For you.'

He'll stay at Grandfather's for a while until he finds a place. When Grandmother asked if he didn't have any shipped belongings from China he said no. My Samchon always travels with a single bag. A real tough guy. Perfect edition. Let the one who hit Mr Sisina show his face.

Sunday, 22nd January

Even during the Lunar New Year holidays Dad doesn't come out of the workshop. It must be because of *The Resolution of a Novelist* Mum gave him. If a novelist didn't have to write novels it would be a fairly comfortable job. Get up drink coffee listen to music read go for walks loaf about. But there's one huge problem. You have to write. And that isn't a question of resolution. It's hard.

In the evening I went down to tell him to come and eat. He was working without even noticing I was there. I can't wait to see what kind of work his resolution gives birth to.

Monday, 23rd January (Lunar New Year)

It's Lunar New Year. Early in the morning we did the ancestral rite at Grandfather's then made our bows. Naturally I also collected a handsome amount of New Year money. My Samchon had already given me an envelope a few days ago but today he gave me money again. 'That was that and this is this.' he said. Since Aunt Jeong-su went to her in-laws with her husband I'll go and greet her tomorrow.

I had rice-cake soup for breakfast then went to Hee-jeong's to make my bows. Her parents said I did my greetings very well and they gave me generous New Year money. Her dad told me to buy something nice with Hee-jeong and have fun. He added that enjoying

yourself properly is more important than only working. Inside, I replied, Father-in-law don't worry. I'm extremely confident when it comes to having fun. But there's decorum and timing. I couldn't say it out loud could I?

Hee-jeong's mum said 'Our Byeok, this year too get on well with Hee-jeong.' That means she already sees me as a future son-in-law doesn't it?

Hee-jeong and I went to my grandparents' to make our bows. Hee-jeong received New Year money from my grandfather, my grandmother, my mother, my father and my Samchon. The two of us felt rich enough to buy a small flat. We arranged to go out together tomorrow morning.

I finished Aunt Jeong-su's maths homework in advance. I didn't want to worry about homework during our date.

Tuesday, 24th January

While Dad was making breakfast, Mum told him the travel agency would probably need to hire two or three more employees soon. But I think instead of hiring it would be better to hire Dad. Dad already understands Mum perfectly as a boss. From her expression he knows what to do. From her outfit he knows her mood. From her tone he can instantly decide whether to trigger the alarm. But I don't know how the agency employees would feel about that.

As soon as I finished eating I went to Hee-jeong's. Since I had a lot of pocket money in my pocket I dressed accordingly. I wore my favourite white trousers and a black sweater. Over that a wool coat and I wrapped a scarf around my neck. Even I thought I looked fairly classy.

Hee-jeong's mum opened the door and said 'Oh my goodness Byeok, you look elegant!' Hee-jeong wore jeans and a white sweater with a red duffle coat over the top. And

with the scarf I'd given her she wasn't merely cute. She was an angel. Her mum told us to be careful of weird people. We answered very loudly. 'Yes!'

Kyobo Book Centre was open even during the holiday and it made me feel a bit sorry for the employees working on a public holiday. While we were looking at books Hee-jeong gave me *Letters to a Young Novelist* by Mario Vargas Llosa. A letter written by a Nobel Prize winner for me. Nobody in the world needs to know how much my heart overflowed. Well. Nobody needs to know. It's enough that Hee-jeong and I know.

Wednesday, 25th January

Morning. Nursery volunteering. Afternoon. Holiday homework. That was my day. I don't understand why a young novelist needs holiday homework.

Thursday, 26th January

Every night I fall asleep hugging *Letters to a Young Novelist* Hee-jeong's gift. It feels too precious. I haven't even opened the first page.

Friday, 27th January

Letters to a Young Novelist has disappeared. I searched my room top to bottom like I was hunting fleas but I couldn't find it.

Alert.

Alert.

Alert.

Saturday, 28th January

At breakfast Dad handed me the book saying he'd read it and it was very good. I shouted 'Dad! Do you know how long I looked for that?!' Dad replied 'Oh did you?' as if it were nothing. I checked to see whether the book was damaged. And then I saw red broth stains all over it. When I asked what they were he said he'd been reading while eating instant noodles and some broth had splashed. Aaah.

As soon as I finished maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su's I ran to Kyobo. But they were out of stock. My whole body started to shake. The older sister at the counter told me there was one copy left at Kyobo in Gwanghwamun. I sprinted there. While I was running my heart hammered convinced someone would buy it before I arrived. Luckily it was still there. Nobody had taken it. I bought it hugged it tightly and went home.

I put the two books on my bed and thought very seriously for a long time. Which one would I love more? In the end I hugged the one stained with noodle broth. The clean one I'd just bought at Gwanghwamun I gave to Dad. Dad hugged me and thanked me.

In my head I told him. Dad finish the novel you're writing quickly and show it to me.

Sunday, 29th January

Without realising it tomorrow is already the first day back. I don't understand why between the winter holidays and the spring holidays we have to go back to school. There are hardly any real lessons. Can't we just remain on holiday?

Monday, 30th January

Back to school. During study period I took out the book Hee-jeong gave me and read it.

Dong-wan and Jong-gu asked what it was but instead of answering I just gave a crooked little smile.

Tuesday, 31st January

I finished the book Hee-jeong gave me—the one Dad splashed with noodle broth—*Letters to a Young Novelist* by Mario Vargas Llosa. From today my dream is clear. I will be a novelist. That dream will never change again. Today I engraved my writer's resolution into myself.

- Resolution of the Writer Heo Byeok -

- I will nurture an obsession inside me.
- I will go to the cinema and bookshops with it and we will never part.
- I will obey it faithfully like an inner voice.

CHAPTER 12

February

Open Up Life!

Wednesday, 1st February

I asked Dad when I'd finally be allowed to read the novel he's working on. He pressed each word dead serious. 'What I'm writing isn't a short story. It's a novel.' So I might not get to read it until after summer?

I went to Grandad's to run an errand for Dad. The stall of the bungeo-ppang Hyung still isn't there. Did he quit because it stopped paying? Or did he find another job? Every time I visit Grandad my small pleasure—eating a bungeo-ppang —has disappeared. I hope he's doing all right.

At Grandad's Gran loaded my arms with a huge box packed with marinated crab. Apparently Dad told her he'd been craving it. I brought it home but I'm a bit worried. I have a feeling a war is about to break out.

Thursday, 2nd February

As expected Mum gave Dad a proper dressing-down. You don't ask your mother-in-law, who isn't well, to cook for you. If Dad wanted marinated crab that badly he could have made it himself or bought it. Why beg his mum? Dad defended himself by saying that if you buy it 'it never tastes like that.' Mum didn't add another word but even I think Dad is clearly in the wrong.

A few years ago after Grandma's knee operation Mum and Dad decided we would stop taking kimchi and side dishes from her. Because Mum and Dad both work Grandma often cooks for them and Mum says it weighs on her. Back then Dad even thanked Mum and agreed. And now Dad's the first one to break the promise.

What's more point number 5 of Dad's sabbatical plan says. 'Never ask Mum to prepare food.' Mum asked Dad, on his way down to his workshop, whether from now on I'd be doing all the housework and whether he in that case would go back to working at a company. Dad said nothing. I have the feeling this cold war will last a while. Honestly why does Dad always go and poke Mum's pride?

Anyway... whatever happens Grandma's crab is a masterpiece. I had two bowls of rice. If the atmosphere between Mum and Dad had been good I could have managed three.

Friday, 3rd February

Dad still can't get over the marinated crab shock. In the workshop he isn't writing. He's only watching a horror film where Jack Nicholson walks around with an axe. I wish he'd apologise to Mum quickly. Or at least go for a little trip to Ganghwado one more time.

Dong-wan told me some good news. The thug who hit Mr Sisina turned out to be a repeat applicant and he failed again this year. Now he's forced to try a third time. When Dong-wan's father heard from the lawyer he apparently shouted 'Justice has triumphed!'

That really is excellent news. Go on you little thug. Serves you right. One more year and your house will look like a cemetery!

Saturday, 4th February

After maths and English at Aunt Jeong-su's I came home and found Mum and Dad cooking together in the kitchen. This morning we were still in a cold war. What happened? The place is overflowing with honey.

Please. Let Dad not smash any crockery today.

Sunday, 5th February

Hee-jeong and I went to the National Museum of Korea following her older brother. Seok-hee says that since being accepted into fine arts he goes to museums and galleries almost every day. Today Hee-jeong asked him especially to take us along.

I saw *The Uigwe of Oegyujanggak* with my own eyes. Something I'd only ever seen on television. It was a truly magnificent book. More beautiful more noble classier than the old books I'd seen at the Louvre. Seok-hee said those books were made for the king. Even the paper was the highest quality. And the binding, silk and metal, gave it an unbelievable elegance. As he said it might be the most beautiful book in the world.

In the Joseon painting gallery Seok-hee explained in detail how portraits were made. Because of Confucianism people were painted as they were. If someone had a squint they were painted with a squint. And if you erased even a smallpox scar the portrait was considered deceitful and vulgar. To the point where people might even doubt the subject's character.

But while Joseon did that the West erased anything ugly. Schubert for example was short and rather unattractive but in portraits he's painted like a handsome chap. Seok-hee said that in today's language they'd photoshopped him to death.

I hadn't noticed last time but today I saw that most objects were protected by glass. So in photos there were so many reflections you couldn't capture much. At the Louvre and the Musée d'Orsay though there were quite a few works not protected by glass.

While Hee-jeong was in the ladies' room Seok-hee casually dropped that first love never works out. He said he'd had a first love too and it didn't end well. Grr... I didn't think a trap would spring here! In my head I answered him. It's not that you don't know but Hee-jeong isn't my first love. In nursery there was Chae-yeon, in primary school there was Su-min. And I'm not even counting unrequited loves! But I wasn't going to say that out loud was I?

Taking me for a boy who thinks Hee-jeong is his first love. If someone heard that they'd think I'd lived in a vacuum until now. Does he take me for an idiot? Today my pride took a serious hit.

Monday, 6th February

Hee-jeong's father invited our family to dinner at their place this Saturday evening. Aunt Jeong-su and my uncle are invited too and Dong-wan's family as well. It's to celebrate Seok-hee getting into fine arts.

I'm going to have to slow-cook Seok-hee. What should I give him? I'll have to ask Hee-jeong.

Tuesday, 7th February

Hee-jeong's brother is going to driving school to get his licence. Sorry but a car is too much for me. Couldn't there be something else nice?

Dad doesn't budge from the workshop anymore. Mum finally told him to go for a walk for at least an hour a day. But Dad... what novel is he writing? I wish he'd tell me even the title.

In his workshop you don't even hear music anymore. And I'm banned from entering for a while too.

Wednesday, 8th February

Hee-jeong and I went to see the drawing academy Seok-hee recommended. He said he drew there for three years. Hee-jeong showed her sketchbook to the teacher and he praised her. 'You have talent.' As if anyone didn't know.

Hee-jeong decided to start going from these spring holidays. Even if she doesn't go to an art school or fine arts she wants to draw there little by little. Wow. Lucky her. So while she draws I should write in Dad's workshop. I can't spend my whole life solving maths problems can I? As a first topic world peace... that's a bit heavy. So something light? Clouds would be light. But what can you possibly write about clouds? Rabbit-cloud, sheep-cloud, candyfloss-cloud... no that won't do. What am I going to write?

Ah! I'll die of old age trying to find a topic!

Thursday, 9th February

Here is my first text. I put my thoughts in order about something that taught me a big lesson.

- My friends Mr Sisina and Dong-wan -

Are adults smarter than children? Adults say. 'You'll understand when you're older.' Is that true? Then is an experienced person necessarily wiser than someone without experience? People say that as you age you become wise and reasonable. But that isn't always true. If age and wisdom were proportional the world we live in should be just and happy. And yet around me there are many happy people but even more who aren't.

When I look at Mr Sisina who came from Sri Lanka I feel he's treated unfairly in Korea. All because his skin is darker than ours. He is handsome, educated and he has a lot of humour. But people don't look at that. When he gets on the underground they avoid him. They discriminate against him simply because of his skin colour without knowing anything about him or his country Sri Lanka.

In my class Dong-wan is good at school and sport. He has always been popular but it isn't the same now. Why? Because he ran in the class-rep election. Dong-wan's mother is of Mongolian origin. So in the past students mocked Dong-wan by calling him Mongolian Soy Sauce. In the corner of their hearts they think Dong-wan is like Mr Sisina a notch below. Being friends with him isn't a big problem but accepting him as class rep—that they won't do. When you see that adults or children it's the same. In my opinion age isn't the point. When it comes to discriminating against another human being nothing changes.

Grandad said that once human malice takes root it covers the whole Earth in an instant. That frightens me even more. Because it won't change.

They say experience makes you wise but I think experience in itself isn't much. Because if you grow old you inevitably gain a lot of experience and yet age doesn't guarantee wisdom. So what makes someone wise?

My day is a string of varied experiences. I'm still a student and I'm young. In my life there are more new things than repetitions. Among all these experiences two remain deeply engraved in me. The first is the forbidden book incident Hey, Wait... The second is the

memory of that Arab man who accompanied me to A&E in Paris with extraordinary kindness. Among all my experiences those are printed at the very back of my mind. Maybe what matters more than experience is the way you receive it.

Writing this gave me a headache all afternoon. I think I'll cool my brain down with some maths problems.

Friday, 10th February

Spring holidays have begun. Please from next year onwards abolish this absurd rule. Having to go back to school between winter holidays and spring holidays. When you play you should play properly. Being hauled out in the middle ruins everything. It's like coming back to sit at the table after going to the toilet halfway through a meal. Couldn't the President sort this out personally?

After the holiday-opening ceremony I went to play at Hee-jeong's for the first time in ages. Her brother wasn't there. He was probably at a museum. I showed her my text. Hee-jeong read it and told me it was noble bold and stylish.

She asked 'But what is *Hey, Wait...*?'

I said 'That? It's a comic. In our house it's a forbidden book.'

'A forbidden book... what's that?'

'Books Dad told me not to read until Year 11. He says it's not the time yet.'

Hee-jeong asked eyes full of curiosity.

'So?'

I shook my head.

'I read that weird book in secret... and it was like a shock. It was really strange. It was sad and it left a feeling of emptiness.'

Hee-jeong leaned in.

‘Show it to me too.’

‘Impossible. I don’t have the key to the bookshelf.’

‘Even without the key you know how to open it don’t you?’

‘...’

I said nothing. My heart was pounding like mad.

Hee-jeong sprang up from the sofa.

‘Byeok come on! Let’s go to yours!’

Ah! My God... why are you giving me a punishment like this?

When I got home I learned my uncle had borrowed all of Dad’s comics. Of course *Hey, Wait...* was in there. It seems my uncle’s return was the will of God.

Why does a text written with good intentions produce such a ridiculous result?

Saturday, 11th February

Mr Jamie is finally leaving next Friday for Boston for a three-night four-day trip. I told him once again clearly. ‘Bon voyage!’ He said he would draw a lot during the trip. I hope he has a good time.

After lessons at Aunt Jeong-su’s Hee-jeong and I went to Kyobo Book Centre. We had to buy a present for Seok-hee. Hee-jeong asked him and apparently he said ‘If Byeok absolutely insists on giving me a gift he can give me *The Woman in the Dunes* by Abe Kobo.’ I’m not exactly dying to give a gift. He must have misunderstood something.

At the till the cashier asked why young people were buying a book like that. Hee-jeong said it was a present for her older brother who was about to enter fine arts. The cashier said ‘This isn’t a book for you.’ and handed it over. On the bus home Hee-jeong read the whole way.

Why do well-intentioned words sometimes end up hurting people?

Sunday, 12th February

Seok-hee's admission party finally ended at one in the morning. But the hero of the day Seok-hee just ate then said he was going to read *The Woman in the Dunes* and shut himself in his room without coming out. The gift seems to have worked.

Mum and Dad slept in today. Fair enough. Yesterday they drank and enjoyed themselves late into the night. I got up early and went to Grandad's. My uncle had spread Dad's comics everywhere. In secret I searched for *Hey, Wait...* but couldn't find it. Because my uncle was sitting on it. I pushed my uncle aside and gently pulled the book out. Ow. The cover tore a little.

I took the book and went to Hee-jeong's. But she said she'd already read *Hey, Wait...* Yesterday while I was looking for *The Woman in the Dunes* in the bookshop she bought *Hey, Wait...* first and slipped it into her bag.

So this is Adam's heart after being defeated by Eve!

Monday, 13th February

I went to Grandad's early. I was going to quietly put *Hey, Wait...* back in my uncle's room... but he caught me.

He asked 'Byeok was it you who took it? I looked for it for ages.'

'Ah yes... sorry.' My heart was thumping.

'Honestly I didn't find it very interesting.'

I stared at him stunned 'Sorry?'

He muttered 'Life's like that eh.'

Today I understood there are two types of human beings in the world.

The Dad type and the Uncle type!

Tuesday, 14th February

Hee-jeong is more the Uncle type. Even after reading *Hey, Wait...* she has no inner agitation at all. Is it because she's the type to go on hunger strike all the way to the end? Or because she's the type to declare a hunger strike then secretly eat Choco Pies behind your back? Either way she's a bit different from me.

Wednesday, 15th February

Dad told Mum he needed the waist of his trousers let out and got blown up. For the last few days he's been able to put the trousers on but not eat while wearing them. The moment he eats he can't breathe.

Mum hates that Dad under the excuse of work breaks all the rules of living. These days Dad hardly exercises he stays shut in the workshop. And at night he eats late-night snacks, every single night without exception. Mum warned him several times but Dad just answers 'All right all right' and changes nothing. And now he wants to let out his trousers.

One of Dad's New Year Resolution has already collapsed without mercy. 'If you eat like an animal you'll end up a pig.'

Thursday, 16th February

Jong-gu's parents have decided to divorce. This morning Dong-wan called me early overexcited to tell me. Since Jong-gu will live with his mother he'll finally be able to live with his older brother. In exchange he'll have to change schools to the neighbourhood where his mother is moving. But when I heard Jong-gu was happy I felt relieved. And yet somewhere inside I felt a small emptiness.

Friday, 17th February

In the end today Dad had the waist of three pairs of trousers let out by two inches. Mum gave up. She couldn't stand watching him unbutton them at every meal. The alteration costs will be deducted from Dad's pocket money. Dad doesn't care at all. He says he can finally breathe properly and he's happy.

Since getting his trousers back Dad no longer sucks in his stomach. But if he ends up with a belly sticking out like a tadpole that won't do...

Saturday, 18th February

After lessons at Aunt Jeong-su's Hee-jeong and I went to the drawing academy. Hee-jeong was drawing Jon and Bjorn in her sketchbook. I had a bad feeling. On the way out Hee-jeong said her head hurt from thinking about Jon and Bjorn then she leaned against me and started to cry. I held her tightly in my arms. And I said the words Dad once said to me. 'Hee-jeong for now we have to look only at beautiful things. Pretty things. Bright things. Anyway when we grow up we'll end up understanding everything. Let's not rush. Let's forget Jon and Bjorn. Sorry.' Hee-jeong buried her face in my shoulder cried and nodded.

Hee-jeong and I put Jason's *Hey, Wait...* into a big plastic bag then buried it in the flowerbed in front of our house. Baduk, thinking we were burying a bone, wagged his tail and tried to dig it up with his paws.

So I couldn't help saying to him. 'Baduk for now we have to look only at beautiful things. Pretty things. Bright things. You too when you're grown up you'll understand but don't rush. Jon and Bjorn are still too much for you!'

Hee-jeong burst out laughing. So did I. Laughter came back to us.

Sunday, 19th February

Seok-hee took us to the Seoul Museum of History with Hee-jeong. The building is big and nice but there were far too few objects on display. I was disappointed. Seok-hee said that during the Japanese occupation everything was looted and almost nothing remains in Korea. We have to recover those things but it isn't simple. Hee-jeong's family—perhaps because of her mother's influence—doesn't seem to have a very good opinion of Japan. But... if you think about it he's not wrong.

After the museum Seok-hee took us to a very chic café. I suppose because he studies art he always chooses places with a good atmosphere. But the coffee was truly awful. Anyway. Seok-hee said that now he's entering fine arts he's finally going to let loose. For three years he only did school and the academy. Now it's liberation. He says he'll travel around Korea and one day he'll go to Europe alone with a backpack. Of course he'll also go to China and Japan. And he even plans America.

I promised to give him brochures from Mum's travel agency. Mum is going to get rich.

Monday, 20th February

While Hee-jeong was at the academy I wrote a very short text.

- Hey, Wait... -

I was on the bus going home. Suddenly raindrops began to fall on the window. People rushed to take cover. The rain became so violent that even cars pulled over. The bus driver stopped too and waited for the rain to pass. A rainstorm that arrived without warning had just declared martial law on the street.

A man on a motorbike took refuge in a phone box. The box was covered in white frost. His helmet was swallowed by the frost and the man disappeared. That day under rain that fell like an invasion the city was conquered without mercy. When the frost invaded the inside of the bus we too were swallowed by the fog.

I showed it to Hee-jeong when she came out of the academy. She said it was a strange text with an unfamiliar sensation. And I liked hearing that. In truth everything Hee-jeong says pleases me.

Tuesday, 21st February

My Samchon moved. He left Grandad's house and moved into a tiny bedsit. My Samchon hates being held by anyone. I wonder how he even goes to work.

His belongings really were just one bag. You can barely call it a move. He'll live there for a while then return to his own flat. When he went to Beijing as an expat he rented his place out and the contract doesn't end until the end of the year. My Samchon said that even if it's small living in your own place is best. Obviously. I too when I'm an adult want to live alone with Hee-jeong in our own home.

Wednesday, 22nd February

Morning, Volunteering at the nursery. Afternoon, maths homework from Aunt Jeong-su until evening. When Dad saw the exercises he jumped. That's normal. Dad barely knows addition and subtraction. If a maths genius like me was born from a parent who's absolutely hopeless at maths it's only thanks to Aunt Jeong-su's heroic efforts.

At night I took *The Catcher in the Rye* from Dad's bookcase and started it. The hero is a weird bloke who lies the moment he opens his mouth. Why does Dad have three copies of this book?

Thursday, 23rd February

I stopped by Hee-jeong's to give Seok-hee brochures from Mum's travel agency. He took them and began reading from the first page with terrifying seriousness. Seok-hee is meticulous whatever he does. I was telling Hee-jeong I didn't understand why we had three copies of *The Catcher in the Rye* at home when Seok-hee said something frightening.

'You know John Lennon? The Beatles singer.'

I said 'Yes I know.'

He continued 'The one who assassinated him was Mark Chapman. And after killing John Lennon that guy apparently said everyone should read *The Catcher in the Rye*.'

'Seriously?'

'It's a bit of a twisted book. But why do you have three at your place?'

Ow... I need to find out whether something happened to Dad.

Friday, 24th February

After work my Samchon stopped by our house. He said he came to pick up the books he'd left here and he started selecting his books from Dad's bookshelf. At a glance there were at least two hundred. He took the three copies of *The Catcher in the Rye* as well. I even brought him the books that were in my room. My Samchon packed the three copies into a box with particular care.

I asked him why he had three. He didn't answer. He just smiled pfft and patted my head once.

What story is hiding behind all this?

Saturday, 25th February

Over breakfast I asked Mum why my Samchon had three copies of *The Catcher in the Rye*.

Mum looked at me for a moment then glanced at Dad.

Dad told me.

‘It’s a keepsake from your aunt. She liked that book.’

‘...’

I said nothing more. I ate in silence then went to study at Aunt Jeong-su’s.

Throughout the whole lesson the image of my Samchon, with that small crooked smile, wouldn’t leave my head. I’m too young and it’s too long ago so I have no memory of that aunt. I’ve only heard that my Samchon loved her with a terrible love. In our family we never speak of girlfriends or marrying again in front of my Samchon. I’ve been trained on that to the point my ears are worn out.

Yesterday I asked him a needless question. Sorry Samchon.

Sunday, 26th February

Last night I didn’t sleep a second. I thought about death. Why does everything have a beginning and an end? They say the beginning is the end and the end is another beginning. But what does that even mean?

The four cats Mr Sisina adopted might have died in that cold drain if Baduk hadn’t saved them. And by what luck did they survive, so they could now live at Mr Sisina’s factory cherished like treasures?

In our life what is a big event? What is a small thing? Is the big event coming first in the class and the small thing getting a hundred out of a hundred in a maths test? Or is the big

event becoming rich or someone honourable and the small thing forgetting to buy milk at the supermarket? What's the difference between big and small? And what if deep down there were no difference at all?

Sometimes the repeating days like a kind of madness disgust me. Is that weariness death? Or is that life? And if that is life...then getting older losing strength your body hurting more and more, does that mean death?

If Mum or Dad knew I was thinking about this what would they say? Does Hee-jeong ever think about this too? Have Dong-wan or Jong-gu ever once thought about life and death?

If there is a heaven I hope my aunt is happy there.

Monday, 27th February

Dad finished his novel. Wow! It's incredible. Dad told me he started writing because he liked it and that while writing he'd been happy. To celebrate he says he's going out for a drink with his friends. He's already getting ready to leave early in the evening. What novel is it?

Tuesday, 28th February

This year February has only twenty-eight days. If February always had thirty-one days without bothering about leap years, spring holidays would last three days longer.

Hee-jeong and I went cycling along the Han River. With cool wind on our faces we sped all the way to under Dongjak Bridge. We parked the bikes and walked. Hee-jeong thanked me. My mouth slid all by itself up to my ears. I thanked her too. Hee-jeong smiled. I smiled too.

Laughing together we walked and walked until our bikes became as small as a fingernail.

- The End -